Demonic Hues

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Demonic Hues

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Summary

The world of Etheria has historically been divided into mortals and immortals.
No one remembers when, but at a certain point, the peace in which both coexisted shattered…
And ever since, a new faction rose in the Fright Zone: the hunters. *Demon* hunters.
Eventually, an inquisition began, and just like all mortals seemed to have allied against demons, all immortals allied against hunters and inquisitors.
As an answer to their threat, a safe haven was established in the kingdom of Bright Moon, where all demons could hide behind the impenetrable Whispering Woods. Meanwhile, the rest of the princesses, immortals too, remained hidden in their kingdoms, fearing the day the inquisition decides to hunt down their kind too.

But can there be some mortals who *don't* fear the immortals?
Can there be hunters who turn their backs on the Fright Zone and join those they had been trained to hunt?
Can there ever be peace again?
Perhaps, all it takes is a legendary hero to appear…

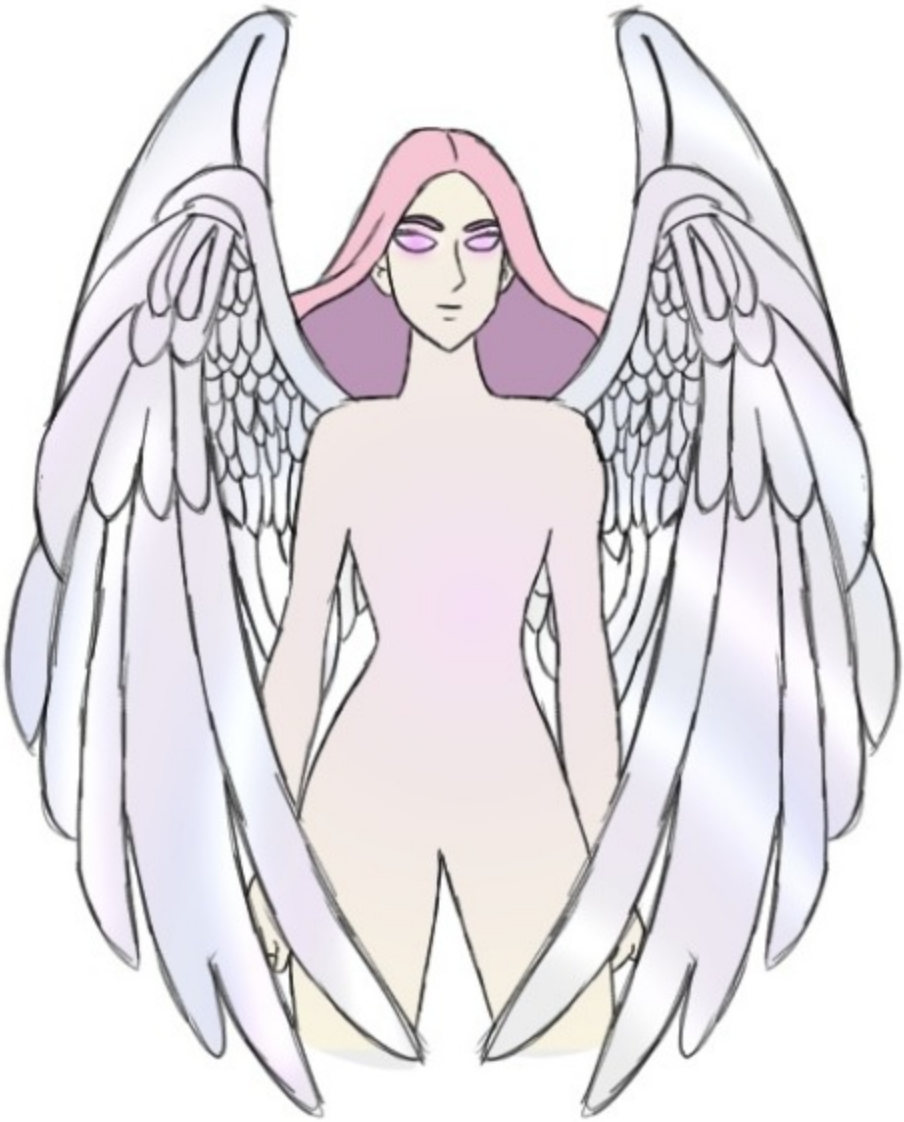


Notes

Normally I post on Wednesdays but… as this is for a Monster Mash event, let's make it a Monster Monday, alright!?

Prologue

Chapter Summary









Chapter Notes

It's already Monday rn so here we begin!!

Welcome to my Demon AU!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Prologue

The Crimson Waste.

A deserted wasteland full of deadly threats that, somehow, the people of Etheria have managed to conquer and inhabit.

A land of mortals who fear losing their home to the hands of demons…

A territory where an inquisition has been taking place for as long as they could remember.

Their fears seemed justified as, across the continent, there were kingdoms ruled by immortals, who had allied with the demons. Hence, no immortal was allowed into their land.

Yet, the hunt *solely* targeted demons…

The inquisitors had decided to strike first because they knew they stood no chance; if the territory of the Demon Hunters, the Fright Zone, weren't between the immortal's land and the Crimson Waste, they would have been taken over already.

However, the immortals could easily pose as humans and enter their lands, so it was up to the hunters and the inquisitors to identify and execute demons.

Even when other kinds of immortals are only expelled as they "pose no threat", the inquisition resulted in dozens of people being accused of being demons in disguise, and thrown into cells to await their judgement…

Were they mortals, demons, angels, or another kind?

The verdict could only be freedom, banishment, or *execution*.

—In there, *demon*!— a guard exclaimed, throwing a woman to the ground before closing the door.

Next to the guard stood a hunter, who promptly declared —Under the laws of the inquisition, you have been accused of being an immortal posing as a human, specifically a demon. Having illegally entered the Crimson Waste, endangering the population of our land, you will now await your sentence. If declared guilty of those charges, you'll be executed, following standard inquisition procedures. Do you understand what I just said, Castaspella?

—What!? I-is that all!? I don't get to defend myself!?

—Hah! As if! We cannot trust you won't use your demonic powers to twist the will of the judges— the guard spat.

—Your declaration and record will be judged; if you have a clean record you certainly have nothing to fear— the hunter explained, his neutral demeanor breaking into a mocking smile. —But you have no record at all, do you?

Without allowing her to reply, once the door was locked they both left.

Castaspella huffed in annoyance and took a look around the cell. Stone floor and walls, iron bars to her left and right instead of walls dividing the cells, a window with bars around three or four meters above ground, a poor excuse of a bed, and a latrine.

—Charming— she hissed, before noticing that the cell on her right wasn't empty. Someone was hiding in the shadows. —Who's there!?

A sinister chuckle came from the depths of the cell, and a voice replied —Wouldn't you want to know?

—That's why I asked…

—What a shame— the other person snickered.

—Why so mean? What have I done to you?

—To me? Nothing; you *don't* know me. But if you are what they accuse you to be… why would I want to introduce myself?

—Being here means that, other than the hunters and inquisitors, I might be the last person you speak to— Castaspella argued.

—I've been here for so long, I'm convinced they'll just leave me here to rot.

—But…

—Food time!— the voice of a guard outside yelled, interrupting Castaspella. —Go to the back of your cells and put your hands on the wall— he ordered.

She only rolled her eyes and obeyed; behind her, she heard the door open, the clank of a tray, and the door closing again.

—You have thirty minutes to eat— a second guard indicated.

It was then time for the other prisoner to receive the food, yet the guards didn't open the door.

Instead, one yelled —I said "Go to the back and hands on the wall"! Don't make me repeat myself, Shadow Weaver!

The tone was so despective that it made Castaspella flinch.

Yet it was evident how that… woman, apparently, had the habit of annoying everyone who interacted with her.

—Stop being so fucking difficult and *obey*! You've been here long enough to know better— the other guard reproached her.

—And what I know is that messing with you is the only entertainment I can have— she laughed.

—I see. You want to be starved, huh?

—You're not allowed to do that, no matter how much you hate me— Shadow Weaver reminded them, with a condescending tone.

—Just move back already, old hag!

After that, the woman finally stood up, surprising Castaspella with her height, and slowly made her way to the back of the cell. Once the guards saw her place her hands on the wall, one finally entered, hurriedly left the tray, and closed the door again.

—You too, thirty minutes.

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Far from the Crimson Waste, on the opposite side of the continent, the kingdom of Bright Moon rises imposingly. Ruled by the most powerful angel, it's a safe haven for all immortals.

No hunter would dare step into their territory, and so it has become the one place where demons and humans alike flee towards when chased by Fright Zone hunters.

Except for a group of daring Demon Hunters who won't hesitate to cross the Whispering Woods…

—A-are you guys sure we should be doing this?— one of them asked, clearly scared.

—Don't be a coward, Kyle— the girl to his left reproached him.

Right after, the lizard-folk walking behind them roared, and one of the leaders of the team asked her —Lonnie, what did he say?

—Rogelio thinks this is a bad idea.

—If you're all so scared, you can always return; you're a liability if you can't fight— she retorted, rolling her eyes.

—Come on, Catra. They *can* fight pretty well!— the other leader assured her.

—Adora, we're infiltrating enemy territory. We *can't* hesitate— she pointed out.

—I know! But- Re-remember what we were taught: use your instincts and prioritize survival.

—Hah! You can't be serious!— Lonnie spat. —If that's such a good teaching, then where the heck is Light Spinner *now*!? Huh!?

—She-she was just captured, right? The-the demons caught her— Kyle stammered.

—We're going to figure that out once we catch our first demon— Adora assured them.

—You really think she's still alive?— Catra asked, curious and hopeful.

—Of course!

—Then how are *we* supposed to rescue her, the so-called best hunter, if she hasn't escaped on her own?

—Face it, Adora. She's dead— Lonnie harshly stated.

—I refuse to believe that. We're capturing a demon, and we're- Ah! Wha-what was that!?

The group halted and looked around, standing in a circle, so each other covered their backs. They kept silent for a moment, waiting for whatever Adora had heard, but everything was silent.

—Nothing on this side— Catra reported with seriousness.

—Idem.

—Idem.

—Idem.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Adora all replied one after the other.

Rogelio was about to roar meaning the same, yet something caught his eye and, instead, he readied his weapon.

—What is it?— Adora asked, not daring to turn and leave her back unprotected.

As he growled lowly, Lonnie translated —There's someone between the trees.

—Advance carefully, don't break the formation— Catra ordered.

The five of them began moving towards whatever Rogelio had seen, treading between the twisted trees of the Whispering Woods, until they arrived at a clear.

As he roared again, Kyle translated —He didn't see someone. Was it that?

This time, they all turned to look at a shining sword stuck on the ground and surrounded by vines.

One second of distraction, and only Catra noticed in time the net that had been shot at them.

—Adora!— she yelped, managing to push her out of the way before all four of them got trapped.

—Guys!

She tried to stand up to help them, but a bright pink light appeared on her left, and she could barely cover her face before being punched with inhuman strength.

—Take that!

Adora got pushed a few meters away, losing her weapon and landing on the vines surrounding the bright sword.

—Shit! Adora!— Catra yelled, trying to cut the net with her claws.

—Keep trying all you want, hunter. That one is *very* sturdy; not even a demon can cut through it— a human boy proudly said.

—Ugh…— Adora groaned, managing to open her eyes. Her first instinct was to reach for her weapon, but she soon realized it wasn't on her, and looked up in shock. —What!?

She knew she had been hit, but she wasn't expecting to see such a petite immortal in front of her.

—These are the hunters!? It was so easy! I told you we could go against them, Bow!

—Yeah, yeah… But if your mother learns about this, we're done for, Glim— he pointed out.

—Not if we hand them in— she smirked, cracking her knuckles, looking ready to knock out Adora.

But she wasn't paying attention anymore. As soon as she heard "Glim", all the pieces fell into place.

A pair of horns and a pair of wings, bright pink powers…

This was Princess Glimmer, a halfling, and potentially the most powerful creature ever to exist.

Adora's first instinct was to flee, but she couldn't leave her team there. So she had to find a way to fight back.

But how!?

Her weapon was out of reach…

As panic overtook her, a single thought appeared in her mind.

The sword behind her.

But she ignored that thought.

Unable to think straight, just following her training, she tried to get up pushing the ground with both hands, which called Bow's attention.

—She's trying to escape!— he warned, startling Adora who fell to the ground again.

—On it!— the princess yelled, propelling herself with a flap of her wings and readying a punch. With a smug expression, she let out —Lights out.

But Adora's instincts were sharper than anticipated, and she had been taught to follow them, so her reflexes easily kicked in.

Her hands reached behind her, closed around the hilt of the sword and, the moment Glimmer's punch was about to connect, she managed to pull it out.

A dazzling light blinded them all.

When the princess recovered her sight, she saw a sturdy shield had stopped her fist.

Behind it, instead of the mortal hunter she intended to knock out, there was a tall and muscular blonde who looked like a godly warrior.

—What?— Bow sighed, stunned for a second like the team of hunters under his net. —Glimmer!— he then exclaimed, shooting an arrow.

—Fuck!— the princess yelped, barely dodging the warrior's hand trying to catch her.

Taking advantage of the smoke arrows Bow had shot, she flew high enough to keep herself out of reach.

However, the shield turned back into a sword and slashed through the air where Glimmer was hovering just a moment before. As she tried to fly higher, it turned into a rope that the warrior flung like a whip to catch the princess' ankle.

Hearing her yelp, Bow used up all his arrows, frenetically trying to stop her and free Glimmer… to no avail.

Once he ran out of arrows, he began to panic.

He had to do *something*.

He soon got an idea, but it was so crazy; he didn't stand a chance…

Yet, as he gathered the courage to attack the warrior with his bare hands, he felt a couple of hands tightly gripping his legs to keep him in place.

Catra, Rogelio, Lonnie, and Kyle had managed to stick their arms out through the holes of the net.

—Let go!— he exclaimed, reaching down to get rid of them. Desperate, his sight bounced between his legs and Glimmer, who was slowly being dragged back to the ground. —No, no!

—Ah! Stop!— she yelled, struggling to break free.

Just three more pulls and the warrior would have her within reach.

Bow was still trapped and could only yell, on the brink of tears, wishing he wasn't just a mortal…

Two more pulls and the princess would be done for.

She screamed louder, genuinely scared for the first time in her life, regretting having ignored her mother.

One more pull.

In a last, desperate attempt, Glimmer shot a pair of pink beams from her hands, yet the warrior deflected them with the golden arm cuffs she wore.

And so, she reached out and gripped the princess' ankle.

Yet only for a second before being blasted away by an unknown force.

—Adora!— Catra immediately yelled, seeing the warrior return to the hunter's original appearance.

—That was close— Bow sighed, falling to his knees in relief.

—Who do we have here?— a male voice asked, with a curious tone.

—Oh, oh…— Bow muttered.

—I-I can explain…— Glimmer began.

—I'm all ears— the demon said, once he reached the center of the clearing.

While the princess fumbled with her words, the hunters under the net remained speechless as they stared at the purple-skinned bearded demon. Once out of their shock, they exchanged panicked glances and looked back at Adora, ignoring the blood dripping from her forehead, just hoping she'd soon wake up…

Chapter End Notes

That was all for today
Next week, Act 1 begins!

See you then!! And thank you for reading :D

Act 1

Chapter Summary











Act 1

Of what happened in prison

Chapter 1

Chapter Summary

Some hours later…

Chapter Notes

Welcome back! I have an important clarification I hope you guys read before the chapter, just in case.
This is an M-rated fic, alright? So there are some scenes that might be uncomfortable, like one in this chapter. I'll explain what it is about in case any of you wanna be sure it'll be okay for you to read it.

▶ Minor and necessary spoiler of the aforementioned scene:

Again, this is M-rated, nothing too serious will happen, but even I feel uncomfortable rereading that scene, so I thought it'd best to warn you about it.

That'd be all. You can now proceed to reading ^_^ Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 1

—Well? It’s been a few hours… Are you going to tell me what the heck your name is!?— Castaspella inquired, quite annoyed.

—Remind me, why should I?

—What else should I call you? “Shadow Weaver” like the guards do?

—Why not?

—It’s such a lame name…

—How charming of you— the woman sarcastically replied, rolling her eyes. —And here I thought I was the wicked one…

—Ah, so you don’t like it when I talk like you, right?— Castaspella pointed out. —Look, I’m usually respectful and nice even to strangers… But it’s proving highly difficult with you because you keep making fun of me!

—As I said before, you're here accused of being a demon, so I have no reason to introduce myself. Besides, being a former hunter, I should be far meaner— Shadow Weaver condescendingly said.

—You were a hunter? Wh-why are you here then!?

—Same as you, of course. But it's far more difficult to prove or refute whether I'm a demon or not…

—Why?

—Apparently, things have *morphed* since my time as a hunter. The change in administration delayed my process— she dismissively explained.

—Yes, the new inquisitors are… very strict— Castaspella agreed. —I was accused because I have no records to be checked. Nothing to prove whether I'm mortal or immortal.

—So that's what that hunter meant…

—Yes.

—What else can you tell me about how things have been the past year?— Shadow Weaver asked, interested.

—Will this be a fair exchange?

—Sure… I can give you insight into this new life— she smirked.

—What about a name?

—We'll see about that.

—Ugh… Alright— Castaspella had to accept. —Let's see. For starters, inquisitors and hunters have signed some sort of agreement about eight, perhaps ten months ago— she began. —It stipulates that hunters can hurt demons, even suspects, in any way, as long as they don't kill them. While still quite cruel, at least it has kept innocents from being killed on sight.

—How interesting. It seems they apply the same here because guards can hurt us if they see fit, but never kill us, even indirectly. That's why they can't starve us— Shadow Weaver explained in return.

—That's good to know— she sighed. —Hmm, what else… Oh, right. Inquisitors have become leaders of sorts. Their word is law now.

—Why?

—They insist that only by obeying them can people stay safe, and everyone is so scared of demons that they were accepted as regents— she replied.

—How ridiculous— the older woman spat. —So that's where the guards got the idea. Except that they only have as much power as we allow them to have— she clarified. —I don't resist because it's amusing. Or, at least, not *just* because of that— she added. —I do so to remind them they are *not* the authorities they believe themselves to be.

—I see— Castaspella sighed again, obviously relieved. —Well… I don't have much else to- Oh, I know! There's this prominent hunter that has disappeared, and now the Fright Zone is less willing to lend their help to the inquisition— she recalled. —Her name was… Light Spinner? I think? That has been the talk of the town *everywhere*. I heard that, after she vanished, many demons appeared dead without any hunter taking responsibility. I think that's also why the agreement was signed— she further explained. —Basically, the Fright Zone lost its best hunter, and now they don't want to send untrained people to deal with what, probably, killed Light Spinner.

—Alright. That's enough— Shadow Weaver interrupted her. —You wanted to know my name? So be it: you can call me "Beatrix". Just never pronounce the name "Light Spinner" ever again.

—Wha-what? How's that related?

—Because *I* used to be Light Spinner— she finally admitted. —And yet, I am now waiting for a verdict, but as Shadow Weaver. The highest ranks of hunters have deemed me a traitor, while the squad I trained remains oblivious— she went on. —The inquisitors are having issues with my case *because* I have no record as Shadow Weaver, and my identity as Light Spinner is a secret the hunters will take to their graves.

—Ho-how!?

—"How" isn't as important as "why"…

—Then *why*!?

—Because they were scared of me, and my methods…

—I can't even imagine what you mean.

—All those dead demons? My doing— she proudly told her.

Something inside Castaspella twisted in disgust, and yet, she showed no signs of it.

—I see…

—Now, it's almost time for dinner. I suggest we don't discuss important matters while they are around— Shadow Weaver pointed out.

—Of course.

—So… Why don't you tell me a bit about you? It's only fair… You know enough about me, don't you?

—Right— Castaspella huffed. —But I don't know what I could tell you— she admitted.

—Let's start with your name. It sounds fake.

—What about it sounds fake!?— she inquired, offended.

—Seriously? "Cast a spell" with an added "a"? Prison hasn't consumed my brain just yet…

—Fine. No, that's not my real name. But I don't think it will serve any purpose to tell you my real one. After all, I'm not as renowned as you— she explained.

—Hah! So I give you information in exchange for nothing!?

—I gave you plenty of info! Giving me your name doesn't count because you told me that out of your own volition… and because I annoyed you, it seems…

—You're far wittier than I thought— Shadow Weaver let out, tilting her head, curious. —Here I believed you were a little fool with bad luck…

—Did you just compliment me and insult me immediately after?

—What if I did?

—You're a bitch.

—You've seen nothing. I can be *far* more annoying than this— she smirked.

—Well, we will probably have a lot of time to find out if that's true— Castaspella replied, rolling her eyes and folding her arms.

Before the older woman could say anything else, they heard —Dinner time! Get to the back of your cells!

—There they are…

—To the back, Shadow Weaver— a guard threatened.

—Lest you want to eat from the ground— the other added, pretending he was going to throw the tray to the ground.

—I dare you— she spat.

—Stop!— Castaspella yelled, right before the guard could let the food fall.

—How cute. You think we'd listen to you— the first guard mocked her.

—No, of course not. Just… don't waste the food…— she pleaded.

—Hah… look at that. She's begging.

—Someone understands her place. Do you want extra food? Is it that?

The guards laughed wickedly and seemed to have the same idea simultaneously.

—Let's do something— one offered. —He will also give you her food tray if you undress for us.

—Wha-what!?

—It's a good deal. You don't have to do anything else. Take off your clothes and we'll give you all the food…

—I…— she hesitated. —Only if none of you touch me— she negotiated, swallowing hard.

They looked at each other, brow raised as if silently debating between them, and finally said —Sure…

Castaspella closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and trembled as she began removing her attire, layer by layer. The older woman could only stare in shock, inevitably thinking back to some disgusting things she had had to do, and increasingly desperate to stop her.

—What the *fuck* are you doing!?— Shadow Weaver hissed.

—Silence!— the guard with her tray exclaimed, never looking away from Castaspella.

After all her clothes were off, the guards eyed her with satisfaction while she trembled, looking away.

—Alright, give her the food. Otherwise, they'll come looking for us— the other guard ordered. —Congratulations— he mocked her.

She looked so scared, gulping nervously and shivering, that they didn't even make her stand at the back and look at the wall, as per the protocol. They opened the cell, left one tray after the other on the floor, and closed it again.

Finally, they left cackling and Castaspella rushed to put on at least the first layer of clothes.

Once dressed, she dropped to her knees, supporting herself with both hands on the ground, and took a deep breath while letting out a wail, seemingly about to cry.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver was barely out of her shock and had to make a great effort to hide her anxiousness, feeling her heartbeat shaking her whole body.

—Did I or did I not say you must *not* give them power over you!?

—Shut up…— she breathed out, staring at the floor.

—What?

—Shut up!

—Can’t stand it when I tell you that you’re being too submissive?— the woman defied her, masking her worry.

—It’s not that. Just… shut up a second— she insisted, closing her eyes tightly as she gasped for air.

—Stars…— the older woman muttered.

After a moment, Castaspella seemed to have recovered enough to reach for the trays. Without a word, she slid one of them towards the bars between her and Shadow Weaver.

—Now eat before they come back…

—What?— she asked, her tone surprised and somewhat soft.

—They can’t starve you, but they can make you starve yourself— Castaspella pointed out.

—And you… did that just to… help me?

—Yeah…

—Why!?

—I don’t know— she admitted, seemingly on the brink of tears. —I just… can’t stand how cruel they are— she hesitantly replied.

—What a fool— Shadow Weaver laughed, reaching for the food with ease as there was enough space between each bar. After a moment of silently staring at the loaf of stale bread she was holding, she finally said —Thank you.

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The hunters under Bow’s net refused to cooperate, so the demon who showed up out of nowhere decided to drag them back inside the net while carrying an unconscious Adora over his shoulder.

Soon, they were at Bright Moon’s palace, and a pair of angel guards in their immortal forms received them, mentioning the Queen was expecting them.

—Mom!

—No more excuses, Glimmer— her mother sternly said. —I had given you an order. What would have happened if either you or Bow were hurt? What would have happened if your father hadn’t arrived in time!?

—But we had it under control!— she argued, so angry she was still in her immortal form. —I-it was that warrior! When she appeared, I-I was blinded and then there was a shield! It was a sword before, and that hunter somehow pulled it out, transformed into that warrior, and…

—Warrior? Sword?

—Here, I gave it to the guards— she said, fetching it from an angel on standby near the door to her room.

—And you say one of the hunters pulled it out?— the Queen asked, seemingly recognizing it.

—Yes. I heard her name is Adora— she replied.

—To the throne room. Bring her to me— she ordered.

—Ye-yes, mom— Glimmer hesitated.

After a few hours, Adora finally woke up. She couldn't recognize where she was, but she felt safe resting on Catra's lap, who was holding her protectively.

—Wha-what… happened?— she managed to ask, before even being able to open her eyes.

—You're awake!— Kyle noticed.

—Yes, but keep it low— Catra calmed him.

—Well, to answer your question, you transformed into some… super tall, super powerful, and super scary warrior— Lonnie explained, quietly. —Then you almost crushed the princess, you know, the halfling that attacked us, but…

—A demon showed up— Catra went on. —He… knocked you out so hard that you transformed back and have been unconscious until now. Your head was bleeding, so it's bandaged.

—The… immortals healed me?

—Yeah. For some reason…

—Who was that demon?

—That was the fucking *King*!— Lonnie replied, indignant but without raising her voice.

—I'm sorry, what!?— Adora asked again, suddenly more awake and trying to push herself up.

—Hey, hey, where are you going!?

—I have to…

Adora's words died in her mouth as a short, pink-haired girl, who looked very familiar, appeared outside the cell, looking through the bars.

—Great. You're awake— she noticed, addressing Adora. —The blonde— she ordered the guards.

—Wait! Where are you taking her!?— Catra exclaimed, trying and failing to keep the angel guards from taking her away.

—Not your business, *hunter*— the girl replied.

—Princess, she's resisting— one of the guards said, after they closed the door to the cell. —What do we do?

—Keep holding her!? She's not that strong…

—Wa-wait! "Princess"!?— Adora exclaimed. —Yo-you're the halfling!?

Glimmer smirked sardonically.

—Don't tell me the lack of horns or wings confused you that much…

—Adora!— Catra called from the cell, but she could hardly hear her as the angel guards took her upstairs.

—What the fuck do we do now!?— Lonnie exclaimed, no longer minding her tone. —Even if we found a way to escape, they have Adora now!

From the back of the cell, sitting against the wall, Rogelio let out a roar, and Kyle agreed —Right! We-we just have to wait until they bring her back. We can search for ways to escape in the meantime!

—And how do we know if they will bring her back!? We don't know why they took her! Or where!

—This mission was a mistake— Lonnie scoffed. —I don't even know why we did this in the first place. Light Spinner abandoned us!

—No! No…— Catra denied, hesitant as a part of her feared it was true. —She wouldn't… Why-why would she?

—Because she doesn't care about us?

—No! She always said we were her best trainees!

—We were her *only* trainees, Catra…

—No, no! Shut up!— she angrily replied. —I- She- Ugh!

—Hey, calm down…— Lonnie gently said, having realized how sensitive the matter is for her. —I… I'm sorry, alright? I-I'm sure she…cares for you and Adora… at least— she tentatively assured her, looking away, ashamed of lying to her so blatantly.

—If she's alive like Adora believes, then I'll find her. And I'll prove to her that I can do this!— she sentenced, determined. —So I'm not waiting for her to be brought back while doing nothing. Kyle is right. We'll look for a way out of here until she's back!

—Do it.

—No!

—It's an order!

—I can't do it! I can't command it!— Adora insisted, on the brink of tears, forcing herself not to flinch under the Queen's scrutinizing gaze. She was holding that sword from the woods, she wasn't tied or anything; she was armed and could move freely. Yet she felt at her mercy. —I don't know what I did or how!

—Then we'll make it happen— Angella decided. —Guards!

At her command, three guards standing near the door transformed into their immortal forms, their angelic forms, and charged towards the hunter.

But Adora didn't scream. She didn't feel scared.

She had been trained for this.

Standing her ground until they were close enough, she held the sword tightly with both hands while frowning at them, showing she was *not* intimidated in the least. When they were within reach, Adora jumped to the side, rolled over her shoulder, and pushed herself up, taking advantage of the momentum to bolt forward.

The door was unguarded.

It was her chance.

Yet, as she sprinted towards it, something shot past her, like a beam of light, and she fell back a meter before the door.

—Fuck— Adora muttered, gritting her teeth.

Queen Angella was standing before her, flapping her wings menacingly, and in her *real* immortal form. She looked so similar yet so different…

The hunter thought she was an angel wearing clothes over her immortal form; she never would have imagined the Queen could look even more ethereal.

Opalescent skin, larger feathery wings, shiny eyes…

She looked far more powerful, threatening, and dangerous.

—Seize her!

Adora didn’t even resist as the guards held her up and took the sword from her. She knew just how perilous the situation was and how much she had fucked up. Unless she complied, she’d never see her friends again.

She’d never see Catra again.

Angella hadn’t given the order to take her back to the cell, but it seemed the guards understood they had to. They slowly escorted her back the way they came, right as a bulky, bearded man, who looked really familiar too, walked into the throne room.

—What happened?— he asked, curious.

—She’s clearly *not* who Glimmer said— Angella replied, looking away.

—Yes, she is— he laughed. —Trust me, I had to use my full power to knock her out before she could hurt our baby— he assured her.

Upon hearing that, Adora immediately perked up and exclaimed —That’s the King!?

That human man, who looked pretty much ordinary, was the powerful demon her friends had mentioned!?

The hunter struggled against the guards' grasp yet couldn’t possibly make them let go of her, and absolutely no one minded Adora’s surprise. If anyone in the throne room heard her, they weren’t showing it.

—Unless I actually see her transform, I can hardly believe she’s the legendary warrior— Angella insisted. —What do you propose?

—A trial. Make her *need* to repeat what she did in the Woods.

—I *just* attempted that, and she almost escaped— she pointed out, as he approached.

—Angie, this is hardly the place for that.

As he took her hands between his, the Queen let out a sigh to calm down.

—You’re right. I was careless…

Finally arriving at the cell, the guards threw Adora inside, smirking, and then returned to their mortal appearances as they left.

The hunter was still in shock. She couldn’t understand how the Queen could be both an angel and an angelic being. It felt redundant yet scary. The Queen was powerful in either form, which meant the Princess had to be quite strong too, even if, apparently, she was half-human.

Right?

Half-angelic being, half-human, while also half-angel, half-demon…

Behind her, the rest of the group observed with worry as the girl stared into the distance, unmoving and speechless.

—Adora?— Catra eventually called.

—What?— she replied, confused as she looked back.

—A-are you alright!? Have they done something to you!?

—I'm fine, Catra. Don't worry. They just… wanted me to transform. And I couldn't— she explained, standing up and dusting her clothes. —I don't know why, but the Queen wanted me to transform, had some guards attack me… I almost escaped and she- Did you know the Queen is an angelic being *and* an angel!?

—I- Well, yes. Light Spinner mentioned it before— Lonnie replied.

—Dor, are you sure you're okay? Did they hit you?— Catra insisted, approaching to check on her. —Maybe you have a concussion or something…

—No! My head is fine!— Adora laughed.

Rogelio roared in concern at the back, and Kyle nodded before telling them —We couldn't find a way to get out of this cell. Did you see some way out when you were taken?

—Not much, but… Well, everything seems too open, so to speak— Adora began, thoughtful. —It feels like nothing is well guarded, but all the guards seem to be immortals, so it's tricky — she admitted. —We'll find a way out of here, though. Don't worry, guys.

As the night progresses, dinner is being served upstairs for the royal family. However, the King stays outside on the balcony, gazing at the horizon.

—May I?— Angella's voice asked from behind him, gentle.

—Of course— he nodded, without looking back.

As the Queen settled next to him, he let out a deep sigh, and she placed a hand on his shoulder.

—What's on your mind, my Love?

—Casta isn't back yet…

—She usually takes a long time to return, remember?

—I know, but… she hasn't sent us any letters or messages, or anything!

—It could be for any number of reasons, Dear— the Queen insisted. —Be patient and have some faith in her.

—Angie, she *doesn't* have the powers *I* have! She's still my little sister! I can't just wait here doing nothing!

—Last time you got like this and interfered, you almost ruined her undercover mission, remember? And this is just a scout mission, she's probably… I don't know… hiding or something— Angella suggested. —So, you're right. She isn't like you, but she isn't any less capable regardless…

—I know— he sighed.

—Come on, now. Let's have dinner, my Love.

Chapter End Notes

So, what do you think so far!?

Sorry for the *strong* scene before… There will be more, unfortunately, but all necessary, I swear. I will also warn about them when the time comes, alright?

Anyways! Any more theories!? I'd love to hear them :D

See you next Monday (or Wednesday if you read my other stuff) and thanks for reading!!!

Chapter 2

Chapter Summary

About ten days later…

Chapter Notes

Remember the "I can be more annoying" from SW and "We'll see" from Casta?

Guess what!? XD

Anyways, no specific warning this time, just know there's like… general sexual ~~innuendo~~ kinda explicit discussion in all the first half.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 2

—How can you possibly get more annoying with each passing day!?

The woman, Shadow Weaver, *Beatrix*, only smirked sardonically. Castaspella had been bearing all kinds of jokes, complaints, mockery, and gloating from her.

—You can always look away, you know?— she pointed out, not without some malice.

—Looking away makes no difference when you're so *loud*! I'm pretty sure the guards can hear you…

—Perhaps, but since they find me hideous, they probably feel more uncomfortable than anything, which works perfectly well for me.

—You've been doing this for how long, again?

—This? Just a few months… Keeps you *sane*. You should try it— Shadow Weaver suggested.

—I am not… I-I am not going to touch myself in front of you! Especially not right after breakfast!

—Any time is a good time…

Castaspella felt insane just from this interaction alone.

—A-and what if the guards show up!? I still shiver just thinking about how they saw me naked…

—I can always warn you if they are approaching— the older woman offered. —My hearing is far more sensitive than that of a human.

—Why would you do that for me?— she inquired, confused.

—You were so foolish on your very first night here… And for a complete stranger, no less.

—But…

—I refuse to be indebted to you, so I plan on repaying you in any way, as fast as I can— she interrupted her.

—Well then, uh... thank you for the offer, but… I simply don't do that— Castaspella admitted, shaking her head.

—Any reason in particular? Or do you just find it disgusting?

—I- No, well. I don't find it disgusting or anything, even if it's a bit uncomfortable to have to watch and hear you do it— she replied, rolling her eyes at the end. —My problem is… *different*.

—Anything I can help with?

—To repay me?— she asked, scoffing in amusement. —I suppose, but I wouldn't ask that from you. You'd most likely refuse, and I don't think it's possible even— Castaspella argued.

—Try me— Shadow Weaver defied her.

—Alright— she sighed. —I just… I can't touch myself because I don't- It doesn't arouse me, but rather the opposite.

—I see— the woman replied, more serious than expected. Then, she seemed to have an idea and pointed out —That would mean you probably need some… *external* help.

—You don't have to do it if you don't want to; "repaying me" is hardly worth it. And I don't see how you'd be able to, anyways.

Shadow Weaver certainly didn't expect that much consideration from her, but that only convinced her even more.

—May I remind you that there's enough space between the bars separating our cells?— Shadow Weaver smirked. —So, if you feel like it… come closer, kneel, and hold on to the bars— she offered, her tone more high-pitched and mischievous.

She hesitated, unsure at first yet so tempted that she considered it.

But then again… she still feared the guards showing up.

—No, but… thanks for the offer again.

—Your loss— the older woman replied.

By lunchtime, they were once again discussing hunters while eating, and a new round of gloating about her skills began.

—You're insufferable, Beatrix— Castaspella hissed.

—You asked about my time as a hunter, and I am honestly replying— she argued.

—No! You're just bragging!

—I was the best hunter the Fright Zone had, you said it yourself on the first day. Remember? There will never be a better one, and that's *a fact*— she insisted.

—Why do you take so much pride in being a murderer!?

—I don't— Shadow Weaver admitted, looking away. —I take pride in my job and my efficiency— she clarified. —I only did what had to be done. I didn't *enjoy* killing them, yet I believe they all deserved it.

—I don't understand what the demons have ever done to any of you— Castaspella huffed. —I don't- I can't comprehend the fear of immortals.

—You don't fear them?

—I have nothing to fear— the woman assured her. —Each minds their business.

—Do you have any idea how many hunters have been killed by demons?

—The same can be said about those half-demons executed by the inquisitors, and the full demons *you* killed, of course— Castaspella retorted. —Besides, how do you expect them to react if they are being actively hunted down?

—I must insist: they deserved it. Every single demon I've killed was far more wicked than me— Shadow Weaver assured her. —Specially the first one— she added, looking away again.

—So you hunt them because of what has been done to you?

—I used to live with immortals, yes. Their treachery made me actually change sides— she replied, squinting.

—How long ago? And what do you mean by "actually change sides"?

—I lived with immortals until twenty-five, perhaps thirty years ago. When I left, it was to join the hunters and pass information back to the kingdom of Bright Moon— she explained. —I would occasionally return to report to my immediate superior, the only one allowed to see me, and my only connection with the Queen, to keep my identity hidden.

—So your superior was a demon?— Castaspella asked. When she nodded, she further questioned her —And that demon betrayed you.

—I won't disclose more details, but yes. And it happened about a year and a half ago, when I "disappeared".

—I see…— the woman let out, pensive. After a moment of reflection, she argued —One demon shouldn't determine your view of all demons, though…

—As I said, every demon I killed was nothing but a wicked piece of shit— Shadow Weaver repeated, annoyed. —I won't tell you to hate immortals too, but just as you argue that they only defend themselves, so do I!

—I get it— Castaspella replied, slightly raising her hands in surrender.

They finally fell silent after that and promptly finished their meals before the guards arrived.

Afterwards, both were feeling tired and decided to take a nap, which lasted until dinner time. The yelling of the guards woke them up, and the older woman felt so groggy she didn't do her usual number.

Confused by her compliance, the guards mocked them until they left, and once again when they returned half an hour later.

—Look at you both, so tame— one said.

—Gives me so many ideas…— the other commented. —A shame we only have a few minutes— he added, smirking in a way that made Castaspella shiver.

—Alright, time to sleep. Lights out.

Both guards promptly left with the trays after turning off the lights, and only the moonlight coming through the window made their figures just visible enough.

—Beatrix?

—What is it?

Castaspella let out a long sigh before saying —Can I take you up on that offer now?

—What offer?

Instead of replying, the woman approached the bars between the cells and knelt.

—You're right, I'm already losing it— she admitted.

With a faint laugh, Shadow Weaver slowly reached for the bars and knelt too, mocking her — You're clearly not made for prison…

—Yes, yes. Whatever…

—What a bad mood— she noticed. —No wonder you need this— she remarked. Then, with a smirk, she added —You might want to hold on tight.

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After a few days, the five hunters had attempted to escape so many times that they were already running out of ideas.

—We're seriously doomed here. We're no match for the immortals and this cell is probably designed for them, not for mere mortals— Lonnie sighed, shaking her head. —And, turns out, the only one who could fight them is that warrior-form Adora turned into, but she doesn't know how to activate it! And, still, they have the sword so it doesn't matter…

Hearing that, Rogelio roared and Kyle nodded in agreement.

—We're still safe and sound, at least.

—Way to be optimistic— Catra scoffed, noticeably low-spirited.

—They are right, though— Adora supported them. —We shouldn't give up yet.

—And what are we supposed to do, Dor?

—Perhaps we can negotiate with the Queen.

—Why would the Queen listen to us?— Lonnie questioned her. —We might be fed and all, but it's not like they care about us…

—But what if they do? We're being given *good* food, no one has tried to torture us for information or anything, and we heard the guards say the Queen ordered them to keep us safe.

—What if they only do that to make us lower our guard?— Catra countered. —Remember what Light Spinner said: anyone outside our team is a potential threat. Even other hunters. If we mustn't lower our guard around other hunters like us, then much less when surrounded by immortals in their own territory!

—Yeah, but she also said that we must know our enemy, never strike first, and prioritize our safety— Adora reminded her. —We know nothing about them, and we're safe. After I tried to escape the first day, I realized that, if the Queen wanted us dead or gone, she would have already done so. So we can't give her a reason to do that; we *shouldn't* strike first.

—I know…

—Sometimes I wonder why she'd teach us that— Lonnie admitted. —It's the opposite of what other teams are taught.

—Yeah, she was… stern, and severe, kind of… cruel sometimes. But her teachings were actually pretty nice!— Kyle commented. After Rogelio roared a couple of times, he translated. —That too. The other hunters always returned beaten up, some barely alive. Which means that what they are taught isn't that useful.

—And every time we saw that, she'd always remind us we have to live as if there were no tomorrow—Catra recalled. Then, exchanging a glance with Adora, she began commenting — That wasn't reassuring but…

—But, if it weren't for that, I wouldn't have dared to confess my love— she finished, chuckling slightly.

—Oh, I remember that day— Lonnie laughed. —She was so *irked*! But, you were only following her advice, and I swear you could see her swallowing her pride. Funniest shit ever!

After a while of reminiscing, they were served dinner and decided to sleep right after. They had some flat mattresses, quite similar to the ones they had at the headquarters, yet only used two.

On the right side of the cell, Adora and Catra cuddled each other and promptly fell asleep, comfortable between each other's arms. Meanwhile, on the left side, Rogelio curled up around Kyle and Lonnie, rumbling lowly in a way that always helped them both fall asleep too.

At the same time, a few storeys higher, Bow sneaked through empty, barely lit corridors, careful not to make a sound, until he reached a beautifully decorated door. With a cautious, special knock that sounded a bit like a melody, he announced himself before opening.

Glimmer laughed contentedly as she rushed to hug him and, once the door was closed and locked, she threw her arms around his neck to kiss him deeply.

—Took you long enough— she light-heartedly complained. —I almost fell asleep…

—Sorry. My dads had some issues with dinner, and we ate too late— he apologized.

—Well, you're here now— she smiled.

—Listen, Glim. I think you are being a bit reckless lately… First, that hunter almost got you, and now you keep trying to patrol alone…

—I know, but… I can't stay here doing nothing— she complained. —I mean, if we hadn't sneaked out that day, those hunters would have crossed the Woods and found us! I know that warrior could have killed me, but she came out of nowhere! We were winning!

—If your father hadn't shown up…

—I *know*! But Dad has more training. I'm sure that, if he taught me, I could have bested her too— she huffed, with an annoyed frown that Bow found endearing.

—Then we should talk to the King and get official permission, don't you think?

—But Mom will never agree.

—What if she does? You're not a child anymore and have become the most powerful halfling out there. We just have to show her how capable you are.

Glimmer sighed, looked away, and said —You can be so sweet sometimes—. Smiling softly, she pulled him in for another kiss, and finally asked —Shall we?

Snickering together, Bow held her up and took the Princess to her bed while kissing her more, both itching to undress each other…

As midnight approached, King Micah entered his wife's study, where she had locked herself in since finishing her dinner.

—Angie?

—Yes?— she replied, her voice tired.

—Don't you think it's enough for today?

—I still can't find anything. And it's been ten days— she complained, closing her eyes and letting out a long sigh.

—Which is why I think you should rest— he insisted, placing his hands on her shoulders as he stood behind her. —You have been at this every night since we captured those hunters…

—I want to figure this out as soon as possible— she let out, resting her head back on his chest.

—I'm sure you will, but not if you wear yourself out— he pointed out.

—I know— she sighed again. —Alright, I'll… end for the night, then— she accepted. —If only I could remember more about the legend of She-Ra…

Chapter End Notes

It's midnight and I'm going to sleep right now, I'm super drowsy… But I hope you enjoyed the chapter!!

See you soon and thank you for reading! (^_^)/

Chapter 3

Chapter Summary

Two weeks later…

Chapter Notes

Another chapter with a warning, guys!
But first, welcome back! I hope you're enjoying the story!
This is the last chapter of Act 1, so the events taking place in the prison(s) will finally end. Does it mean freedom? Or does it mean death?
You'll soon find out!

Now, the warning, for violence this time:

▶ Brief and necessary spoiler:

So, it's really not that bad, it's more of a very brief mention. But I rather warn…

Now yes, please, by all means, be my guest! ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 3

As two more weeks pass, it’s about to be a month when Castaspella’s sentence is finally announced.

She was *found guilty*.

In a week, she’d be executed as per the inquisition protocols…

—It’s impossible! It hasn’t been a month yet! How have they passed sentence so fast!?— Shadow Weaver exclaimed, demanding answers.

But the hunter who delivered the news didn’t pay attention to her.

Instead, she asked —Have you understood what I said, Castaspella?

—Yes, I have— she replied, looking down yet speaking with a firm voice. —May I ask based on what, exactly?

—You may not.

With that, the hunter turned to leave, but before she had so much as taken two steps, Shadow Weaver yelled —How low have the hunters fallen to follow inquisitors' commands blindly!? You don't even *know* the answer to her question, do you!?

The woman stopped in her tracks for a moment, gave one of the guards a look, he nodded, and she finally left. Right after, the guards went to open the older woman's cell, walked in, and Castaspella could only watch as they beat her up.

—Stop!— she screamed, pressed against the bars between the cells, her arms extended, trying to reach them. —Stop! Please!

Neither woman could do anything, and the guards knew it. If they were ordinary humans, they had no power to oppose them. If they were really demons, they wouldn't risk revealing themselves by using their powers against them.

They would do *nothing*.

Castaspella cried out louder, begging them to stop while tears fell down her cheeks, and Shadow Weaver remained curled up, protecting her face and stomach from the kicks of the guards.

Fortunately, they soon stopped, seemingly tired and groaning from aching all over. They had to stop as their muscles hurt terribly, and decided to leave the cell considering she had probably had enough…

—Fuck— the older woman uttered, noticing blood on her hands. They had managed to hit her nose. Her ribs also hurt awfully, as well as her legs and thighs. —Could be worse— she told herself.

But Castaspella disagreed.

—Beatrix— she called, still sobbing. —Why did you do it!?

Dragging herself through the floor, closer to the bars, she explained —That hunter… she, and who knows how many more, betrays the very core of what it means to be a hunter…

—Ho-how!?

—She… is supposed to look after mortals— Shadow Weaver began. —Knowing why someone… is sentenced, it's part of our duty, to make sure no mortal is… wrongfully killed.

—But you shouldn't have said that— Castaspella lamented. —It wasn't worth it— she sobbed, reaching for the woman's face. —I accept my fate, I don't really care about why they found me guilty.

—Then you're a fool— she replied, looking up at her. Noticing her weeping, she reached for the woman's face too, and brushed her thumb over her right cheek to dray it off. —I'm not worth your tears either…

For some reason, seeing her cry made Shadow Weaver come to a realization she didn't want to contemplate. But it was difficult to ignore, especially since Castaspella put so much effort into helping her up despite the bars interfering with her movement.

Eventually, she was sitting against the bars, nose clean after the young woman used her own clothes to wipe off the blood from it.

—It's like you have a death wish or something— Castaspella joked, trying to hide her sadness and concern. —At least I have one more week…

—Then we plan your escape— Shadow Weaver severely stated.

—There's no point. And I don't think you should risk yourself any further.

—It's not like you can stop me— she reminded her.

—Right…

—Why are you so resigned?

—I know the inquisitors well enough, I guess.

—This wasn't the first time they imprisoned you, right?

—Indeed…

—Why wouldn't you tell me?

—I liked hearing you give me tips and all— Castaspella giggled.

And that giggle…

Shadow Weaver was slowly losing her grip.

She absolutely did *not* want to explore that feeling but, at the same time, it felt… imperative.

—Why do you worry about me?

—I told you the first time… I can't stand how cruel they are— she reminded her. —And this time, it was my fault, in a way— she added, looking away, ashamed. —Consider your debt fully paid.

The woman smirked before letting out —Fair enough.

After a few hours, they both fell asleep against the bars, with Castaspella tightly holding Shadow Weaver who, in turn, rested her hands on top of the woman's. Neither had really paid attention to this and, when they woke up, they both pretended nothing happened.

However, the older woman woke up with tears in her eyes and only one thought: she'd soon lose Castaspella, the only person who cared for her since her "disappearance", *despite* knowing who she was and what she did. She would soon lose this woman, who cried *for her*, who bore the traumatizing experience of undressing for those filthy guards… *for her*.

She had to tell her.

She had to admit it, to herself, and to her…

Because she refused to lose her without telling her about the feelings she had developed.

Stupid, weak, disgusting feelings.

Overwhelming, powerful, undeniable feelings.

Yet more bad news would soon arrive…

The following day, early in the morning, they were woken up by another hunter, who had gone to deliver Shadow Weaver's sentence.

She was finally *found guilty too*.

—Wait, what!?— Castaspella exclaimed, feeling her senses suddenly go numb.

—Me!? On what basis!? If I were a demon, would I have let those two motherfuckers beat me up yesterday!?— she angrily spat.

—That is not my prerogative— the hunter said.

—It's ridiculous how you've sold yourselves to the inquisitors…— she hissed.

—I advise you to keep your mouth shut if you don't want another beating— one of the guards said, unusually formal, probably due to the hunter's presence.

—Have you understood what I said, Shadow Weaver?

—I have— she hissed.

—Good.

Castaspella's shock was evident on her face, and that was the only reason why the older woman didn't speak her mind this time. What she didn't know, was *what* had her in such a state.

Unbeknownst to them, both had the same strong feelings, and she refused to accept it like the older woman did before.

And yet, despite Shadow Weaver's resolution when she woke up, now she wouldn't dare admit her feelings anymore.

They both felt like it was the worst possible moment for it, and they stubbornly pushed it aside.

However, Castaspella didn't hesitate to say —Now we need that escape plan.

—What? Weren't you…

—Forget it. You were right— she seriously sentenced. —We have six days to plan it out.

As they both sat on each side of the bars, Shadow Weaver proposed —What about taking advantage of the execution walk to escape?

—We can't open the cells ourselves so, yes, that will have to be.

—We'll have to locate all exits and make a run for it as soon as they release our feet.

—They do that?

—Yes; they think our will is broken and that we won't escape— Shadow Weaver explained. —They are also overconfident and believe they can catch two women if we attempt to run away. Especially me— she pointed out. —After all, they have no idea how much I've trained.

—That should play in our favour, yes— Castaspella agreed. —But, Bea… Can you really run after how they hit you yesterday?

—I heal fast. By tomorrow, I'll be as good as new— she assured her.

The women continued planning between meals and until they went to sleep. They had a main plan and several contingency ones, just in case.

But when they tried to rest, each on their poor excuse of a bed this time, neither could.

As Castaspella stared at the wooden ceiling, she went over all the reasons why she had to keep her feelings in check, especially now, and only focus on their escape.

They were both sentenced, so what if Shadow Weaver thought she wasn't genuine?

She already found her quite foolish, so what if she took this the same way?

She wouldn't be able to bear her mocking about this matter…

And there were even more reasons why she shouldn't even dream about having a relationship of that kind with the woman, even if they managed to escape.

Meanwhile, Shadow Weaver cursed internally.

Just her luck.

She also thought that telling her about her feelings now, after being told she'd be executed too, would sound fake or desperate.

Besides, what if it made Castaspella uncomfortable?

These would be their last days together if their escape plans failed…

She couldn't bear the idea of things getting uncomfortable for something as stupid as a feeling that could or could not be *love*.

It made her think about her trainees…

When she told them to live as if there was no tomorrow, they decided to confess their love, which they wouldn't have done otherwise.

But now, being in a situation where there really would be no tomorrow in just a few days, she found herself unable to follow their example.

After all, she couldn't understand how they had done it…

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—Wake up, everyone!— a guard yelled, hitting the bars of the cell with his lance. —You're required to have breakfast and get ready in half an hour.

—What's going on?— Adora groggily asked.

—Some fucker is being annoying— Catra replied. —What's with the urgency now!?

—You have to get ready. Queen's orders— he replied.

—Ready for what!?

—You'll know in due time— he answered once more, before retiring.

The five hunters had no option but to obey, and eventually were escorted by a group of six guards to an area they recognized as some training grounds.

—What are we doing here?— Lonnie asked, as if her teammates could know.

—I have a bad feeling— Catra admitted.

—Hunters— Queen Angella's voice rang out, commanding and severe. —You have been granted one chance to leave— she announced.

The five exchanged a confused glance.

After two weeks of having no news, they were suddenly offered "a chance to leave"!?

—The fuck does that mean?— Lonnie muttered.

—If you can beat a handful of our guards, you will be allowed to walk away after being escorted to the frontier— the Queen went on. —If you were to return, this opportunity won't be given a second time.

—What's the catch?— Catra hissed between her teeth. —This is too good to be true.

—As you're *trained* hunters, I suppose you will have no trouble dealing with some angels, will you?— she added.

—There it is…

Then, she gestured at someone behind the group, and they turned around to find none other than the King approaching them with the weapons they had confiscated.

—Why are you doing this?— Adora dared ask.

—Because I know what I saw— Micah replied, giving her a warning look. —And you better do it again, girl…

The five took their weapons, checked if they were fully functional still, and exchanged glances before both Adora and Catra nodded at the King.

—Good luck, kids.

There was no hint of sarcasm in his voice, which confused the hunters even more. But they had no time to dwell on that.

—Let the trial begin!— the Queen announced, throwing something upwards that shone with the sunlight.

The team stared at it, forgetting they were about to be attacked by angels, and followed with their sigh whatever that was until it landed on the ground, vertically stuck just a few meters away.

—The sword!— they said in unison, right before noticing the angels flying their way.

—Formation!— Catra ordered, and the five stood in a circle, back to back.

They needn't be ordered to open fire.

Follow your instincts and prioritize survival.

They could hear Light Spinner's words guiding them; this was nothing like training, yet was similar enough that they knew what to do.

Their shots broke the angels' formation immediately as they maneuvered to avoid the blasts, and the five began moving little by little towards the sword, making sure Adora could reach it safely.

Yet they were also forced to break their formation soon enough, when the angels threw their lances at them.

—Incoming!— Lonnie exclaimed, right in time for everyone to duck away.

Adora had the sword almost within reach, so she didn't hesitate to throw herself forward, rolling over her back, and landed right next to it.

Taking advantage of how her teammates distracted the angels, she put her hands around the hilt and felt strange for a moment.

It wasn't like in the Whispering Woods. This time, she was hearing a voice inside her head.

For the honor of Grayskull…

She had no idea what that meant, and forced herself to return her attention to the battlefield. Having pulled out the sword, she tried once again to "activate" that warrior form she had manifested back in the Woods, to no avail.

The voice sounded louder in her head, but all she could see were her friends being overwhelmed by the angels, Catra screaming orders while the others replied they were at their limit.

And so she did it.

Something took over her, she raised the sword and exclaimed that phrase booming inside her head.

—For the honor of Grayskull!

The angels attacking the hunters stopped at once, shocked at the powerful light that suddenly shone a few meters away from them, and then saw her.

The legendary warrior.

The Queen had warned them about her, but they still couldn't believe it.

—Attack!

Ignoring the four hunters, the angels charged towards the new threat, lances ready. Yet the same shield that stopped Princess Glimmer at the Woods manifested once more, and all the lances bounced off of it.

—What!?— one of them exclaimed.

Adora had no idea how she did that, but now felt overconfident. With a smirk, she charged forward to the nearest angel and pushed him away with the shield. Without notice, the shield returned to its sword form, and Adora yelled as she skillfully slashed forward.

Before long, the angels had escaped.

Perhaps because the danger was gone, or perhaps because she felt a bit exhausted, Adora returned to her normal form and gasped for air while her teammates rushed to check on her.

—That was awesome!— Kyle exclaimed.

—How did you do that!?— Lonnie asked.

—Are you alright!? They didn't hit you, right!?— Catra nervously inquired, checking her body for any signs of injury.

—I'm fine, I'm fine! And I have no idea how I did that— she laughed. But then, she recalled where they were, and her demeanor turned serious. Once she found again where Queen Angella was sitting, she pointed the sword at her and demanded —We passed your trial! Escort us to the border now!

The regent stood up, keeping her regal stance, and replied —You will be taken back if so you wish. But first… we need to interrogate each of you separately.

—What!?

—Why!?

—Are you kidding us!?

The hunters exclaimed at the same time, indignant, but the guards were already approaching them.

—If you comply, you'll be granted freedom— the Queen assured them. —Resisting will only make everything more difficult for everyone.

The hunters were all returned to their cell after being interrogated, and the last one to return was Adora. She walked in willingly, seemingly in a good mood.

—Finally!— Catra exclaimed, rushing to hug her.

—Took you long enough— Lonnie complained. —She was going crazy!

—Don't worry, I'm fine— she assured them, taking Catra's hands after breaking the hug. —In fact, it wasn't half bad, you know?— she admitted. —They gave me food and drink, said I must be starving after the battle, praised our skills and how we could stand our ground in front of their best guards while in their angel forms, *and* guaranteed our freedom. Both angels *and* some demons!

—They told me something similar, yeah— Lonnie nodded.

—Yes! They were really nice to us too— Kyle chimed in. —Rogelio already told me about his questioning. The demons asked us both about Adora and the sword.

—They asked me the same. Just… what I knew about Adora, her origin, or whatever…

—So they asked us all the same?— Catra realized, tilting her head in confusion. —Why?

—I don't know, but… it's not like any of us knows much about where we come from— Lonnie pointed out. After hearing a roar, she corrected herself —Except Rogelio.

—And what did they ask you, Dor?

—They wanted to know if I had ever done something like that before. And how it felt, how I did it… I couldn't answer many questions, and what I did answer sounded strange— she told them. —I mean, just earlier, I activated that warrior form by saying a phrase that was ringing inside my head— she explained. —And that makes no sense— she laughed.

—Well, speaking of nonsense, they… also asked me if I had heard of the legend of "She-Ra"?— Catra recalled.

—They didn't ask me that, no— Lonnie denied, seconded by Kyle and Rogelio.

—Ah… well… Actually, the Queen showed up at my interrogation— Adora admitted. —She shared with me some ancient scroll… about She-Ra— she explained. —She said that's what the warrior form is called.

—So… *you* are She-Ra now?— Catra asked, wary.

—Apparently?

—I was told that her legend says she's some… justice bringer, some kind of hero of Etheria tasked with protecting the balance of our world.

—How would I do that? It makes no sense… I-I'm a hunter!

—But that's the thing, Dor. They said they have been hoping for She-Ra's return to end the inquisition and all…— Catra revealed. —If you're She-Ra, you're not just a hero. You're *the* hero of the *immortals*.

—Oh— she sighed. —Oh! That's why they offered to let us stay here!

—I'm sorry, *what*!?

—I'm with Catra here. *What*!?— Lonnie asked too.

—They said we have a week to decide: we can stay here, free and all. They'll provide us with food, rooms, and even training for these new powers I have!

—I… think they only meant you, Dor— Catra let out, looking away.

—I thought so too, so I said I'm only staying if you do too.

—Really?

—I- This will sound strange, but I think we shouldn't return to the Fright Zone. You all said it: both angels and demons treated us nicely, fed us, praised us despite having beaten their own people…— Adora remarked. —If you rather return, then we return. But… I would rather stay here.

—Adora, our mission was to find information on Light Spinner's whereabouts. And we made *no progress* at all!— Catra reminded her.

—But that's the thing! If we stay here for a while, earn their trust, we can ask them directly if they ever captured her!

—I mean… we *would* be safer if we stayed here— Kyle commented.

—What!? But…— Lonnie reacted, yet trailed off, seeing his expression. —You really don't want to go back, right?

—I…— he hesitated. Rogelio roared softly, supportingly, and he nodded. —I don't think I can bear the Fright Zone anymore. Since Light Spinner disappeared, we've been… you know, bullied and all.

—You can't be serious— Catra let out. —You all want to stay!?

—Listen…

—Adora, why!?

—Hey, hey… I get it if you don't want to stay. I promise, I'll go wherever you go. But yes, I really want to stay— she admitted. —Just… not at your expense.

—But *why*?

—Because… I-I don't know. This just feels right. The immortals aren't as we thought, the demons aren't beasts… they aren't that different from us— she replied.

—If we're really free, then we can still leave at any moment later, right?— Catra asked, hesitant.

—Absolutely. The Queen herself said so.

With a sigh, Catra held Adora's hands tightly and said —Alright. When they come next week, we'll tell them our decision. *We'll stay*…

Chapter End Notes

See? That wasn't so bad…

WELL

This concludes Act 1!

Next week, Act 2 begins! I hope you enjoy!!!
See you next Monster Monday!

Act 2

Act 2

Of what happened in freedom

Chapter 4

Chapter Summary

Six days later...

Chapter Notes

Welcome back ^_^

A new act begins as their time in prison ends at long last! Is it good? Is it bad? From what you last read, what do you think? hehe

Anyways, you'll soon find out, and you may have an idea already seeing how the story doesn't end yet.

By the way, this chapter is fairly longer, like twice as long as chapter 2 <("^_^)

I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 4

—We can rest here— Castaspella sighed, sitting against a wall in an empty alley.

—What exactly happened back there!?

—What are you talking about?

—I don’t think the guards are *that* lame— Shadow Weaver remarked.

—Yes, you do…

—What I mean- Ugh… It took them so long to react! And then they were so slow chasing after us? Not to mention that the one that almost got me missed the mark by a lot; either their aim is shit or they are blind— she recounted.

—Well, yeah. When we separated, the ones running after me also seemed pretty out of shape, but what can I tell you? It’s just like you said: they were overconfident! We took them by surprise, Beatrix…

—And how did we lose them so easily?

—I know my way around these streets— Castaspella assured her.

—And they don’t?

—So it would seem… Or I’m just that great— she gloated.

—Who’s bragging now?

The woman giggled and let out a long sigh as she rested her head against the wall.

—Well, I guess it *was* a bit strange that they *didn't* tie our feet as you had said. It made things even easier— she commented.

—Indeed. I can't imagine why they didn't— the older woman let out, pensive.

—Alright. Whenever you’re ready, we better continue. We were quite lucky, in my opinion, but we’ll soon run out of said luck. We must hide…

—If you know your way around *so well*, then we’ll sure have no problem, right?— Shadow Weaver taunted her a bit.

—O-of course!— Castaspella nervously replied. —It won’t be easy, but I know a few abandoned places around here…

—Lead the way. I don’t need any rest— the older woman assured her, looking perfectly fine, as she said.

It didn’t take them long to make their way to the outskirts of the Valley of the Lost, where some poor-looking, long-abandoned huts offered them a form of shelter for the night. After all, evenings got windy and sand-storms were pretty common in that area.

—We need to move again as soon as possible, but this shall do for now— Castaspella stated, dusting the surface of a table inside one of the huts.

—We’re still not out of the crevasse. If we’re found, how are we supposed to escape?— Shadow Weaver inquired, noticeably anxious. —We’re cornered!

—No, we’re not— the woman calmly replied, trying to ease her fears. —There’s a way to get out of this chasm, alright? But we need a plan first. And food, of course.

—How do you intend to acquire any food, exactly?

—You could provide some ideas too, don’t you think!?

—I have none!

—Then give me some time to come up with alternatives to starvation!

A tense silence installed for a moment between the women, who hadn't noticed both had raised their tone.

—Right, of course— Shadow Weaver uttered, looking away, still anxious and a bit angry, but not wanting to take it out on her for reasons she didn't want to address. —I'll… check the other huts for some clothes or whatever I can find.

—Thank you— Castaspella replied. —And sorry for yelling.

—Never mind…

As the older woman left the place, she sighed and looked down at the table, wishing she was already back home.

She'll soon be…

But now, it was time to get food.

How?

Well, obviously, the old trick of any fugitive: she would *steal it*.

As the night fell on them, Castaspella returned to the hut with a bundle of cloth between her hands. Shadow Weaver had seen her leave moments before the sun completely sank under the horizon, and she reckoned it had to be about midnight now.

Had she really gotten food?

How?

And where was the outermost layer of her clothes?

Unless…

—I told you I could solve it— Castaspella proudly stated, opening the bundle over the table.

Only the moonlight leaking into the hut illuminated the silhouette of the fruits and cans she had managed to steal. But, of course, Shadow Weaver could see in the darkness and didn't need that much light to perfectly distinguish the food… and the piece of cloth as the missing clothes.

—You really just used your own clothing to carry those?

—Very smart, no?

—Forget it— the older woman sighed. —How can you find your way in this darkness?— she decided to ask instead, genuinely confused.

—I may be human, but I can see pretty well in the dark regardless— Castaspella sentenced, somehow smugger than before.

—I didn't think you could possibly be prouder than me— Shadow Weaver mocked her.

—What was it? "I'm only stating a fact"— Castaspella argued, echoing her words from back in the prison. —Just be grateful, grab a bite, and tell me what you found in the other huts…

The women each grabbed a fruit, sat on some creaky wooden chairs, and began eating.

—I found some pieces of fabric we can use as hoods. Also brought a flat mattress from a roof-less hut for tonight— she replied, before taking a bite.

—Is it usable?

—Not much different from the prison ones.

After swallowing, Castaspella further asked —Who's sleeping on it?

—And here I thought you'd be the first one to suggest that we share it…

—You'd be alright with that?

—Why wouldn't I?

—You don't seem… like someone who likes sharing.

Shadow Weaver shook a bit with silent laughter as she munched another bite of fruit, and laughed faintly once she had swallowed.

—You are right, indeed— she admitted, smirking. Her sight then turned mischievous as she pointed out —But I believe it's easier to touch someone when you're both in the same bed.

—Mattress, barely— she let out, rolling her eyes. —So is that the price for sharing it?

—There's no *price*— the older woman promptly corrected, hissing, and sounding slightly offended. —I'm not like those guards…

—I-I didn't mean to compare you! I just… Sorry if it sounded- I was trying to be, I don't know, funny or… enticing?— Castaspella apologized.

—The tone was right, but the choice of words… not so much.

Shadow Weaver's look let her know she wasn't upset, but she still felt bad.

—I wouldn't mind…— she began, but interrupted herself with a cough. —I mean, I liked it… What we did in the cells… I enjoyed it, and it would be… uh, *nice* to repeat it— she finally dared say.

—Why so shy all of a sudden?

—I don’t know— the woman admitted, resting back on the chair now that she had finished eating. —I tried to match your tone and mood but completely messed up…

—Why are you- I mean… Aren’t you affected by what happened? I reckoned you’d be traumatized or *something*— Shadow Weaver admitted. —After all, you never took off the base layer of your clothes again after that, so I supposed you were… perhaps… uncomfortable with the matter.

—I- No, well… I don’t- It’s not really like that— Castaspella stammered. —It’s just that… I am not… pretty or anything— she finally muttered, looking down. —So I don’t… like exposing my body.

—What a fool…

—Mean!

—You can’t seriously think your body is something to be ashamed of— she insisted.

—What would *you* know!?

—Do you forget I was there? I *saw* you— Shadow Weaver reminded her. —Your body is just fine.

—I don’t know whether you’re insulting me or not, Beatrix— the woman replied, folding her arms.

—I am not insulting you— she assured her, rolling her eyes. —If you want to see what a body to be ashamed of *really* looks like, I can always take off my robes…

—You don’t have to… I-it’s okay— Castaspella quickly clarified. —But I don’t think you should be ashamed of your body, either.

—Trust me. *I* do have proper reasons…

—Really?

—That demon who betrayed me left a very visible, very painful reminder of what he did…— she began, her tone going slightly higher for a moment. —The scars you see on my face and arms… they are all over my body— she finally revealed.

—Are you serious?— the woman gasped, almost covering her mouth in surprise.

—Very.

—Why!?

—I don’t know…

—How can a demon do something like that!?

—I must admit I don’t think it was intentional, but that doesn’t make it any better— she scoffed.

—I’m so sorry, Bea…

—No need to be.

Once again, there was silence.

Neither knew what to say nor do, so Shadow Weaver simply sat there, leaning back on her chair, while Castaspella stood up to wrap the remaining food with her clothes again.

—I… believe we should sleep.

—What are we supposed to do tomorrow? The food you got us won’t last long, and you shouldn’t risk stealing more.

—Well, I told you we should start moving again tomorrow.

—What’s the plan?

Sitting down once more, the woman proposed —What about continuing towards the West, boarding a ship at the docks, and aiming for Bright Moon? We’ll be safe there.

—I don’t know if I should… go there— Shadow Weaver sighed, looking down.

—Why?

—I… I am known as a hunter, remember?

—You’ll be with me, I can get you in without any trouble— she assured her, winking. —I have contacts, trust me.

—Why would you?

—I’m not abandoning you! A-and other hunters have been accepted before, you know? Since you used to live with immortals, I don’t see why you can’t go back to it— Castaspella pointed out. —I understand hating demons for what happened to you, but… not all demons are like that— she insisted, looking down.

—I suppose you’re right, but it’s still… a risky plan.

—Let’s just try, yes?

—I suppose we lose nothing… But the docks are days away.

—I know. We’ll… probably need some more provisions before departing.

—We’d be traversing the desert. Where are we going to sleep?

—I am quite crafty. I'm sure I can set up a make-shift tent with stuff from these huts— Castaspella confidently told her.

—I'll have to trust you, I suppose— she groaned. —I do *not* trust people usually, so consider yourself *fortunate*.

—I can tell you're quite wary— she giggled. —And, from what you told me, that's quite justified. So… I guess I do feel fortunate, yes— she smiled.

—Fool— the older woman faintly laughed, shaking her head in amusement.

The women did sleep together that night. Just like in prison, they touched each other, quenching their thirst, and that was all.

Neither got naked and, once done, they said goodnight and turned around to sleep.

However, when they woke up, they were snuggling close, their faces a breath away from each other.

And just like when they fell asleep together in prison, they both pretended nothing happened when they woke up.

Shadow Weaver felt like her opportunity to confess had passed, while Castaspella still refused to ponder on what she was feeling, going over her many reasons to keep the woman at arm's length.

Yet they both had such a strong need to keep the other safe that they couldn't remain indifferent to each other…

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Eventually, the five hunters were granted freedom as promised.

It was a *relative* freedom, however, as they all remained under vigilance.

They were given a pair of rooms, one for Adora and Catra, the other for Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, and both chambers were guarded all day by either angels or demons in their immortal forms.

It only emphasized how relative their new freedom is.

But it was better than the alternative.

Much better, in fact, now that they had their first proper meal together. They already considered the prison food good, so this felt like a luxury.

—Are we sure this isn't poisoned?— Catra asked, eyeing the food with wariness.

—This is great!— Adora assured her, mouth half full. —Please try it!— she begged, once she swallowed.

—She's right! It's so much better than anything I've had before!— Kyle supported her.

—Come on, it's obviously not poisoned— Lonnie joined them, a bit more dismissive of her concerns.

—I don't know… This feels… too good… I don't feel comfortable— she admitted, hugging herself.

—It's okay to be careful, but… you can't starve yourself— Adora tried to argue, speaking gently.

—What if it's all a trap, Dor? What do we do then!?

—If- I-I don't think it is. I have a really good feeling about this! But… if it were, then we do what we know best. We *fight*— she replied, confidently.

Catra looked around at the rest of their team and they all gave her resolute looks.

They are together in this, and that includes protecting each other.

—I also have a good feeling, but if we turn out to be wrong, you can trust we'll follow your lead— Lonnie assured her.

—Thanks, guys— she sighed. —I… guess it can't hurt to eat some…

—Yay!

They eventually finished and wished each other goodnight as they retired to their rooms.

Adora and Catra walked hand in hand down the huge corridors of the palace, admiring the luxurious decoration and beautiful architecture.

Everything was so different from the Fright Zone…

And they still couldn't get over their bed. So fluffy, soft, and comfortable.

—…Anyways, this is what I mean when I say everything is too good— Catra argued, shaking her head.

—Is that really it, though?

—What do you mean?

—Are you sure these little things are what keep you on edge?

—Of course! What else would it be?

—It just feels like there's something else bothering you…

—I promise, Dor. It's not really something I can put my finger on. It's literally everything and nothing at the same time. It's the food, the rooms, the "freedom"; the guards, the Queen, the Princess— she replied. Taking a deep breath, she added —And one of us has to keep her guard up just in case.

—So… me accepting so easily… me being this… "She-Ra" hero… Those aren't the things putting you on edge?

—You'd never put me on edge— Catra quickly assured her. —I want to trust your judgement, but just in case, I'd rather be wary so *you* don't have to.

—Thank you— Adora smiled. —I said it already, but I'll say it again. If *anything* happens that threatens any of us, we escape. *Together*— she reiterated. —Wherever you go, I go too.

—Promise?

—Promise— she softly replied, leaning forwards until their foreheads were touching. After a moment, she straightened her back again and asked —Should we go to sleep now?

—Sleep?

—Any alternate ideas?

—Well… we spent your twenty-first birthday in that cell… why don't we… make up for it?

—And what exactly do you have in mind?

Catra smirked and pointed out —This room has a great bathroom, remember? What about a… relaxing bath, some massages… and then you let me treat you well?

Adora laughed and threw her arms around her neck while giving her a brief kiss.

—That sounds amazing— she accepted.

—Well, come on now— Catra said, picking her up in her arms to carry her to the bathroom.

As promised, Adora was treated to a hot bath and a massage that *almost* got a bit out of hand, and was finally carried back to the bed, wrapped in a towel that didn't last long.

Catra took it upon herself to make her enjoy the night to the fullest.

If there was something she was grateful for in this place, it was the privacy they now had.

Here, they didn't have to hide, muffle their moans, or tone down their arousal… They could scream each other's names to their hearts' content.

The following morning, after having breakfast, the five hunters were walking together when they noticed a bit of a commotion. Following the sound, they saw a pair of unknown individuals who were arguing while walking into the throne room.

—We have our fears, and our people come first!— the blonde one was saying.

—And do you think I don't!?

—Mermista, you have…

—I swear, if you name him, Perfuma, I'm never talking to you again— the other one warned her, sounding more serious and less aloof than just a moment before.

As the doors to the throne room closed behind them, the hunters exchanged a glance and left the building, walking into an empty garden.

—Do those names ring a bell for you too?— Lonnie asked.

—I think… yes?— Adora hesitantly replied.

—I'm pretty sure Light Spinner spoke about some other immortal princesses… Those would be them— Catra told them. —But they are neither angels nor demons— she then clarified.

—Then what are they!?— Kyle asked.

—They are a nereid and a sidhe… Or a fairy, if you may— a voice answered.

—Pri-Princess— he nervously stammered, turning around to find Glimmer walking towards them. However, his demeanor completely changed in a second and all his nervousness disappeared in exchange for utter confusion. —What are those names you just said?

—How many immortal species do you know again?— Bow asked back, curious.

—Who cares?— Catra interrupted, stepping forward. —What are you two doing here? You're supervising us personally now?

—You seemed pretty suspicious when you walked out of the building— Glimmer replied, smug.

—Well, we just wanted a place to talk— Adora replied, a bit nervous as she preferred to keep things peaceful. —We… don't really know that much. Can you tell us more about other species of immortals?

—Sure!— Bow immediately replied, earning an annoyed look from Glimmer.

—No!? Why would we tell them anything!?

—Glim, they are just curious…

—They are *hunters*!

—Your mother…

—I know! But- I only accepted if we kept our guard up!

—Newsflash, Princess— Catra interrupted them. —We're just the same.

—*And* we're not planning on doing anything as long as there's no threat, alright?— Adora quickly clarified.

—Ye-yeah. This is a really nice place, I wouldn't want to… ruin it— Kyle commented, far too honest.

—You know what!? Fuck it!— Lonnie spat, fed up. —It'll sound like bullshit to you, but Kyle is right— she began, facing Glimmer. —I don't expect you to trust us, Princess, but the truth is we're *better* here. No, we will *not* stay if you become a threat to us, but I *sure* hope you won't because I don't wanna go back to the Fright Zone either!

Rogelio roared in agreement and, calmer than her, Kyle said —We had no idea demons weren't the monsters everyone else believes them to be. And, just in general, we thought all immortals would treat us like scum for being mortals… But, you guys didn't.

—Is… the Fright Zone that bad?— Bow asked, exchanging a concerned look with Glimmer.

—For us? Yeah— Lonnie nodded. —What we were taught… Others think we're weak— she explained. Then, with a scoff, she added —They probably think we died here because of that…

—What were you taught?— Glimmer inquired, curious but suspicious.

—To survive— Adora replied. —To live— she went on. Then, with a glance at Catra, she concluded —To take care of those we love.

—That's… not what I expected— the Princess admitted. —Why- Who taught you that?

—Her name was… Light Spinner— Catra replied this time, looking away. —She wasn't a nice person, like at all… But she didn't want us to be cruel and reckless like the other teams — she elaborated. —She was strict, hard to please, and I could go on all day about her shitty attitude. But what she taught us was completely opposite to that— she insisted.

—So she didn't teach you to… I don't know, kill us painfully, dismember us…— Glimmer was asking, until Bow gave her an indignant look.

—No— Lonnie denied, shaking her head.

—She tried to teach us how to kill you at first, and I almost threw up— Kyle admitted. — Then she changed strategies and said we were better suited for non-lethal methods.

—Basically, she taught us how to track you down, survive your attacks, catch you if possible, and some interrogation techniques— Catra concluded.

—After all, hunters aren't supposed to kill alleged demons, just hand them in to the inquisitors— Adora explained. —And for those who were undeniable demons, as in, we saw them in their immortal form, we still had to hand them in because execution is the inquisition's job.

Glimmer let out a brisk laugh, looking down in complete shock.

—I was- I literally tried to *kill you*! You mean to tell me you weren't?

—I…— Adora hesitated. —No, well, I wasn't… I mean, after you trapped my friends, I just wanted to fight back to free them. But I can't really say what I was going to do when I transformed into that warrior… She-Ra— she admitted. —I wasn't thinking clearly, I don't really remember what I did.

—But you *do* remember what you did on the battlefield last time— she wanted to confirm.

—Yeah. But it wasn't the same. I think- Well, I told the Queen I had to say a phrase to transform, which I hadn't said the first time, so I guess that's why it was different.

—Alright— Bow let out. —So you're not the ruthless blood-thirsty hunters we thought you to be…

—And demons aren't the monsters we were taught they were— Catra talked back, folding her arms.

—Which means we can, perhaps, calm down a bit, no?— Adora pleaded.

—Why-why don't we go back to those princesses and the immortal species you mentioned before?— Kyle proposed, nervous but trying to remain positive.

Glimmer smirked, looking down and shaking her head in amusement.

She couldn't believe it, but it was actually better than imagined.

—Yeah, why not…— she accepted, approaching a bench, followed by Bow. She waited for the hunters to sit down too, some on the bench in front of them, some on the grass, and then began —Those princesses are Mermista, ruler of Salineas, and Perfuma, Ruler of Plumeria.

—In the kingdom of Salineas, other than mortal mere-folk, you can find immortals of two species: nereids and naiads. Both are kinds of nymphs. Mermista happens to be a nereid, which would be a nymph that inhabits both saltwater and freshwater. The naiads, on the other hand, inhabit springs, rivers, and lakes— Bow patiently explained.

—Meanwhile, you have two very different kinds of immortals in Plumeria, other than the human mortals. There are sidhe, also known as fairies, and Sluagh. Their differences are *very* notorious, and it's more difficult to explain them— Glimmer went on. —But I'll try. Perfuma is a sidhe, which is a type of immortal not that different from angels.

—They don't like the comparison, and you know that…— he reminded her.

—I know, but they only know angels and demons!

—So you're going to call the Sluagh "similar to demons"?

—Well, that's not that far either…

—If your father heard you…

—Bow, you sound like Mom— Glimmer retorted.

—Fine, go on…

—Alright— the Princess sighed. —Sidhe are sometimes called faeries because they are really nice immortals, with healing and protective powers. They look beautiful and similar to humans but more ethereal, They can also move through the air and change shape at will!— she explained. —But, even though they are mostly pacific, which is quite encouraged by Perfuma, they can still fight pretty well. They have lances of blue fire and these… pure white shields…

—It's quite a rare sight— Bow commented.

—Yeah. Contrarily, the Sluagh are… more temperamental. Also travel through the air, but, opposite to the Sidhe, they look kinda… ugly.

—They are also similar to humans, but… bony. Like skeletons with some flesh still attached, and a few strands of black hair hang from their skulls. They also have *very* sharp claws, and pointy teeth protruding from beak-like mouths. Oh, and wings! But nothing like the angels' wings. They are more like leather, quite large and like those of a bat; they kinda look like a cloak when they have them closed around their bodies— he described. —You do *not* want to see their immortal form. And they rarely want to show it themselves— he went on. —Part of the reason why Perfuma encourages a pacific lifestyle for her people is to keep the Sluagh comfortable. After all, they can go feral easily if provoked…

—Is that why the Princess was so worried?— Adora asked.

Seeing Glimmer and Bow's confused look, Catra explained —We heard the princesses discussing; if we understood them right and Perfuma is the blonde one, then she's the one that said they "have their fears" and that their people come first.

—*Yeah*… About that— the Princess nodded, looking away. —Some princesses don't really like that we freed you guys here— she explained. —In fact, you're not allowed to leave Bright Moon.

—Unless you were going to the Fright Zone— Bow quickly clarified. —You just can't go to other kingdoms.

—Of course— Lonnie scoffed.

—But it's probably better that way— Glimmer assured them. —Look, you're… not as bad as we thought. Yet other immortals don't know that and are so wary of hunters, fearing they

might be hunted too, that you'd probably have a bad time in other kingdoms.

—That's… what we were told at the Fright Zone too— Adora recalled.

—Holy shit, right!— Catra reacted.

—What are you talking about?— Kyle asked, seconded by Rogelio.

—Oh, wait. You mean Scorpia and Entrapta?— Lonnie realized.

—Yeah.

—Those names…— Glimmer let out, pensive. —How do you know them?

—They are… immortals who work with the hunters— Adora hesitantly explained. —And they said they were rejected by the other immortals. Especially Scorpia.

—We shouldn't talk about that— Catra hissed.

—I know, sorry.

—Fine. We won't ask more about that if you don't want to tell us, but… I suppose it's fair, then— Bow lamented.

—I thought those two princesses had died.

—They are also princesses?— Lonnie asked.

—Yeah— they both nodded.

—That makes a lot of sense, now that I think about it— Catra muttered. —But again. We shouldn't tell you anything else.

Glimmer and Bow nodded once more and finally left, relieved and feeling more at ease about the hunters.

Chapter End Notes

> You may have noticed that, this time, while the first part was since about, I don't know, noon until past midnight, aprox, the second part was all the way until the following morning…
>
> I would have fixed that so the same time-frame was covered in both parts, as usual, but… I felt too lazy, I'm so sorry… <("^_^)
>
> Anyways, I'll try not to mess that up again lol

Hope you enjoyed and see you next Monster Monday!!

Chapter 5 - Flashbacks

Chapter Summary

Hours earlier...

Chapter Notes

I don't really remember why I decided to skip this and put it as flashbacks instead, BUT the sacred notes said so!! XD

Anyways, here's what led to the previous chapter's events ^_^

I hope you enjoy!! :D

Chapter 5

Flashbacks

The guards arrived early. Each handled one of them, tying their wrists with a rope, from which they pulled them out of their cells to take them to their public execution.

Not cuffs, not chains… just ropes.

Shadow Weaver was right: they underestimate prisoners on the way to death.

There had been reports of some prisoners escaping right before being executed, but usually, those had obvious help from immortals who infiltrated the public and promptly helped them to escape.

There would be no such help this time, would there? How would two unknown prisoners get any external help?

After all, immortals only helped half-demons who hadn’t developed their powers, as both trained half-demons and full demons are rarely caught…

Shadow Weaver had heard of such cases, which usually ended with them finally showing their powers to walk away from the execution unscathed.

How hadn’t the inquisitors learnt yet?

Either they were delusional enough to believe they’d be the first ones to execute demons, as they had deemed them, or they knew they weren’t yet still ordered the execution.

After all, if they are the authorities now… who would dare contradict or defy them?

The sun was up in the sky, shining strong and raising the heat in the Valley of The Lost. Despite their shoes, the women could feel the hot sand burning under their feet as they were led to the center of the arena under the watchful gaze of a loud audience.

Castaspella exchanged a look with Shadow Weaver, gestured at one of the exits to their right, and shook her head. As the older woman gave her a confused look, she quietly mouthed “follow me”, and waited for her to confirm.

Shadow Weaver hesitated a second.

They were already close to the gallows built in the middle of this former battleground. Their window of opportunity was closing…

Could she really trust Castaspella or were her damned feelings tricking her?

Well, she had to trust, like it or not; the alternative is a broken neck…

As she finally nodded, Castaspella yelled —Now!

They both pulled hard from the ropes and began running towards the exit to their left.

It took their guards a moment too long to realize, and the ropes burnt their hands as they slid between their fingers.

The rest of the guards reacted slowly as well; the gates began closing slowly, yet so late that the women managed to slide under it just in time.

—We have to free our hands!— Shadow Weaver exclaimed.

—First, we have to get out!

As they ran down a passageway, they came across a few piles of crates, and Castaspella didn’t hesitate to pull them down to block the way behind them. Yet the guards finally caught up to them, carrying crossbows.

While some of them busied themselves moving the crates away, the others began shooting at them as they kept running.

Castaspella looked back in time to see one aiming for Shadow Weaver, yet their arrow missed by a large margin, making her laugh. She quickly pushed the older woman to her right to change directions and keep running, looking for an exit.

—What’s so funny?

—You're lucky; thought that arrow would hit you— Castaspella replied. —Now just push forward a bit more. I think we're close.

—How do you know?

—I recall where they brought me through.

After this much time, *she remembered*?

Could she be leading her to a trap?

Castaspella kept making her turn different ways while the guards footsteps sounded closer and closer. Then, she had her run through a tunnel to her right, while she took the one to the left, telling her they'd meet again outside, and lose the guards.

Once more, she could only trust, despite hating how it felt to *not know for sure*.

And yet, the passage she took *did* lead outside the prison.

—She was telling the truth— she sighed.

—Of course I was!— her voice suddenly said, as she appeared from the left, hands free. —Let me untie you and we'll go— she hurriedly said, making quick work of the knots. —Now come on! Move, move!

Once again, she hesitated for a moment as she looked at her free hands, until the yelling of the guards approaching through the passage made her remember they weren't safe yet.

Perhaps she could trust her after all…

Shadow Weaver followed Castaspella through narrow side streets and alleys. They ran between houses and shady shops, tripped whatever they could behind them to slow the guards down, and eventually reached an empty alley where Castaspella halted and rested against a wall.

The guards were nowhere to be seen.

Even with her sensitive hearing, Shadow Weaver couldn't hear them anymore.

They had lost them. They had escaped.

But how!?

How had they… managed that!?

<~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~>

—Are you absolutely sure you did the right thing?

—What- But-but, why!?

—In our current situation, it was the most sensible decision.

—Mom! They are *hunters*!

—She's right, Angie…

—I know, and I still believe inviting them to stay in the kingdom, and reject their previous life as hunters, is what we *had to* do— Queen Angella insisted.

—Can you just explain your reasoning to us, maybe?

—It's actually quite simple— she nodded. —We saw a few days ago what they are capable of. We saw them fight, not to kill our people, but to protect each other. Those hunters, those *kids*, they aren't murderers like others we've known!

—Mom, they are *hardly* kids, they must be about my age!— Glimmer complained.

—And you *are* a kid, my Dear— she promptly replied.

—I am not!

—Alright, alright— Micah interrupted. —So, let me get this straight: You gave them the option to stay, *free*, in Bright Moon?

—Under vigilance, of course. But yes. I offered them a new life as allies, and have been making preparations these past days to quickly arrange some accommodations if they accept — she nodded.

—Why!?

—After all my investigation, I designed the trial to test them as *people*, not just their combat prowess. And during the interrogations, I confirmed my suspicions…

—And what would be the result? I don't think either of us is seeing what you do— the King inquired.

—They are a group, a team, almost a *family*. They protect each other, they value each other's lives… We saw them work together to help the blonde girl… Adora, reach the sword. We saw her finally manage that transformation, *only* to save her friends— Angella pointed out. —After they were safe, she could have tried to attack us, especially when I said we'd interrogate them first, instead of taking them to the border as promised. Yet she didn't. None of them did.

—Because they know what's best for them— Glimmer smirked.

—Or because they genuinely have no thirst for murder like the hunters we need to protect ourselves from.

—Angie… What have you really seen in them?

—I see enough innocence…

—What if it's all a trick!?

—Then let us hear another opinion, alright?— Angella offered, gesturing at a guard at the door. With a nod, they opened and Bow walked in. —Welcome…

—What are *you* doing here!?— the Princess immediately jumped.

—Sorry, Glim. Your mo- The Queen asked me to wait outside and… in my humble opinion, yes, she's right to give them a chance— he explained. —I am just a mortal but, *as a mortal*, I can tell you they are not a real threat. I've seen… ruthless hunters, blinded by rage or fear, some even just… thirsty for blood. But, them!? For all we know, they were scouts or something…

—We heard them say they wanted to capture a demon!— Glimmer reminded him.

—Uh, yeah. *Capture*, not *kill*. That already says a lot— he insisted. —I just think they deserve a chance, an option, a way out of the hunter's life they have had— he went on. —I mean… My dads…

—Your fathers are a special case. George was hesitant as a hunter, and Lance was wrongly accused. Their love was the reason he abandoned the teachings of the Fright Zone— the King remarked.

—Then what about a hunter who abandoned the path and joined the immortals *without* any such reasons?— Bow asked. —He even fell for an immortal *after* a while of living in…

—…Salineas, yes— Glimmer interrupted, rolling her eyes. —You can't really think they will be the same case as Sea Hawk!

—I don't think they will be the same, but… the chance of them making the same decision as him exists, and it's not like we have to let our guard down! For starters, the Guards are already gossiping about that, and…

—I'd rather hear it from them after this meeting— Angella interrupted him. —As I said, they would only be free within Bright Moon, and remain supervised— she reminded them.

—The rest of the Alliance won't like this one bit, Mom…

—Then they are free to come discuss it personally with me, if that's the case— she severely replied.

—Alright. Let's… see whether they accepted the offer or not and… we'll see what comes out of this— Micah sighed.

—We'll lose nothing trying and, best case scenario, we may earn ourselves a powerful ally and a couple of skilled warriors— his wife insisted.

Chapter 6

Chapter Summary

A week later…


SPOILER



Chapter Notes

I am so sorry for this chapter's trigger warning, but like, I "chose not to use archive warnings" because I didn't want to spoil or give the wrong impression.

▶ Brief spoiler for non-con reference:

So, just in case, I wanted to warn that. It's a super tiny reference, but… yeah…

Regardless, I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 6

—Just a bit further…— Castaspella exhorted her, while helping Shadow Weaver move. —We're almost safe— she assured her.

The women struggled to walk between the passageways of an abandoned settlement in the middle of the desert. They had been traveling for about a week but were finally about to arrive at the port. They calculated it had to be about a day away now…

—Are they gone?

—Yes, don't worry. But I still rather we make camp behind these ruins.

—What were they even doing around here?— Shadow Weaver weakly asked.

—If you don't know… You're the hunter.

—Yes, but Tung Lashor was *never* open about where he took his goons…— the older woman explained.

—I see.

—How did we lose them?

—They gave up, actually— Castaspella clarified.

—They did?— she asked again, surprised. Shadow Weaver let out a cackle but it made the wound on her side hurt so much it forced her to stop. —This damned shit…

—Maybe don't… do that for now— the young woman suggested, finally helping her rest against a dilapidated wall. —I'll put up the tent and then you can lie down, alright?

—Sure… It's just an arrow through my side, nothing urgent.

—Would you rather I tend to your wound on the sand!?

—Take your time— she smirked. —I'll be fine, I was messing with you.

—I know— she sighed.

Once everything was settled, Castaspella helped Shadow Weaver into the tent, where she laid down; the first two layers of the young woman's clothes working as a pillow for her.

—Aren't you cold?

—No, I'm fine— Castaspella assured her. —Now, let me see the wound.

She carefully lifted her clothes up to her abdomen, and used a bit of their clean water to wash away the blood after pulling the arrow out. However, her expression suddenly went from focused to surprised, and the older woman got worried for a second.

—What is it?

—You're… a-already… *healing*— she let out. Ah, *that*. —Are you… *really* a demon!?

—Not exactly— Shadow Weaver promptly replied, smirking. —What you're seeing is related to why I disappeared… The hunters didn't like it one bit.

—What happened then? You were betrayed by a demon, you said, which caused the scars and all, but… this…

—The only good thing I got out of it— she scoffed. —There aren't many ways of obtaining powers from a demon, so I'll let you take a guess.

—You had… intercourse with one.

—The same one that betrayed me— she nodded.

Castaspella shook her head a bit, clearing her thoughts, yet remained pensive as she finished cleaning Shadow Weaver's wound.

—So, what happened?

—In short, I was offered powers in exchange for… *that*, and at first accepted. But I hadn't noticed the… crazed look in his eyes. And no matter how hard I tried to stop him, he wouldn't let me go— the older woman explained.

—Bea…

—I got myself into that…

—I- Was that why you reacted like that to me undressing for the guards?

—Pretty much— she admitted.

—Listen: even if you accepted at first, as soon as you didn't want to anymore, he should have stopped. Mortal or immortal, it's the same— Castaspella seriously said.

—It was my greed and lust for power that got me into that.

—Which speaks badly of you, but doesn't *justify* what he did to you! And I don't even mean the scars and that, I mean *forcing you*.

—Castaspella— she interrupted her. —Everything that has happened to me is a consequence of my hybris. I sought powers I shouldn't have, I used said powers to kill demons left and

right, and as soon as the hunters learnt what I had done, they put me in jail. I am wanted by both hunters and demons, considered both and neither simultaneously. In the past year, I had… too much time to reflect. I hate it, but I recognize I'm the cause of my own misfortune — she explained. —However, I don't regret it one bit.

—You're… on the run, no longer bleeding but still wounded, and have nowhere to go but the land of the immortals you betrayed— Castaspella pointed out. —Yet you *don't* regret what you've done?

—Of course not— the older woman laughed. —I shall heal, I don't care about the immortals accepting me or not, I'll see what I do, and I'd say you're *lucky* to have me around now— she went on. —I have the power to keep your fragile human life safe— she concluded with a smirk.

—You know what!? Fuck you…

—You'll thank me later…

—Or *not*. You're the one who got hurt, after all— Castaspella reproached her. —Now better rest so we can continue later.

—So we sleep now and continue on our way at night?

—Yes. First of all, because you still need time despite the speedy healing— the young woman began. —Second, most ships depart at night, and we can't just "wait around". It's not safe…

—Of course.

—But also, because it'll be safer to move; there are also hunters around the docks…

—Then you better rest too— Shadow Weaver said, letting out a yawn.

—I don't need to.

—I insist.

—Why? Want some company?

—What if I said "yes"?— the older woman replied, smirking.

With a chuckle and shaking her head in amusement, Castaspella lay down next to her and sighed —I suppose I can take a while to rest… Why not?

She observed the older woman for a moment, noticing she wanted to say something, and gave her time to speak.

—I'm… surprised you weren't appalled by the revelation— Shadow Weaver finally decided to admit. She turned to face the young woman and said —You were… pensive instead. Why?

—I…— she hesitated. —I have seldom heard of mortals managing to get powers from intercourse with immortals, instead of simply dying, I mean. So, I wondered what powers you got.

—Ah… I see— she smirked. —Well, besides the speedy healing, I have some interesting kinetic powers. I'm unable to teleport like demons, but I can instead command shadows at will. I don't have increased strength, but can provoke electric shocks just as strong as the punch of a demon— she bragged.

—Interesting. Way to inflate your ego, though.

—I'm just naturally superior— Shadow Weaver replied, smirk widening.

—Sure…— Castaspella uttered, rolling her eyes yet letting out half a smile as she found her bragging, perhaps, a bit endearing at this point.

Little by little, the women fell asleep.

The tent kept them safe from the chilly wind, and the occasional sandstorm outside.

Eventually, night fell and Castaspella woke Shadow Weaver up.

—Already time to go?

—Your wound looks much better already. So yes, we should get going.

—Fine…

—It will probably hurt for a while more, though. Won't it?— the young woman asked, while picking up the layers of clothes she had taken off to put them on again.

—Indeed. But I can bear it.

—Even if we have to run from hunters again?

—I'll know when that happens— Shadow Weaver replied, far too aloof for Castaspella's taste.

—Beatrix…

—If it were necessary…— she interrupted, dusting off her robes as she stood up. —You can simply leave me and make a run for it.

—I am *not* like that.

—I'd do it in your place.

—No, you wouldn't— the young woman confidently replied. —You and your "need to repay me" wouldn't let you.

—Aren't we even already?

—Who helped you escape? And I mean both prison *and* Tung Lashor!— Castaspella pointed out.

—You, little…

—What?

—Forget it… Do whatever you want— Shadow Weaver sighed, resigned. —Let's pick up the tent and leave already.

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As the Queen had promised, Adora was given training for her new powers, and allowed to spar against immortals, along with Catra and their team.

Most times, they would have a few rounds against royal guards in their angelic forms, but whenever the King noticed improvement, he would decide to test their prowess himself.

After a couple of days, Adora was assigned Glimmer as her sparring partner for solo rounds, and after that first week since they were freed, the dynamic of the group changed significantly.

For the most part, Catra was evidently jealous.

She'd always watch Adora and Glimmer's sparring sessions, arms folded and face contorted in a scowl.

It was no wonder that she and the princess had so many arguments, sometimes loud enough that the Queen herself had to intervene.

Catra did *not* like Glimmer in the slightest and, while the other hunters tried to be as respectful as possible, she never shied away from arguing with the princess.

That day, when a couple of guards arrived carrying a seriously hurt Glimmer, a part of Catra wanted nothing more than to mock her.

She felt smug; the princess wasn't as indestructible as she claimed…

However, Adora looked *worried*.

—This isn't good— she kept saying, pacing around the room. —I-I should do something!

—Why? It's not like you can do anything— Catra pointed out, trying to hide her annoyance.

—I should be able to!— she insisted, halting her pacing to look at her. —I mean, one of the powers I have as She-Ra is healing, right!?

—You've been trying to use it all week, and failed.

—But…

—Besides, immortals heal fast, she's surely fine, Dor— Catra interrupted her, trying to dismiss her concerns.

—Maybe it isn't enough!

—Adora, *what* do you want to do!?

—I…— she hesitated, looking towards the door. —I want to go… and see if I *can* heal her this time.

—You…— Catra began, yet cut herself short, changing her mind. —Whatever. You know what? Go. Try. Just… don't take it to heart if you fail, alright?— she finally told her, looking down, her tone betraying how concerned she actually was.

Adora approached her, cupped her face, and leant forward to kiss her briefly.

—Thank you— she softly said, before letting go and leaving the room.

—Yeah…

She didn't even know where to go to find the princess, or some kind of medical bay, but, fortunately, it wasn't long before she came across the Queen herself.

—Yo-your Majesty!— she stammered. —I- So-sorry. Can I… ask where the princess is?

—You… want to visit my daughter?

—I…— she began, clearing her throat. —I would like to try using She-Ra's power to heal her.

—And that would be welcome, but you have shown no progress in that regard, young hunter — Angella pointed out.

—I know! But I feel like I should try all the same.

The Queen let out a sigh, thoughtful for a moment.

Could it be a trap?

Could the hunter be trying to get close to her daughter while she's most vulnerable?

No… From what she had seen that week, there was no chance this girl, Adora, would do something like that.

—Alright. I suppose… it can't hurt to try.

—I did it! It worked!

—You… finally managed it? *For her*?— Catra asked, incredulous, folding her arms as she looked away.

—Isn't that great!?— Adora kept celebrating. —Now I can keep us all safe even if someone gets hurt!— she told her, placing her hands on Catra's sides, her tone and expression soft.

—Someone like the princess?

—Someone like you— Adora corrected her. She then gently made Catra look back at her and offered —Would you rather we… go to sleep already?

—Yeah, please.

After a short bath, both of them went to bed, and it wasn't long before Adora fell asleep. Yet Catra was unable to close her eyes at the very least.

She felt anxious, stressed enough to remain wide awake, and eventually got up, careful not to wake Adora up.

Catra had no idea what to do…

She felt like she was losing her best friend, her partner, the one person she loved more than anyone, and all because of *that princess*.

She could barely bear being at the palace. Nothing was bad, yet everything felt *wrong*.

And now, she wanted to escape.

The Fright Zone was far worse, no doubt, but living in the same place as Glimmer was driving her crazy.

Yet… Adora and their team… they all seemed so comfortable and happy…

They had promised to escape together if necessary, but… she couldn't do that to them.

So, perhaps, she should just… escape *alone*.

With a sigh, Catra decided to scout for a way out, returning later to pick up her few things, and silently left the room.

Traversing the corridors, the hunter stuck to the shadows, avoided several guards, and eventually reached a hall full of impressive murals.

She was observing them in shock when a voice said —Appreciating the art, I see…

Catra gasped and jumped back, hair standing on end, and stammered —Que-Queen Angella!

—Good evening.

The hunter cleared her throat, eased down her hair, and stood straight to reply —Evening.

—I see you're on a little nocturnal trip.

—I… can't sleep— she said, hiding half of the truth.

—You seem unwell. Anything you need to talk about? I know you and my Glimmer have some trouble, but… I hope that won't drive you away.

—No, no, that's… not it. I swear. A-and I wouldn't want to keep you, your Majesty— she replied, as polite as she could. —It's nothing.

—You are my guest, young lady. It would be no problem to talk for a while if that helps you.

—I- Uh… Thank you— she finally sighed, accepting. —It's just… We came here, to your territory, I mean, looking for- We-we just wanted to capture an immortal because we're looking for information.

—Information on?

—The-the whereabouts of the woman who raised us and trained us in the Fright Zone— Catra began. —She was the best hunter but… disappeared about a year ago. A bit more, maybe… We believe- We *want to think* she was captured— she hesitantly explained.

—She was important to you— the Queen realized.

She almost shook her head.

—She wasn't… a good person. She was mean, cruel, severe, never treated me well. But yes, she's still important to us. She raised us, taught us life skills, and… despite being so… *bad*, her lessons were good. I don't know if *you* have her captured, or if at least you heard of her but, if you know *anything*…

—What would her name be?— Angella interrupted, noticing her hesitation.

—Light Spinner.

—I see… Well, I wish I could help, but… I don't know anyone by the name Light Spinner— she lied.

Chapter End Notes

That would be all for today!

I hope u enjoyed and wish me luck finishing next week's chapter lol

Chapter 7

Chapter Summary

That same night...

Chapter Notes

Hello! Welcome back!

We're around the middle of this story (aprox), and this act is also nearing its end! There are no warnings for this chapter, and it's pretty short, I guess…

I won't say much more, just, be my guests and I hope you enjoy ^_^

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 7

The women didn't have options.

Castaspella's plan was their only escape.

Or rather, they had the option to go just anywhere else, but only by crossing the sea would they find refuge; any other path would result in prison again.

So they had to reach the docks and board whichever ship they could… As stowaways if necessary.

—And what are we supposed to do once we reach the other side of the sea?— Shadow Weaver asked, unable to bear the silence anymore.

—*I* will return home, and *you* are invited to come with me— Castaspella replied, keeping her sight ahead. —I can say you helped me escape from the inquisitors and they will surely let you stay.

—First of all, you said it yourself, *you* helped *me*. Not the other way around. And second, I am *a hunter*. They won't like it one bit, especially once the truth of my identity gets out— the older woman pointed out.

—I know, I know— she sighed. —But, trust me a bit… I can get you the permission of the Queen herself to stay with us.

—Why would you? You don't even know me…

—Well, you did trust me enough in prison, can't you just do it again? And as to why I'd do that for you, well, I just don't see why not…— the young woman replied.

—I insist: you *don't* know me. Not enough…

—Then tell me more about you— Castaspella requested, finally looking back at her. —I don't know, tell me… about your duties as hunter, or something. Did you just, well, *hunt* like a mercenary? Did you have apprentices? Trainees, maybe? You did mention training a squad…

—I did, of course. Five trainees whom I raised since they were babies…

—Really?

—Two of them were… pretty exceptional— she continued. —Adora is a especial girl, the most promising talent I've ever seen… And then there's Catra; a good hunter but not *especial* like Adora— she explained. —The only exceptional thing about her is that she can keep up with Adora *despite* not being especial like her.

—I- Why that expression!?

—Take a guess?— Shadow Weaver smirked.

—Oh, no… I can't even imagine how cruel you were to her— Castaspella let out, looking away. —Just from your expression, I can guess you treated her like shit *precisely* because of what you just said.

—Of course I did— the older woman laughed. —A girl like her, capable of being at the same level as someone so gifted as Adora… She can only develop her full potential if pushed to the limit!

—Oh, really!? You're going to use that excuse!? Don't you know that people can reach their full potential through positive reinforcement!?

—That does *not* work in the Horde. Hunters face a world of dangers beyond their imagination; they can't begin to fathom the powers they will face when fighting an immortal — Shadow Weaver rebuked. —If I don't push them to the limit…

—You can do so *without* being a jerk!

—Where's the fun?

—I cannot *believe* we're having this conversation…

—In any case, I can say, with great certainty, that Adora not only performed flawlessly, but also, that she possesses, most likely, some angelic heritage— Shadow Weaver went on. —In short, she's the *ultimate* hunter— she declared.

—You think?

—If you knew her, you wouldn't doubt me.

—What if- Pe-perhaps you're not seeing the full picture— Castaspella argued, looking ahead once more. —You might be misjudging them *both*.

—I *know* what I'm talking about. I am *always* right…

—Sure— the young woman sighed, rolling her eyes.

After that, there was silence for a moment.

Shadow Weaver didn't want to consider it but, what if she was right and there was something she was missing?

No, impossible. How would Castaspella know *more* about Adora than she herself!? *She* raised the girl, named her, trained her, taught her everything she knows…

But there had to be a reason for her to say she's "not seeing the whole picture" with such confidence.

Unable to bear the quietness that settled between them again, she decided to speak up once more.

—Funny that you could guess how cruel I've been to Catra just from what little I said…— she began, smirking.

—Well, it's pretty basic stuff, in my opinion. Speaking about someone so derogatorily…

—That's nothing— the older woman scoffed, clicking her tongue.

—But… Let's get this straight: you *raised* your trainees, no?

—Yes.

—Meaning that you taught them basic life skills, how to speak, how to… basically how to do everything! You-you named them, didn't you!?

Shadow Weaver kept smirking as she laughed breathlessly, sardonically.

—No.

—No?

—I *only* named Adora— she clarified. —Later, she came up with the name "Catra" for her little magicat friend…

—You- So you didn't name *any* of the other trainees!?

—That would be correct.

—You're despicable…— Castaspella declared, deadpan. —What the heck did you call them, then!?

—"Kid", "girl", "boy". Depending on whom I meant and who else was close enough, I'd maybe have to call Catra "cat girl", or that other boy, Rogelio, "lizard boy" since he's lizard-folk.

—Did I say you're despicable? No, no. You can't even be *described* by words!— Castaspella indignantly uttered between gritted teeth, looking ahead and wanting to walk faster now.

—Aren't you exaggerating a bit?

—I don't think so! I- Di-did Adora name them all, then!?

—Not really— Shadow Weaver denied, seemingly unaffected by the young woman's indignation. —No. Once each of them was old enough to understand the concept of a name, each chose their own. In Catra's case, she decided to keep the one Adora gave her…

—Alright— she sighed, matching her pace again. Extremely curious, yet fearing what the answer could be, Castaspella decided to ask —Why that fixation with Adora?

—As I said: she's especial. She has angelic heritage and more power than any other mortal.

—What if you're wrong? What if it's… not "angelic heritage"?

—How would *you* know!?

—Whatever— Castaspella sighed, giving up. —Then answer this: why the fixation with Adora being "especial"?

—Because that was my mission.

—Your… mission?

—Adora was the key to gaining the respect of my superior and even the Queen herself…

—Ho-how!? From what you told me, your superior was… quite a jerk, to put it nicely. Why would you want *his* respect!?

—It was the only way to rise through the ranks— Shadow Weaver replied, her expression… resigned.

—So it was always about power?

—Obviously. Why else would I put so much effort into raising *kids*?— the woman dismissively answered.

—Normally, people *care* about the kids they raise. You sound more like a *menace* to them!

—And I absolutely am.

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Reflecting after her conversation with Queen Angella, Catra returned to her room, expecting to find Adora still asleep, yet that wasn't nearly the case.

—Oh, there you are!

—What are *they* doing here!?— Catra immediately reacted, finding both Bow and Glimmer sitting on pillows on the floor with Adora.

—The-they just- Ca-calm down— she hesitantly replied, standing up to approach her. —They just came to have something called "sleepover". They said it's fun!

—I don't care what that is! They woke you up and…

—I don't mind, really— Adora assured her, as gentle as possible. —Why don't we give it a chance? They just…

—Why would they even want to do anything with *us*!?

Still sitting, Bow and Glimmer exchanged a concerned glance and decided to answer themselves.

—We are sorry— he began.

—Yeah. Really. We want to… make amends— the princess assured her. —I *know* you hate me, but I'd like to change that.

Adora took Catra's hand and pulled her closer, inviting her to sit with them. Wary, she followed and sat down, but it was evident she had her guard up.

—Look, we know how we treated you guys, and perhaps it was too much— Bow admitted. —So we thought this would be a good way of fixing things. Start over, get to know each other.

—Why?— Catra asked, squinting. —What exactly made you change your mind?

—If you think it's because She-Ra- Adora healed me, then you're… *not* wrong— Glimmer confirmed. —But it's not just that. I- That made me realize I had been judging you wrong, and I *really* want to give you a chance. That way we may… be less *on edge* around each other.

—We also wanted to invite your friends but, they seemed really comfortable sleeping— Bow chuckled.

—So we came here and Adora woke up right away— the princess went on. —By the way, where were you?

—Can't I go for a night stroll?

—It was just… a general question. I'm not trying to control what you do, alright?

—Fine— Catra sighed. —I was… checking out the palace, i-identifying ways out i-in case we need them… And I came across the Queen, so we talked for a while.

—Oh— the three reacted, surprised.

—Are you alright?— Adora asked, concerned.

—I am. I… just couldn't sleep. And she offered to chat, alright? I… took the chance to ask her about Light Spinner, but she says she doesn't know her, and had no reports of someone by that name being captured or anything.

Seeing her pained, and a bit disheartened herself, Adora placed her hand on Catra's back and rubbed it a bit comfortingly.

—The hunter who raised you, right?— Bow asked.

As they nodded, Glimmer reflected —So, you said she disappeared, no? And that she was the best hunter… So don't you think it's unlikely that she got captured?

—The alternative is that she was *killed*— Catra pointed out, annoyed.

—But what if there's a third possibility?

—That would be?

—Perhaps she… left to another part of the continent?— Bow suggested.

—And *abandoned* us!?

Catra was getting increasingly anxious, and it made him swallow hard.

—I-I didn't mean that. Just… Could have gone to do something, maybe was chasing a demon, and didn't return for some reason.

—You don't understand: she's been gone for over a year! At first, we thought the demons that appeared dead were her doing, so we expected her to return when that stopped, but… a whole year went by, and it's been difficult to hold on to the hope that she'll return.

—But we still do— Adora chimed in, determined. —Perhaps you're right. Something else could have happened, maybe we can still find her…

—I don't think we can from here, though— Catra pointed out.

—I… have an idea— Glimmer hesitantly said. Bow gave her a questioning look, while the hunters seemed surprised, and she explained —We have a… good net of scouts and informants. Actually, my aunt usually works gathering information from *everywhere*, and she should soon be back from a long-time mission in the Crimson Waste.

—You think she'd help us?— Adora asked, hopeful.

—I don't see why not!— the princess replied, smiling. —I mean, she rarely tells me anything about her missions, but when I ask her for some information she has always delivered without asking questions.

—Yeah, and your dad gets seriously angry about you "wasting" her time like that— Bow reminded her.

—Oh, come on! This wouldn't be a waste— she argued. —It's a favour as a… thank-you for joining us!

Adora chuckled and Catra relaxed a bit, both feeling much more at ease, and thanked the princess.

Having settled that, the four of them changed to lighter topics, officially starting their sleepover, and exchanged stories of their childhood for hours before finally falling asleep…

Back in her room after her conversation with the hunter, Queen Angella sat on the bed and let out a long sigh, still thinking about what she told Catra.

She was so engrossed in her thoughts that she didn't notice Micah leaving the bathroom while drying off his hair with a towel.

—Oh, you're back!— he said, approaching. She immediately looked up and let out a sad smile. —What's with that expression?

—No-nothing.

—Did you find what you were looking for?

—Not really. I never reached the library— she admitted. —I came across one of our guests sneaking around…

—Really?— he asked, raising his brows. —Do you think they plan on escaping or something?

—Perhaps she was… but I don't think she does anymore— the Queen replied, thoughtful.

—What makes you say that?

—She accepted talking with me, and… it turns out that the hunters were looking for information on Light Spinner's whereabouts.

—Wha-what!?

—I told her I didn't know her— she admitted.

—Why lie to her?— he inquired, confused, sitting next to her on the bed.

—There's no point in telling her the truth: that the woman she and her friends seek, whom they seem to care for, is actually a *murderer*…

Chapter End Notes

That was all for this time!
I know, pretty short, indeed…

As I said, we're nearing the act's end, (next chapter is the last one), so the overall thematic is soon to change too!
~~You do read each acts' subtitles, right?~~

~~Ahem… I mean…~~
~~I hope you enjoyed and lemme build some hype by telling you there'll be a bit more info on SW's and Casta's backstories, as well as a new immortal species will be introduced!~~

~~So! See you next Monster Monday!~~

Chapter 8

Chapter Summary

A day later…

Chapter Notes

I apologize in advance for this chapter was super rushed… (and I'm posting it hours later than usual)
For about a week, maybe a bit more, I've been completely unable to write, then got… hit with a bit of a bad news and it didn't help at all…
So I had to wrestle the words out of me to finish writing this chapter in time.
I had little time to edit it too, so I hope it isn't too bad…

Anyways, I hope you enjoy the ending of Act 2! It is time for the big reveal!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 8

With morning arrived a chilly wind that neither of them expected. It hindered their sight and made it difficult for them to locate the docks. Everything looked the same, and the sand threatened to get into their eyes.

However, Castaspella's sense of direction was good enough to set them on the right path, and they arrived just before nightfall.

—This place is crawling with hunters— Shadow Weaver noticed, with a brief glance from their hiding spot behind a tall pile of crates.

—I imagined… Most of them should be gone in a few hours, however— the young woman assured her, sitting down on the sand and letting go of all their supplies.

—You're awfully familiar with hunters' schedules, it seems.

—I'm familiar with the *docks*. I've been here many times— she clarified.

—Why would that be?— Shadow Weaver inquired, curious, sitting next to her.

—I just- It's my job…

—You're a spy for the immortals, aren't you?— she realized, her pitch going a bit higher.

—Yes…— Castaspella sighed.

—You didn't strike me as a good actress— the older woman smirked.

—Opposite to what you may think, I am! I once pretended to be drunk at a Royal Party to infiltrate the palace and gather information— she proudly told her.

They both chuckled lowly, careful enough despite the relative ease, and Shadow Weaver let out a deep sigh.

—No wonder you were repulsed when I told you I killed those demons…

—Look, I-I get *why* you reacted like that. Really. But I can't- What actually upset me is that you spoke so… *casually* about having killed people! Demons or not… I am repulsed by the idea of taking someone's life— she explained, giving her a sorrowful look.

—I *did* tell you I didn't exactly *enjoy* killing them. Don't think it doesn't repulse me too— the older woman replied, having the decency to look ashamed. —But I had no choice…

—You spoke about how the way hunters behave now betrays the "core of what it means to be a hunter", which I presume is some sort of honor code… So, how does murdering demons fit that!?

Shadow Weaver couldn't even look back at her; the reproach evident in her voice.

—It doesn't. That's exactly why I accepted being imprisoned.

—You…

—Willingly walked in there? Yes.

—So, the change in administration…

—No, it was unrelated to my extensive time there— she admitted, shaking her head. —Everything was arranged so that my sentence would be impossible to pass. That's why I *know* they just… forged the documents for our execution.

—And the guards, the hunters that delivered the sentence… they didn't know?

—Only the highest ranks of the Horde and High Inquisitors were aware. Field hunters, the rest of the inquisition, even my own trainees… they have no idea.

—Bea…— Castaspella called, placing a hand on her arm to call her attention. When the woman looked back, she expressed —I'm really sorry.

—You don't have to be.

—But I am. And… I really hope you can give demons a chance.

—Can’t make promises…

The young woman chuckled and let out a sigh, leaning back on a crate.

She observed the setting sun with a relaxed expression, basking in the little moment of tranquility before the inevitable gamble to board a ship.

Shadow Weaver did the same, enjoying the quietness this time, and her thoughts inevitably returned to her unspoken feelings for the woman.

She understood her, didn’t judge her; even when she wouldn’t agree with her actions, she was willing to give her a chance and even vouch for her to be accepted by the immortals.

She promised her the favour of the *Queen*, no less.

Ah… perhaps it was inevitable.

Once again, she was losing her grip.

—Beatrix— Castaspella began calling, waking Shadow Weaver up.

—Huh?

Groggy, the older woman brushed her eyes as she noticed that she had fallen asleep on her shoulder. The sun had already sunk under the horizon and the temperature dropped a bit.

—I’ll take the compliment, but I can’t let you sleep right now, you know?

—I didn’t mean to- Wait, why? Weren’t we waiting?— she suddenly realized, raising her head and looking back at the young woman.

—It’s almost time already and, all the same, I need you alert in case we’re found!

—Right— Shadow Weaver sighed, closing her eyes a bit.

She really wanted to sleep, didn’t she?

And it was actually… pretty *nice*.

No, no. What was she thinking!?

How could she fall asleep on Castaspella’s shoulder like that!?

Had the year of solitude caused this!?

Before, she wouldn't have been caught dead being so careless…

—Listen— the young woman finally said, calling her attention and pulling her out of her seething. —Now is *not* the time to fall into that spiral of sulking you’re sinking into.

Understood? We must make a run for the closest ship and find a way in before any hunter recognizes us.

—That's the plan? We run?

—Any bright ideas?

—What about pretending we're just innocent mortals seeking to board a ship?

Castaspella raised a brow at the ridiculous suggestion.

—First of all, you and I both *know* our descriptions as fugitives will make that impossible. But that's not even the worst part. Do I have to remind you that these ships all sail towards the immortals' land? Without a perfectly plausible explanation, like… being merchants or something, we'd have no reason to be boarding one of these ships!

Shadow Weaver immediately rolled her eyes.

Fine, she was right.

The woman wasn't really sure what she was thinking, why such relevant details were escaping her…

Or perhaps she knew exactly why but didn't want to admit it.

—Alright. Your plan, then. What do we do?— she grumpily asked, folding her arms.

—I recognize the captain of one of the ships. We're going there— Castaspella began explaining. —When I tell you, follow me.

—Very well— she sighed, standing up. However, when the young woman stood up too, her sight fixed on something behind Shadow Weaver, and it made her want to turn to look too. —What…

—Wait— Castaspella interrupted, reaching for her hands and giving her a desperate look. —Listen, do you trust me?

Taken by surprise, she immediately replied —A bit.

—Enough for me…— the young woman scoffed. Much like Shadow Weaver, she was now revisiting those… *feelings* she had developed in prison; her instinct told her she was making a mistake, and perhaps she was, but those stubborn feelings were begging to be heard. Pulling from her hands, she ordered —Hold on to me.

—What?

There was that suspicion again.

She sighed, releasing her hands and rolling her eyes, frustrated.

It was a good quality to have, Castaspella reckoned, but now was *not* the time!

—Hold on to me!

Her insistent look and the obvious urgency in her tone made Shadow Weaver obey without further questioning her. Swallowing her pride and dismissing the awkwardness, she moved to stand next to her, wrapped her arms around the young woman's waist, and finally turned her face around to see what was behind her.

She had been so focused on Castaspella that she never heard the voices of the hunters.

—Don't move…— the one leading the group ordered, seemingly fearful. —Do-don't do anything…

And now *what*!?

Shadow Weaver held tighter onto the young woman, unsure of what she planned to do, but now fully trusting her, and *that* was when she noticed…

Castaspella was smirking.

Soon, a series of symbols began appearing all around them.

It was *her*.

The older woman was in utter shock.

She knew exactly what this was.

But before she could so much as gasp, *they were gone*.

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The following day, late in the afternoon, Princess Glimmer went to find the hunters with a proposal.

They were sitting in the gardens, relaxing after their training of the day, and felt a bit confused at first.

—You don't know many kinds of immortals, do you?

—No…— Lonnie admitted.

—Would you like to see another one?— she asked.

The hunters exchanged quick glances, wary, until Catra finally asked back —What exactly do you mean?

—The princess of the Kingdom of Snows, Frosta, asked for an audience with my mother today. She *just* arrived and, trust me, it always ends with her turning into her immortal form — Glimmer explained. —I can help you spy on the reunion, if you want…

—What- Wait— Lonnie interrupted. —I *love* the mischief you propose as much as anyone but… What do you want in exchange?

—Nothing! Re-really— the Princess replied, nervous.

—Glimmer!— Bow suddenly interrupted, arriving just in time. —What are you doing?

—Well, if it isn't the Arrow Boy— Catra mocked him. —Your *girlfriend* here just offered to help us spy on the Queen's meeting with Princess… Frosta, was it?

—What!? Why would you want to- You *know* it usually ends with her turning into a Mahaha! Why would you want them to see that!?

—Ju-just for them to see! I-I don't know… I thought they'd be curious!

—Really?— Bow insisted, reproaching now. —No relation to wanting to know more about Scorpia and Entrapta?

—So *that* is why?— Catra immediately reacted.

—Wait…— Adora stopped her, giving her a gentle look. —Maybe it wasn't related…

—Hah! Sure…— Lonnie scoffed, folding her arms.

While Kyle and Rogelio seemed to agree with Adora, they were, unfortunately, wrong.

—Fine. I did think about asking you all about them afterwards… You- I mean, you don't have to tell us anything, maybe *we* can tell you what we know about them instead… But I thought it might interest you to see Frosta…

—Glim… Why?

—She's my best friend! Is it wrong that I want them to see her?

—You mean *fear her*?

—Same difference— the Princess replied, unable to hold back a smirk.

—You know what? I'll take the challenge. Let's see how scary this… "Mahaha" is— Catra finally accepted.

—What!?— Adora and Lonnie reacted, shocked.

Soon enough, with help from Glimmer and Bow, the five hunters were standing outside the throne room, looking through a high window. Not even the guards noticed them, but their position was quite perilous…

—It's easier when it's just the two of us— Bow noticed, hearing the wooden platform creak with their every movement.

—If we don't move much, we should be fine— the Princess replied, in hushed tones. —Now we should shut up…

Nodding in agreement, the hunters kept silent and made an effort to listen to the conversation between Princess Frosta and Queen Angella.

The contrast between the tall angelic being and the petite teenage human was striking…

—I am just remarking, your Majesty, that the decision was made without the rest of us agreeing to it.

—That much is true. However, I believe it goes without saying that the inquisition only targets demons; the other races of immortals are safe, so I don't see why I needed the approval of any of you— the Queen replied.

—What if…

—If your concern is with them "starting" a hunt targeting any of your people, then let me clarify that, no, these kids are *not* a threat in that way— she insisted. —In any case, they are free only within Bright Moon. They are not allowed into your kingdoms without your approval, which is where it *really* is necessary.

Princess Frosta scoffed and reluctantly agreed —I suppose that much is fair, yes…

Having reached a consensus on that, they moved onto different matters, some concerning trade, some concerning the safety and security of their kingdoms…

By the time the sun sank under the horizon, the meeting was finally coming to an end. It was evident that the first part of their meeting was what concerned them the most, but they couldn't discuss it yet.

Not there, at least.

—I think we should get back— Adora told Glimmer. —How do we… get back?

—Erm… we should- We need to get down again…

—How?— Catra insisted, noticing the Princess' hesitation.

—Normally I just fly down carrying Bow…

—Can you take us all down one by one, maybe?

—Or teleport us down? Demons have that power, no?— Lonnie pointed out.

—I can't do it properly yet.

—Why don't you try?— Adora encouraged her.

Glimmer looked back inside at her mother, who was still talking with Princess Frosta, and let out a sigh.

—Yeah, let's try.

She let out a deep sigh and closed her eyes, focusing.

It had never been easy for Glimmer to control her more demonic powers, usually relying on her angelic ones, but it was true that many of those would be more useful in plenty of situations…

This was one of them.

Trying to recall her lessons, the Princess began conjuring the sigils to teleport them all, yet *something* wasn't working, and the whole wooden platform began rattling.

—Shit!— Catra exclaimed, jumping back to the window frame, quickly followed by the rest.

Glimmer opened her eyes immediately, and turned into her immortal form just in time to flap her wings and avoid falling with the wooden platform.

—Sorry— she shyly apologized, looking ashamed.

—What is going on up there!?— the group heard.

They all turned around to see the Queen standing up from her throne and looking their way.

—Busted— Catra muttered between her teeth.

—Everyone get down here this instant!— she ordered.

They obviously couldn't, so a pair of guards turned into their angelic forms and flew to help them down.

Meanwhile, no one noticed that Princess Frosta was *fuming*.

Until it was too late, of course…

—How dare you disrespect this throne room! The Queen! And *me*!— she angrily yelled. Her skin began turning blue, her petite body gradually grew in height, and before they knew it, white eyes had fixated on them. —You need to be taught a lesson, hunters!— she declared, giggling maniacally.

As soon as she said that, she leaped forward and caught Adora right as she raised her sword instead of retreating like the rest.

—No, no!— she began yelling between laughter, lying on the floor, unable to get up. The other hunters didn't understand what was going on; Frosta, the Mahaha, was just tickling Adora with long sharp nails. —Stop! Please!

Catra didn't think twice before rushing towards them, exclaiming —Get off her!

But it was for naught as she was also caught by Frosta.

As their leaders were being tickled mercilessly by the giggling Mahaha, Lonnie looked around, hoping the guards, or just *anyone* would help, but they all seemed terrified of the immortal.

—Fuck it!— she finally let out, charging forward and ramming right into Frosta. They both landed about a meter away, but the Mahaha soon recovered and began tickling the hunter. —No! Stop! Help!— she pleaded, barely interrupted by her laughter.

Now free from the immortal, Adora and Catra helped each other up, feeling exhausted and breathless, but still making the effort to help Lonnie.

—For the honor…

—Stop!

Once again, before Adora could turn into She-Ra, she was interrupted, this time by the Queen.

—Ple-please! Help me!

—Princess Frosta! Let go of her!— Angella ordered, towering over them in her angelic form. —I won't repeat myself.

The Mahaha looked up at her between her long black disheveled hair, and gave her a defiant look.

But she knew better than to challenge the Queen, and obeyed, taking a step back and raising her hands.

—Apologies, your Majesty, for my lack of self-control— she let out, still giggling despite seriously meaning it.

—Turn back to your mortal form, now.

As her long, sinewy limbs gradually returned to the normal human length of her human form, her skin lost that blue tint, and her cold eyes recovered their pupils.

Seeing her as the petite teenager once again, Adora and Catra rushed to help Lonnie up and took her back with them to the group.

—Sorry again— Glimmer apologized once they reached the group.

—Fine, you won, Sparkles. She's scary as heck.

—All of you owe us an explanation— Angella sternly sentenced, back in her normal form, with Princess Frosta standing serious next to her.

Feeling guilty, Glimmer didn't hesitate to step forward, turning back too, and take the blame.

—It was my fault, Mom. I had the idea of spying and… I just wanted them to see… I-I thought they'd want to-to see Frosta be-because they don't know other kinds of immortals besides angels and demons…

—So now I'm a freak-show for your new friends?— the Princess of Snows asked, sounding betrayed.

—No, no! I-I would never…— Glimmer began, stepping closer. —You're my best friend! And I'm proud of that! I think you're awesome and wanted them to see you!

—You mean *fear me*.

—I… guess, yeah— she had to admit.

Frosta sighed deeply and stepped forward too, her expression softer now.

—Don't do that again— the Princess told her, embracing Glimmer.

She hugged her back and let out a smile.

After a moment, the princesses let go of each other, Frosta respectfully farewelled, and once she left, the Queen began her interrogation.

—What was going through your minds!?

—We're sorry, your Majesty— Adora apologized.

—You had no idea what her immortal form was, and yet you risked your lives…— Angella remarked, disappointed. —I take it you *really* don't know a thing about other immortals, right?

—Not much, no.

—The people of the Kingdom of Snows, the immortals, are either Mahaha like the Princess, or Ijiraat— the Queen began. —You've seen what a Mahaha is like, and what it does, but… I would rather you don't discover what an Ijiraat is in the same way…

—I-I planned on just telling them…

—Then, allow me— Angella requested. —The Ijiraat are shape-shifters. They aren't the only immortals with such skill, but they are the most scary, I would say. They can take various animal forms, but also human form; you'd only distinguish them from their glowing red eyes…

—And they can steal memories— Glimmer added.

—But they aren't evil or anything, alright? They just…

—They can be mischievous, of course, but usually, both Mahaha and Ijiraat remain in their mortal forms unless provoked. Like just now…— the Queen concluded.

—Oh…— Adora sighed. —We're so sorry for that.

—Now, please, tell me exactly what you expected to get from this— Angella asked her daughter.

—I… Well…

—She wanted to know about Scorpia and Entrapta— Lonnie interrupted. —We shouldn't talk about them, though— she added, folding her arms and looking away.

—The… princesses!?— the Queen asked again, wanting to confirm.

—Yes. They work with the Horde.

—They are alive…

—You didn't know either, your Majesty?— Adora realized.

—We can't say much but… know that they are alright and just… supervise the Fright Zone.

—I thought…

—Everyone, Mom.

—So, what do *you* know about them?— Catra asked. —We can… confirm whatever you do know, we just can't give you any inside information.

—I understand— Angella nodded. —Well, it is known that Scorpia's immortal form isn't very different from her scorpioni form, since she's from an extinct- *almost* extinct all-female race called "daughter of Serket".

—Yes, that much is correct— Adora confirmed.

—Her being alive explains… a few things— the Queen muttered. However, she quickly changed subjects and asked —And about Entrapta, is she still working on creating other Automatons?

—Yes. That's correct.

—Well, we don't know much about her… Entrapta is one of a kind, and a very mysterious immortal— Angella began. —We thought her dead because she… well, she just disappeared one day— she explained. —I suppose it makes sense that she joined the Fright Zone, seeing how they have technology much like her…

—So you don't know her origins either?— Lonnie realized.

—We don't. As an automaton, she must have been created by someone, but… who?

—Is it true that she doesn't have a mortal and an immortal form?— Glimmer asked.

—Yeah— Catra confirmed, folding her arms. —She's just… an immortal, an automaton shaped like a human, she looks like mortals but has all the characteristics of an immortal.

—Yes, that's what I recall— Angella nodded. —It's… good to know they are fine, even if their allegiance to the Fright Zone implies they felt… rejected by us.

—And *that* is why we can't tell you anything more about them— Catra pointed out. —They have expressed their contempt for you several times, and we can't- we *won't* betray them in any way.

—It's completely understandable, and I respect your decision— the Queen assured her.

—Why-why did you drive them away?— Kyle shyly asked, finally daring to speak despite feeling frankly intimidated by Angella.

—We didn't mean to— Glimmer quickly replied. —It was all a misunderstanding— she insisted.

—Maybe it was, but we should have tried to make things right instead of just thinking they died— the Queen sighed.

After a roar from Rogelio, he further proposed —Why don't you reach out now? Knowing they are alive, you can maybe… clarify the whole situation, right?

—There's a reason why they feel rejected, Kyle— Lonnie reminded him. —It won't just be solved with a "chat".

—Besides, if they joined the Horde… they clearly don't want anything to do with us— Glimmer lamented.

—I'm not saying you *should* go ahead and reach out now, but… maybe don't abandon the idea just yet— Adora said, smiling gently. —I want to believe there's a chance still…

Chapter End Notes

Series_Shipper, I am so so sorry! I wanted to make you doubt before this chapter *precisely* because you had it right from the beginning! <("^_^)

In any case, congratulations and I hope that the reveal still managed to shock you! lol

Anyways XD
Next week is (hopefully) the beginning of Act 3!!
What will the consequences of the reveal be!?

What will the hunters' next move be?
Are there *more* truths to be uncovered?

See ya!!

Act 3

Chapter Summary







Act 3

Of the truth revealed

Chapter 9

Chapter Summary

That same night…

Chapter Notes

Um, so…
I had to rush again… I thought I would have finished by today's midnight to post like I used to, but nope…
Plus, we had a little issue with electricity.

ANYWAYS

A new Act begins, and with it will come many revelations!

Also also, the first "half" of the chapter is super short this time because I severely miscalculated, and I don't have time to come up with any way to fix it
I am *so sorry* for how messy this is…

I still hope you can enjoy it!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 9

—Gah!

For the tenth time, Shadow Weaver threw herself at the demon, in a futile attempt at catching her.

She didn’t even know what she’d do if she managed as much, however.

If, somehow, she *could* catch her, then what?

Would she pin her down? As if her strength wasn’t far weaker than that of a demon…

But say she could… *then what*!?

Would she hand her in to the inquisitors? To other hunters?

Would she kill her!?

With her powers, she could *actually* immobilize her, yes. She could also kill her just as easily as she had done with others in the past… yet she kept trying to catch her with her bare hands, while handicapped by the ship's movement.

—Will you… keep doing this… any longer?— Castaspella casually asked her, interrupting herself only to move away from Shadow Weaver's grasp. —This place is… less than ideal for this…

Indeed, it was; they were in the ship's cargo hold.

—Just wait until I get my hands on you!

—Then what will you do? Rat me out with the captain? Remember, I know him— she began, smirking smugly. —Or do you intend to kill me yourself too?

The demon snickered sardonically while Shadow Weaver gasped for air, close to running out of energy.

—You're… shameless— the woman managed to reply, face flushed from the effort. Losing her balance, she staggered back and held onto a crate, still gasping, and added —You… *lied* to me!

—I *technically* just hid part of the truth— Castaspella countered, still a bit sly. —Or do you think I had ulterior motives to have helped you?— she inquired, approaching the woman, seemingly unaffected by the ship's movement. —I'd love to hear your thoughts…

As her skin gradually turned into a familiar purple that Shadow Weaver knew very well, starting from the tips of her fingers, the demon raised a hand to trace the hunter's jaw.

—Bullshit! You…— she quickly spat, yet her throat betrayed her and she began coughing.

—There, there… Maybe you need to calm down a bit, and listen to me while you recover— Castaspella proposed, knowing fully well that the woman had no other choice.

—What the…— she began, but got interrupted by a cough again. —What the fuck do you want!?

—Begin by answering a few questions— the demon ordered. —You said you had- you were forced into having intercourse with a demon, correct?

—Sure…

—What happened to said demon?

—What I've told you… it's all true— Shadow Weaver replied, squinting. —I killed him as soon as I got the powers from him. He was my first victim, the one who betrayed me.

—So that much was true… Then why haven't you used those powers against me? Why use your bare hands like a mere mortal, not even weapons like a hunter, which we don't even have available, if you could always subjugate me with the demonic powers you… got?

Castaspella had made a pause, unsure whether to say she "stole" those powers instead. But taking into account what she had gone through for them, "get" seemed to be the most appropriate way of saying it.

She didn't steal them.

She *got* them and paid the price.

—Be-because…— the woman hesitated, seemingly breathless still. —I… can't.

—What do you mean?— Castaspella quickly interrogated her, partially relieved but also suspicious. —Beatrix…

—Ugh— she grunted, looking away. —I couldn't say it before, we… didn't have time… but I… may have…

—Caught feelings for me?— the demon completed, raising a brow and hiding her hopefulness behind a tone of mischief.

—That's exactly why I *have* to kill you! Ugh! But I can't!— Shadow Weaver grunted, slamming her fist against the crate behind her. —I knew love was a weakness! A mistake!

—Geez, how romantic— Castaspella mocked her, rolling her eyes. —And here I was hoping you'd want me to return your feelings…

—Forget everything I've said— the woman muttered between her teeth.

She then pushed herself off the crates, in an effort to counter the ship's movement, and looked for somewhere to sit, as far from the demon as possible…

<~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~>

—Hey, guys!— Princess Glimmer exclaimed, rushing to find Adora and Catra. —Have you seen Bow?

—Yeah, the guys were hungry and he walked them to the kitchen— Catra replied, aloof.

—They are a bit shy and didn't want to ask for dinner alone— Adora further clarified, noticing Glimmer's confused expression.

—Whatever, I'll tell you first!— the Princess decided, seemingly excited, but actually pretty pissed off. —I found out what the "important matter" Mom has to attend to is. And why Frosta didn't leave the kingdom after the audience.

—And?

—She called for a Princess Alliance meeting! *And* didn't invite me!

—Are you usually invited?

—Yeah!

—Then why not this time?— Adora inquired, following Catra's lead.

—*That* is what I want to know— Glimmer scoffed, giving them a daring look.

—You want to spy on them. *Again*. After the *wonderful* experience with that Mahaha.

—Catra…

—No, no. Let her answer, Adora. Are you really proposing we defy your mother like that once more *so soon*?

—Yes— Glimmer admitted, lowering her head in defeat.

Clicking her tongue and folding her arms, Catra smirked as she replied —Count me in, Princess.

—Really!? Ah!

With her loud squeal, the hunters chuckled and followed her to find Bow.

—Wha-what!?

—Come on, Bow! You must want to know too!

—I-I mean, yeah, but…

—Then this is your chance!

—What if we're busted again?— he pointed out, calmly trying to dissuade her. —You don't want…

—Another encounter with the Mahaha? With other immortals? No, but, I'm willing to risk it — Glimmer assured him, looking away, refusing to drop her plan. —If you're so afraid, then you can stay out. But *we* are going— she sentenced.

—Wait, wait. I-I'm not letting you do this while I sit and have dinner!

—Then come with us!

—No!

—Enjoy your dinner, Bow.

—Wait— he immediately begged, catching her arm as she aimed to turn around to leave. —Are you *sure* sure you want to do this?

—Absolutely— she replied, giving him a look he knew very well.

—Damn, you're determined, aren't you?— he chuckled. —Ah… Alright, let's do this.

—Yes! Our first mission as the Best Friends Squad!

—The *what* now!? Wha-what do you mean, Sparkles!?

—Us!

—We-we can hardly be called "best friends"!— Catra pointed out, sounding indignant.

—Then why are you blushing?— Glimmer immediately inquired, smug.

—I am *not*!

—Yes, you are, Love— Adora chuckled.

—Traitor!— she complained, making them all laugh before finally giving in and laughing with them.

—Hold up. Why would this be our first mission? Didn't spying on your mother and Princess Frosta earlier count?— she then realized.

—Well, yeah… It would but, this time it's just *us four*!— she clarified, sheepish. —Come on, now, let's get going— the Princess finally decided, leading the group.

—Careful now, this is more difficult than earlier— Bow warned them, once again having installed a wooden platform outside a window to the war room. —We *really* need to stay still and… A-Adora is it really necessary to have the sword on you again?

—I…

The hunter hesitated, tugging the rope from which the sword hang on her back.

—If it's so necessary to carry it with you at all times, we can always get you a belt with a sheath, you know?— Glimmer pointed out.

—No- I mean, yes, but… I just- The Queen told me to make sure I always have it with me and all… So I carry it this way! I didn't want to ask for a custom scabbard to be made for me…— she shyly explained.

—Mom said- Re-really!?— Glimmer reacted. She then looked at Catra with a disgruntled expression and said —Please tell me she doesn't sleep with the sword too…

However, there was a moment of silence before the hunter admitted —She tried.

—A-alright. That-that's enough. Let's listen, the meeting is starting!— Adora decided to interrupt.

Bow chuckled a bit yet ultimately gestured for them to keep quiet.

As the four kneeled on the wooden platform, looking inside, the princesses and the Queen sat around the table.

—Shall we begin this meeting?— Angella inquired.

—Is the King not going to join us?— Perfuma asked back, confused.

—Not this time, no.

—What is this about, Queen Angella?— a princess with light-blue hair asked.

—Who's that?— Adora whispered.

—Princess Netossa; the one next to her is her wife, Spinnerella— Glimmer replied, hushed.

—Well… as you already know…— the Queen began, hesitant. —She-Ra is now in Bright Moon.

—The hunter— Spinnerella noted, sounding a bit annoyed. —Whom you didn't ask if we…

—I did not ask for your opinion because you do not *live* in this kingdom. If you feel unsafe…

—*How* would I *not* feel unsafe coming here!? How many of my people have been hunted, or at the very least chased down through entire kingdoms!?— she indignantly asked. —We may not live here, but I'm still a demon! Their sole presence still threatens my head!

—You know full well the hunters have not found any way of actually killing an immortal yet…— Angella argued.

—With all due respect, your Majesty. Are you intending to say the demons we found dead near the edge of the Woods…

—That wasn't the hunters' or the inquisitors' doing— she sternly assured Netossa, interrupting her. —Of course I thought about you all; not only demons, I mean every single one of you. And *that* is why I invited the hunters to stay— she further explained. —But the matter at hand is… unrelated. Or rather…— she tried to continue, but hesitated again. —I believe you're all aware of the mission in which my husband's sister was sent.

—Yes— they all replied, some louder than others.

—Good. Then it might surprise you to know she's not back despite Adora being here for a month and a half already.

—Wait— Perfuma interrupted. —You mean she's *not* the one who brought the hunters here!?

—Her mission *was* the blonde hunter and her potential to be exactly who she turned out to be. *Where* is that demon then!?— Mermista inquired.

—We *don't* know— Angella admitted, shaking her head. —The reason my husband isn't present is to make sure his bias won't affect your decision. Do we send out a mission to find her?

—What?— Adora muttered, while the princesses began their debate.

The hunter took a few steps back, almost fell from the wooden platform, and barely caught herself in time.

—A-Adora, careful— Catra warned her.

—I need to leave.

—Adora?— Glimmer asked, confused as she looked back.

—Don't worry. I'll help her down. You tell us what happened afterwards— Catra decided. Gently, she whispered —Take my hands…

Once the hunter jumped down, she followed and guided her to a nearby bench. They sat together in the quiet gardens, holding each other until Adora was ready to speak.

—They knew… *Always knew*. But she never- She acted like she didn't know, put us through that "test", that-that "trial" of hers… I thought I- that *we* had proved ourselves! But no! They- *She* always intended to have me on her side! Why-why *lying*!?

—Adora…

—I swear I didn't know— Glimmer's voice interrupted. —I had no idea.

—But your mother did! And she lied to me, to *us all*!— the hunter yelled back, standing from the bench, tense from head to toe, hands closed in tight fists. —I- She only- It's all about this stupid sword, isn't it!?

With a violent move, Adora threw the sword to the side and attempted to storm away, but the three rushed to stop her.

—Please wait.

—I'm sorry about this! I wish I had known!

—We care about you too, Adora!

Catra, Glimmer, and Bow, all spoke in unison, concern evident in their voices.

—Listen— her girlfriend pleaded. —You know I'm still wary, I have yet to fully trust them, but… I am *sure* these two didn't know. All that people in there, they may only care about She-Ra. But Sparkles and her boyfriend here are honest. I… *feel* it.

Adora lowered her head and sighed deeply, resigned.

—Glimmer… they said that…. I was your aunt's mission— she began, severe, keeping her sight on the ground. —What does that mean?

—I have no idea. But we can always… *ask* — the Princess replied, smirking.

Adora looked back at her, frowning, and the halfling nodded confidently.

—Then let's go.

The meeting had ended a few moments before, with the princesses deciding no mission would be sent to find Castaspella, and the halfling quickly summarized the discussion for the hunters as they headed for the war room.

—They don't give a shit about your aunt, Sparkles…

—Yeah, I know… *She* knows too— the Princess admitted.

—Then what will we do now?— Bow inquired, a bit disheartened.

—Follow my lead— Glimmer ordered, just as they arrived at the large doors of the chamber.

The Queen was *just* stepping outside, expression conflicted, when she saw the four teenagers.

—Oh, my! Glimmer! I wasn't expecting to see you here…

—Hello, Mother. We need to talk— the halfling began, folding her arms.

—You spied on us again, didn't you…— Angella immediately realized.

—We may have, but *you* lied to us all— her daughter replied, squinting back and keeping her tone even.

It made the Queen hesitate.

She was *right*, wasn't she?

And Adora's expression behind Glimmer, the way she tightly held her sword, it all said enough…

—Ah… very well— she sighed. Resigned, she gestured towards the war room and invited them —Come inside and I'll tell you everything.

Chapter End Notes

So sorry! That's all for today!
I promise there's more to come and I hope it will compensate for how lacking this chapter was…

However, if you still enjoyed the chapter, then I'm glad and I hope you'll be back next week for Monster Monday!!

See you!!

Chapter 10

Chapter Summary

Moments later…

Chapter Notes

So, um, my notes are a bit weird in this whole act, and the first halves of these three chapters are relatively short. Well, the next chapter should actually be a bit longer again as Castaspella will finally explain a lot of things, but I'm kind of confused as to why I divided the chapters like this…

Anyways, I hope you enjoy this chapter too despite it being quite short!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 10

The demon giggled softly in a way that made Shadow Weaver flinch; she *liked* that giggle of hers…

But Castaspella had now fully turned into her immortal form, and the sight was… bittersweet.

She had dark claws in her hands, with golden and scaly accessories wrapped around her wrists; thin horns curved inwards protruded from her head, a pair of fangs now showed, and fully white eyes shone in her face.

When she finally spoke, it pulled Shadow Weaver from her trance: a familiar voice that came from a stranger.

—Allow me to repay your honesty…

—No. I said “forget it”.

—Beatrix, please…

—Why?

—It's only fair— Castaspella argued, approaching the wooden chest on which the woman had taken a seat.

—Stay there.

—Alright…— the demon sighed. —Just know that I… also developed feelings for you. You don't need me to tell you why that's a problem…— she began, smirking slightly. —It doesn't have to be, however… When I teleported to escape the hunters, I brought you here with me because I want to believe we… have a chance— she went on, daring to step closer and getting no complaints this time.

—What do you mean?

—Normally, I keep mortals at arm's length— she replied, taking another step closer. —But seeing that you have these… "demonic hues" as it's called, there should be no risks— she concluded, reaching out to tentatively caress the woman's face.

—Wha-what are those "hues" you mentioned?— she inquired, suspicious yet letting the demon cup her face.

—I couldn't see them in my mortal form, but now I see that you have a peculiar strength not many mortals possess— she noted. —I reckon they are called that because it's like… a tone that surrounds you; a mark only visible to our eyes…— Castaspella explained, leaning down to her height.

—What are you…

—Let me right the wrong that was done to you— the demon whispered, moving her face closer yet stopping just before brushing her lips.

She wanted Shadow Weaver to decide.

It made her heart beat faster, her breath became shallow, and she finally accepted —You mean it.

She really did.

The woman's fears vanished in an instant, replaced by a sudden relief that had her stunned for a second before being overtaken by a visceral need to finally kiss her.

But she's still a demon.

Could she really trust tragedy wouldn't repeat?

Perhaps…

However, what mattered now was that *this* demon had proved herself more than enough, had admitted to liking her back, and seemed… honest.

She was decided.

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and hesitantly met Castaspella's lips.

She slowly stood up to be more comfortable yet, right that moment, the ship's sudden abrupt movement made the woman feel like losing her balance.

Her first instinct was to hold onto the demon's waist.

Shadow Weaver's hands clutched her sides as she felt a shiver, and her timid kiss turned bolder, suddenly thirsty.

The woman could feel sharp teeth and the taste of fruits from the last time they ate…

She could also feel Castaspella smiling while kissing her back, and the intensity growing little by little.

Maybe she could, in fact, right the wrong that was done to her…

<~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~>

As per the Queen's request, the group had entered the war room and sat at the table, expecting.

After closing the door, Angella turned to look at them, and noticed Adora had placed the sword on the table, yet pushed aside the question of *why* she had done that.

For a long moment, they all kept silent while the Queen gathered the strength to speak.

—I understand why you're reacting like this, so please listen to me; I will explain everything and answer any remaining questions you have, yes?— she began, her expression quite sorrowful. —Indeed, we did send Castaspella to spy on the Horde, several times, at first to keep track of their movements and plans, and… well, then to specifically follow and watch Adora, since we noticed something special in her— Angella revealed, unable to meet their sight. —Many thought she was related to angels, maybe, that she wasn't entirely mortal, but we weren't sure and didn't know what it meant for the Horde to have someone like her on their side— she went on, shaking her head slightly. She then looked at Adora to say —That's why we had you under vigilance. We didn't mean you harm, but…

—But what if I had remained on their side even after finding this sword?— the hunter severely asked. —If we hadn't accepted, if we had preferred to return to the Fright Zone… would you have allowed it?

—We… would have to take some measures, but I can assure you, we never lied. You were free to leave, still are— the Queen assured her.

—And why is it so important?— Catra decided to ask.

—As you already know, "She-Ra" is a goddess-like warrior from legends of old times, that speak about a hero tasked with maintaining the balance of the world… But that's not all— she first replied. —There's also a prophecy about her and how she'll either bring peace or destruction to Etheria, which is why we wanted to teach you how to use your powers, both for healing and destruction. And… well, we hoped to teach you the truth about the world, about us, so that the beliefs of the Horde wouldn't *doom* us all— she concluded.

—The… *truth*— Adora repeated, pensive. —It is *your* truth, as much as the hunters of the Horde have theirs…— she pointed out.

—But now you know both sides of the story and can choose for yourself— Angella insisted, smiling gently.

—So, about Auntie— Glimmer decided to chime in. —What do you know? Why isn't she here if her mission should be done?

—Unfortunately, we have had no news about her since your encounter with them— her mother replied, gesturing at Adora and Catra. —The only thing we've discovered recently is that she was caught and imprisoned, sentenced and almost executed, but disappeared along with another prisoner.

—What!?

—It's been a long time, I know, but she might- We can only hope she's on her way home now…

Chapter End Notes

Again, sorry this is so short!! I've been sick this week, still are, and yesterday began the posting of the Big Bang fics!!

So, I apologize for how short this chapter was, next week's will be better, I promise, and I urge you to check out the fanfics we're posting this week!!

See you next Monster Monday!!

Chapter 11

Chapter Summary

Hours later…

Chapter Notes

Welcome again to another chapter!
The last one of Act 3!!

There's another Act tho, don't worry, I'm not leaving this here XD

There will be a few last revelations UvU I hope you all are ready!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 11

Castaspella hummed contentedly and let out a pleased sigh.

She felt energetic, bubbly, and giddy, like a child on a sugar rush.

On the other hand, Shadow Weaver was *exhausted* yet her senses were almost *alive*.

She could feel the wooden floor underneath her body, slightly wet and not as cold as some hours before…

The salty air filled her lungs, and the movement of the ship almost lulled her to sleep.

It took her a moment too long to realize nothing covered her, as her clothes had been removed yet weren't entirely off.

She groaned while attempting to move a single finger, and the demon next to her shifted to rest on her side, looking at the worn-out woman.

—Beatrix?

—Huh…— she rasped as a response.

—How are you feeling?

—Hmm… undone— she muttered. —But… not *bad*— she promptly clarified, smirking weakly.

—Good to know— Castaspella whispered, leaning down to kiss her softly. —Then rest a while and allow me to explain a few things to you— she proposed.

—Sure…

—I suppose you believe there isn't much for me to explain, but trust me, you're missing the bigger picture, Bea— she began, comfortably resting her head on her hand while still lying on her side. —You see… Demons and angels, we're not what you mortals think. As in, we're not separate, *opposite* entities, nor are we natural enemies or anything. That's all bullshit that none other immortal species gets subjected to.

—You want to talk about demon stigma?— Shadow Weaver breathlessly scoffed, sardonic. —I lived among them long enough to know that…

—Then it won't surprise you to know that my brother, a *really powerful* demon, is married to the most powerful known angel— she tested.

—What did you say your name was?

—I didn't…

—Tell me— the woman requested, eyes closed.

—My real name is Esmeralda.

—You're the King's sister— she sighed.

—Hmm… I wasn't expecting you to have heard of me— Castaspella admitted, surprised. —Good thing I didn't tell you before then— she sighed. —In any case, I suppose you also know about their daughter…

—The strongest halfling to ever exist— Shadow Weaver interrupted. —Of course.

—Well, then, I needn't go into much detail about how humans who have relationships with either demons or angels are scarce since not many can bear the consequences…

—I know as much, yes; I didn't know about those "hues" things, though.

—And you still risked it, just to get powers.

—Obviously.

—Ah… Bea…— Castaspella sighed. —Alright, listen: the reason this hunt is even happening through half the continent in the first place, is due to the greed of the first mortal to learn about it.

—What!?

Shadow Weaver opened her eyes wide, still too tired but suddenly *very* awake.

—The first mortal to find out they could obtain powers from immortals in that way had the *brilliant* idea of getting rid of all demons, by starting the campaign of fear you know *so well*, in order to keep the knowledge and power for themselves— Castaspella clarified. —Not like it can be done, of course. You *surely know* we can't be killed that easily, that this hunt is a waste of time, resources, and *lives*.

—Yes.

—Those who have been executed were only half-demons who hadn't been trained and whom we couldn't release in time— she further explained. —And most of those captured are either on a mission like me, or attempting to ridicule the Inquisition to send the message, *yet again*, that this is all… a *circus*.

—Alright, you got me. I didn't know the origin of the hunt. Is that the "bigger picture"?— the woman asked, now trying to put her robes back in place.

—Oh, certainly not. Just some context— Castaspella replied, helping her move her clothes down. —The bigger picture you're missing, my Dear, is related to your precious *Adora*.

—What would *you* know about Adora?

—I'm not a simple scout, Bea. I am *the* scout, if I can say so myself. I am sent on missions by the Queen herself, and for the past few years, my mission has been your star hunter— the demon explained, turning to rest on her back.

It was now the woman's turn to lay on her side and look down at Castaspella.

—You spied on *us*?

—I did. This last time, I arrived *after* your "disappearance" however— she added. —But no, I didn't know you were Light Spinner until you said it, I would have never guessed.

—Why didn't you say anything before?

—I wasn't… sure if I could trust you— the demon replied, looking away for a moment. She then glanced back at the woman to ask —Do you understand that?

—Absolutely— Shadow Weaver admitted. —Alright, then, what is the "bigger picture" I'm missing about Adora?

—What you saw in her isn't… "angelic heritage". I was sent to keep an eye on her because we knew she was something special, yes, but we reckoned it was something completely different. Something… only old stories speak about.

—Like what?

—Wouldn't you want to know?— Castaspella giggled.

—That's why I ask.

—A shame, I don't know myself. The point is… I was sent to spy on her and follow her into the Crimson Waste when she got deployed as a hunter. But she never was.

—Her team never completed their training. Poor performance from them all.

—You seriously underestimate them. Their skills are on par with other hunter teams that have been deployed for years now. And I had to bite my tongue before, but you're *so stupid* for behaving the way you did towards Catra.

—What makes you say that?

—She's incredibly skilled! She's on Adora's level! She can keep up despite "not being special" like her!

—You're a professional now?

—Oh, shut up!

The woman smirked, rested back on the floor again, and let out a long sigh, closing her eyes.

—How naïve.

After a moment, Castaspella snuggled up to her, and whispered in her ear —But I can see through your cruel façade. Why are you so afraid of showing those kids affection?

—You don't know what you're talking about…

—Sure…

Without another word, the women rested for a while until hunger forced them to get up…

The trip lasted a week.

Fortunately, as Castaspella had told Shadow Weaver, she knew the captain: Sea-Hawk.

Thanks to her contacts, the crew welcomed them aboard and shared their provisions with them.

The demon was completely at ease, obviously acquainted with the whole crew, while the woman remained wary, not wanting to share much information, or her real name either.

So it was a relief for her when they finally docked in Bright Moon one night.

—We go on foot from here?

—It's a long walk to the palace, but at least it's a nice route, very scenic— Castaspella told her, starting to walk.

—Hold on— Shadow Weaver called. —Esmeralda.

—Yes?

—Are you sure about this?

—Of course! What are you afraid of?

—I betrayed them; the Queen, the immortals…

—You were wronged, Bea. You had your reasons— Castaspella pointed out, approaching the woman. —While I still find it disgusting that you took so many lives, I… want to give you another chance— she assured her. The demon then took her hands and held them tightly. —Can you give me, *us*, another chance too?

Shadow Weaver closed her eyes and took a deep breath.

—Fine. Why not?

With a small smile, Castaspella pulled her in for a kiss before guiding their way to the palace.

However…

—I see something— the demon suddenly warned her.

—I see movement too.

—It's a group coming our way— she noticed. —Four people.

—We should hide.

—Let me do it— Castaspella proposed, manipulating the surrounding shadows to conceal them both. —Keep quiet.

As the group approached, leaves and branches crunching under their feet, the women stood still and observed… until they were close enough.

The demon gave Shadow Weaver a look and realized they both had recognized them.

It couldn't be possible.

But there they were.

Castaspella immediately let the shadows return to normal, right as the group came face to face with them, ready to fight.

There was no mistake.

It was them.

In utter shock, both women exclaimed in unison —What are you doing here!?

<~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~>

A few hours after the conversation with Angella, once Glimmer returned from talking with both her parents about her aunt's situation, Adora and Catra found her.

—Hey, Sparkles.

—Hey…

—You look a bit dejected— Adora noticed, concerned. —I take it your parents don't have any plans?

—They just… *Ugh*! I know Auntie is more capable than I know, and I understand why they say it, but we can't just "hope" and do *nothing*!— the princess complained.

—Why don't we… do something, then?— Catra proposed. —If your aunt really can help us find *anything* about Light Spinner, I think it's only fair that we help her in return…

Adora smiled softly, glancing at her partner, and then gave Glimmer a nod.

—That would be…— she began, letting out a sigh. —Let's go talk to Mom.

—Wow! You want to do this by the book, huh?

—We'd have to leave the kingdom, so… I'd rather my parents know this time— she admitted, looking away with a gloomy expression. —And… Thanks, guys.

As decided, the three of them went to find Queen Angella in her office, and confidently presented their offer. As trained hunters, their tracking skills would surely prove useful in finding the missing demon, and with both Glimmer and She-Ra to help them, they would have a powerful edge in case of *trouble*.

However…

—Absolutely *no*— Angella declared, oblivious to her husband's torn look next to her. —I am not sending kids out there to find a scout whose literal job is doing this so no one else has to. Her skill set is specifically focused on getting through this kind of situation, alright?

—I…

Micah hesitated, but he understood what she meant and didn't dare speak his mind.

—With all due respect, your Majesty, we're not kids. We're above twenty and highly trained — Catra argued.

—Yes. I swear we can do this, Mom.

—I won't allow it. And that is final.

Hearing that, the three girls clenched their jaws and closed their fists tightly; Glimmer almost turned into her immortal form, but managed to control herself.

—You care for her as little as the rest of the Alliance— the princess muttered, before storming out of the room, soon followed by Adora and Catra.

Angella gasped, feeling offended for a moment, before her expression turned sorrowful, realizing she was, in fact, taking the same passive stance as the other princesses.

—A-Angie— the King called. —I-I know it's not like that, but…— he began, before looking away. —You *know* that I also want to search for her.

—But what if it happens like last time? What if interfering puts her in more danger?— his wife argued. —It's not that I don't care about Casta, it's the opposite, alright? I don't want to- I can't imagine how it would affect you if she…

The Queen trailed off, unable to finish the sentence, and Micah immediately hugged her.

—I know… Thank you, Angie.

A week passed and the matter seemed to be forgotten.

The girls didn't bring it up again, and Queen Angella reckoned they had abandoned the idea.

Yet that was far from the truth.

The hunters had quickly jumped into crafting a plan as soon as Catra and Adora proposed it to their team. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio helped them and the princess prepare everything for the trip, and agreed to cover for them for as long as possible.

And right at the last minute, Bow returned from his fathers' house, only to find out he had been left out.

—How could you!?— he complained, in his most hurt tone.

—Sorry, but… you left soon after we talked with Mom and… when we learnt you'd spend the week with your dads, we preferred to let you enjoy your time with them.

—So I can't go?— he immediately asked, giving Glimmer his best puppy eyes.

—I…

—Why would you want to come with us, Arrow Boy?

—This is… dangerous, to say the least— Adora pointed out.

—All the more reasons for me to go too! I-I don't want anything to happen to Glimmer… o-or you both, of course.

—Aw, Bow— the princess let out, moved. —But… listen, they are trained, and I have my powers. You only have your bow and arrows, which are limited…

—But I can also help you out with my tracker pad so that we can navigate and don't get lost, and…

—Listen— Glimmer interrupted, placing her hands on his shoulders. —I wouldn't forgive myself if anything happened to you.

—I'll be careful, Glim. I swear. Just *let me go with you*.

Adora and Catra exchanged a glance, worried, but completely understood. They would insist just as much in his place.

—Ah…— the princess sighed. —I don't think I'd be able to stop you, anyways…

His eyes practically shined, and he immediately hugged her tightly.

—We'll take care of each other— he muttered, sighing in relief.

—Alright, love birds— Catra finally decided to interrupt. —We should get going in a few hours, as soon as the sun goes down, so get ready. You need to get up to speed, Arrow Boy.

—I'll explain the plan to him.

—Actually, Glimmer, you also need to get ready. Let Lonnie explain everything to him.

—Oh, right.

—I'll go look for her then— he agreed.

Just as planned, as soon as the sun was down, the four of them rendezvous outside the castle, ready to cross the Woods towards the Fright Zone.

However…

—Where are you all going?

—Da-Dad!

The King caught them right before they could so much as take a step towards the Whispering Woods.

—You-your Majesty— Adora stammered. Chuckling nervously, she asked —Wha-what are you doing out here?

—Spoiling your plans, it seems— he replied, folding his arms.

—Plans? What plans? We-we just… We're going for a stroll, that's all!

Micah gave her an incredulous look, almost reproaching, and Catra sighed, defeated.

—Forget it, Dor. We clearly can't fool him.

—No, you can't— he agreed. —You're going to look for my sister after all, aren't you?

—I- Yes, Dad— Glimmer admitted, looking down for a moment. —It's just that… Auntie might be in danger. We need to do something!

—And I agree— he sighed, letting his arms fall. —Thank you— he told them, expression soft. —I won't stop you, but only if you tell me your plan.

—It's… a bit long but… We're going to cross the Woods, then the Fright Zone, and search the Crimson Waste— Adora briefly explained. —We can easily infiltrate, pretend they are new recruits, and… Well, we'll have to see how to proceed from there.

—I see…— he nodded. —However, I think you should cross the sea instead. That way, you'll reach the Crimson Waste directly. The docks aren't that far and today the merchants' ship arrive.

—Thank you, Dad— Glimmer sighed, with a faint smile. —What about Mom?

—I'll deal with Angie, don't worry.

With a final nod, the four parted towards the docks.

The Best Friends Squad still had to cross part of the Woods to reach the docks, and silently made their way between the trees, barely illuminated by the moonlight.

It reminded Adora and Catra about the night they arrived to Bright Moon, but now, the halfling and her companion walked *with them*.

And just like that night, a sound put them on high alert.

—I think I saw something— Glimmer whispered.

—There's someone else around— Catra confirmed.

Immediately taking out his tracker pad, Bow activated some sort of heat sensor and showed them a pair of figures cloaked in some way.

Adora gestured at them to follow her, took out the sword, and slowly advanced towards the position where the tracker pad detected the figures.

And when they were close enough, ready to strike an unnatural mass of shadows in front of them, the cloak receded and the group was frozen in place.

—What are you doing here!?

—A-Auntie!?— Glimmer exclaimed, conjuring a sphere of light.

Seeing them both clearly, the hunters gasped, and Catra immediately recognized —Light Spinner!?

Chapter End Notes

Well, what are your thoughts!? How do you think this reunion will play out!?

Hehe, I'm so excited to share the last 4 chapters and epilogue >^<
I certainly hope you'll like what will come, and I hope you liked this chapter too!!

See you next week! (or in two days if you're reading my spop 4th anniversary big bang too!)

Act 4

Act 4

Of what will be...

Chapter 12

Chapter Summary

Moments later…

Chapter Notes

Today I had a blast at the ComiCon and even found some AWESOME MOTU merch, and obviously bought Shadow Weaver action figure, which is now standing next to my Castaspella action figure. Well… The back of the box *does, in fact, call her Beatrix*, so I freaking won XD

Nah, but seriously, it feels so goooooood!!!

So I'm really happy but also sleepy, and I hope this was well edited lol

Please, enjoy the chapter!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 12

—What happened to you!?— Adora asked Shadow Weaver, who had turned her face away, as if ashamed of being seen like that.

—A-Auntie, where…— the princess was asking, but got interrupted by Castaspella immediately rushing to hug her tightly.

—Oh, Dear! What are you doing out here!?

—We were going to search for you!

—Master, *what* happened to you?— Adora repeated, daring to take a step towards Shadow Weaver.

But the woman didn't look back or answer.

Realizing what was going on, Castaspella finally let go of her niece and gave them an apologetic look.

—It's a really long story…

—Tell us—Catra ordered, more like a plea.

The demon glanced back at Shadow Weaver and felt her heart drop.

Concerned, she approached her and muttered —Bea… Are you alright?

—Obviously no— the woman replied, jaw clenched. —This is *not* what I agreed to. I was not supposed to ever see them again…

—You're ashamed…

—You *know* I should be.

—Look at me, Bea— Castaspella requested, gently cupping her face and turning towards her. —They are worried about you…

—They should hate me. And they *will* once they learn the truth, but it's *not*… something they were supposed to know.

—Wha-what's going on here!?— Glimmer decided to interrupt, shocked at the intimacy of their interaction.

Castaspella looked back for a moment before telling Shadow Weaver —They deserve to know. Let me tell them.

—Fine— the woman finally agreed, grunting.

The demon gave her a small smile and squeezed her hands briefly.

She then turned to look at the group and began —I'm sure you have many questions. So let me start from the beginning. About two months ago, I was sent to the Fright Zone to… spy on you; my mission was to keep an eye on Adora, but soon after, I was captured and imprisoned by the inquisition. And I happen to be put in a cell next to Shadow Weaver…

—Sha-Shadow Weaver?— Adora stammered.

—That's what the guards called her… And the… scars you see… are part of the reason while she disappeared and changed her name into that.

—But what happened? What *are* those scars!?— she asked once more.

The woman kept looking away, now almost fully turned around, so Castaspella continued —That was… done by a demon.

—What!?— the hunters exclaimed in unison, while Glimmer and Bow exchanged a glance, understanding what she really meant.

—I won't go into details, but she was… betrayed by a demon who- Well, she was a spy for us too, but only her superior knew, and he…

—What did he do to her!?— Catra exclaimed, furious.

—I don't think you want to know— Glimmer answered before Castaspella could.

—What do you know, Sparkles!?

—I recognize the… scars.

—Tell us— Adora requested, serious now.

The princess exchanged a glance with her aunt before replying —It's a… thing that can happen when a demon and a mortal… well, have, uh… sex, and the demon *forces it*.

—What the fuck!?

—You're kidding me. That-that can't be true, right!?

Adora gave her former Master a torn look, but the woman kept silent, purposely ignorant of the concern of her trainees.

—I am so sorry you had to learn about it this way, but that's why she left…— Castaspella explained.

—And why was she imprisoned!? Why didn't she return to us!?— Catra indignantly asked.

—And… What happened to your veil?— Adora added, insisting on addressing her.

—I used demonic powers to *kill* demons myself— Shadow Weaver finally spoke up. —I broke our code, went against everything I taught you… I have no honor left to protect.

—Please, look at us— she requested, taking a step forward.

—Don't pity me, Adora.

—We're concerned, you- Why do you have to reject us every time we- Don't you trust us!? — Catra yelled, on the verge of tears. —You wanted to know why we're here!? We left the Fright Zone and tried to cross the Woods to capture a demon and learn whether *you* had been captured! We're here *for you*!

—We got into trouble, and then I pulled out this sword, turned into some… legendary warrior, and the Queen invited us to live here.

—But we *never* gave up on you! We trusted you were alive! We wanted you back! And now you say you weren't ever going to return!? You won't even *look at us*!

—Why would you want to look at my wretched visage!?— Shadow Weaver shrieked, turning towards them, pointing at her face.

—Because we care, Light Spinner— Adora muttered.

—Ugh! Why did we even bother!?— Catra then exclaimed, her voice breaking. —Lonnie was right! You abandoned us! Never cared for us!

—Why would it matter to you!?

—Alright, alright— Castaspella interrupted. —Calm down, please. —It's evident you three need to talk, but this might not be the best place.

—Right. We should get back, guys— Glimmer agreed. —But you have a lot to explain, Auntie— she then pointed out, reproaching. —Especially whatever is happening between you two.

—Stars…— Shadow Weaver scoffed.

—And you just let them go!?

—Listen, they have a plan…

—That is not *solid* at all!— Queen Angella exclaimed, furious towering over Micah.

The King, however, knew he had nothing to fear and stood his ground, looking up at her.

—They are capable. I know it.

—What will we do if…

—Your Majesties!— a guard suddenly interrupted. —They are back.

—Who is back? The kids or the scout?

—Both, my Queen. And there's someone else with them, another woman.

They both exchanged a glance before dismissing the guard and rushing to the entrance where they found, certainly enough, the four "kids", Castaspella, and a very scarred woman that was harder, but not impossible, to recognize.

Still outside, on the edge of the Woods, the King and Queen decided to interrogate them before letting them in.

—How could you do this!?— Angella began, examining her daughter, looking for injuries. —You could have gotten yourself killed, or captured, or…

—Mom, I'm *fine*!

—And you, Bow. I'm disappointed— the Queen went on. —You swore to protect her…

—I couldn't convince her *not* to go, your Majesty. That's why I joined them.

—I gave you three an order, *none of you* had permission for this!

—You were *abandoning Auntie*!— Glimmer argued, gesturing at Castaspella, who had remained silent and only looked at the scene with concern.

—I was not- Ugh! Glimmer, if you're all back already, you surely must have a power for speed I didn't know about!— she sardonically said.

—N-no… We… found her on the way to the docks— the princess admitted, looking down.

—See!? I *told you* she could return on her own!

Meanwhile, the King had been staring at the scarred woman, unsure what to do, wondering if his sister knew who she was or that the hunters were looking for her.

But then Shadow Weaver noticed him staring, and couldn't help taunting him.

—Are you trying to *burn me* with your mind?

—Huh?

Castaspella looked back at her, forgetting about her niece's discussion with Angella, and gave her a confused look.

Before she could ask, the woman added —Or are you already plotting ways to get rid of me?

—What the fuck are you talking about, Bea?

—That little traitor of your brother is part of why I didn't want to return— she replied, squinting at him.

And she was *so focused* on Micah, she didn't notice Castaspella's expression or her sudden transformation into her immortal form. Only when it was too late, when the demon had her pinned against a tree a few meters away from the others, did she realize what was happening.

—You *know him*!? What do you mean he *betrayed you*!? What have you *not* told me!? I swear, Beatrix, if he's…

—Wait, Esmeralda! Wait!

—If you laid a single finger on him…

—I did not!

—Then explain yourself!

—I *told you* that demon was my first *victim*! Meaning he's *dead*! Micah is *alive*!

—Then why- *How* did he betray you!?

—It was *his* Master! And Micah did *nothing* when he learnt about it, other than excuse what he did to me!

—What!? He…— Castaspella began, breathless. —He wouldn't…

—He *did*.

Little by little, the demon returned to her mortal form and released her.

She took a step back and shook her head as she said —I'm sorry… I just- I wasn't expecting you to know my brother.

—I know— the woman replied, taking deep breaths. —I guess I earned that one.

—No, no… I shouldn't have- I jumped to conclusions…

—Es…

Shadow Weaver approached her and was about to *try to* comfort the demon, in whatever way she could, when the hunters finally rushed towards them.

—What the fuck was that!?— Catra began, giving Castaspella an accusatory look.

—A-are you alright, Master?

—Leave her, it was my fault— Shadow Weaver retorted. —And you shouldn't call me that anymore.

—What does that mean?— Adora questioned her.

—It *means* that you both need to stay away from me. I am *a disgrace*. I am no longer your Master.

—So you *really* just abandoned us. Ditched us. Left us to the merciless Horde, where we were harassed until we couldn't take it anymore!— Catra accused her. —Or don't you even care!?

—Girls, it's not like that— Castaspella tried to calm them down, but the hunters glared at her immediately.

—You don't get to speak like that now.

—We were *so glad* that you had brought her back, but-but you- Why would you attack her like that, and then pretend to be on her side again!?— Adora asked.

—I'm not pretending! I just thought- I-I was confused, alright? I didn't mean any harm…

—Alright, that's enough— Angella interrupted, approaching with her husband, Glimmer, and Bow in tow. —Everyone, go inside— she ordered. —And you? To a cell— she then clarified, pointing at Shadow Weaver.

—What!?— the hunters exclaimed.

—That's *not* going to happen, Angella. She's with me— Castaspella immediately rebuked. —You don't know who she is.

—I know more than you!

—Oh so you know that Micah's Master, *that demon* we three were supposed to know *so well* did *this* to her!?

She only had to point at Shadow Weaver's scars to make it clear, not wanting to *say it explicitly*. Yet the Queen didn't budge.

—What I know, is that he had been poisoned shortly before… everything that happened. Now that I know that Princess Scorpia is still alive, I realize he had been poisoned with *her* venom, and the effects of a Daughter of Serket's venom are… worse than you imagine.

—Doesn't justify shit, Angella!

—But it explains it! He wasn't a monster! The venom had twisted his mind! So subtly that none of us realized until it was too late! I-I suspected it, but I didn't know Scorpia was still alive, so I couldn't…

—I don't care! You're… You're missing the point here!

—I am not. I don't care if she was wronged, Castaspella. Her reaction was to *kill your people*. Do you think she's suddenly changed for you!?

—She did!— the demon retorted, on the brink of tears. She then looked back at Shadow Weaver, and couldn't help asking —You did, right?

—I said I'd give you a chance…

—But I am not. I can't- I *won't* let a murderer into our home— the Queen insisted.

—I *had* to kill him! He left me no choice! Or are these scars not proof enough!?— the woman finally exploded. —You said the venom twisted his mind, but you have no idea how *worse* it got once I obtained the powers he offered! He seemed normal and *suddenly* became crazy, began corrupting me, would have killed me if I didn't do it first!

—What about the others!?

—You can't possibly think they were innocent…— Shadow Weaver scoffed. —Perhaps it wasn't *my job* to kill them, and there *I* was wrong. But each of them did unforgivable things, and turning them in to the inquisition would have achieved *nothing*.

—I still can't let you and your hands full of demon blood into my kingdom!

—Angella, stop it! Please!

—I won't! If she hadn't left when she did, she would have been banished anyways. And if she doesn't leave now, I *will* do it.

—So you knew— Catra chimed in, calling everyone's attention. —You *knew her* and you *lied to me*.

The Queen had the decency of looking away in shame as she admitted —I just couldn't tell you the truth. If you had seen your eyes, the admiration you have for her… I couldn't just break that illusion.

—But now you're ready to kick her out, force her to return with the people who imprisoned her.

Angella looked down, silent, until Micah placed a hand on her arm and made her look at him.

—Maybe we can… let her in to discuss this? Then we decide if she can stay or not…

It took her a moment, but she finally agreed.

A tense silence installed between them as they all walked into the castle, and the doors closed behind them with a thunderous thud.

Chapter End Notes

See you next week for Monster Monday! (Or in two days if you read *Fidem et Proditionem*!)

Chapter 13

Chapter Summary

Moments later…

Chapter Notes

I tooooooooooooooooootally didn't *just* finish writing this chapter, no… no… Whatever makes you think that!? <("^_^)

AHEM
So, welcome back! It's Monster Monday again!!

This chapter is *not* divided into two parts, like the previous one, but it's kinda long? I'd say? At least longer than the previous one, for sure...
Anyways… I am a cruel writer, hence you can only expect me to write sweet nice calm moments before an awful storm, which is basically this chapter in a nutshell :D

But *hey*, you get sweet nice scenes with all our couples!
~~You're gonna hate me~~

XD I still hope you enjoy!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 13

—Alright. Let's begin with the important question— Angella sighed.

—Are you two together!?— Glimmer immediately exclaimed.

—I…

—That's not what I meant— the Queen clarified, interrupting Castaspella. —The question *I meant* is: why did you bring *her* here after knowing who she was!?

—I wonder the same…— Shadow Weaver uttered, rolling her eyes, leaning back on her chair in the war-room.

—I spent a month there with her— the demon began. —I saw the cruelty to which she was subjected, the unfairness… And after helping her, she repaid in kind— she explained, making

the woman snort next to her. —What's so funny!? They tried to starve you, they *beat you*! And now you laugh!?

—Saying I repaid you in kind is *quite* hilarious. Why don't you *tell them* how exactly I did that?

—Oh, for fuck's sake! You're impossible! I *obviously* meant standing up for me and getting beaten as a consequence!

The woman still chuckled sardonically, and Castaspella cleared her throat, suddenly remembering they weren't exactly alone.

—In any case, during that month we got to know each other better, and despite the *many* reasons I had to flee on my own, when we were told she was sentenced to be executed too, I decided to help her escape.

—That was *not* your responsibility, Casta— Angella argued.

—Like it wasn't hers to question the hunter who delivered my sentence, reason why she got beaten! Besides, she wanted to help me escape *before* knowing she would be executed too, despite how much *I* tried to dismiss it.

—I should have known something was wrong when you acted so resigned…

—Alright, let me change my question then: why did *you* try to help Casta escape?— the Queen asked Shadow Weaver.

—I owed her.

Silence.

—That's… all!?

—Yes. Now it's our turn to ask questions— the woman decided. —What are you two doing here!?— she asked the hunters. —And what happened to the other three?

—Oh, so you suddenly care…— Catra let out, spiteful, folding her arms.

—Wha-what she means is… we're all fine— Adora quickly jumped to clarify. —After being imprisoned here for a while…

—A month…

—Yeah. It was three weeks, then there was a trial of sorts, we passed, and after a week we were released after accepting to stay here— she finally explained.

—And why, pray tell, would the *benevolent* Queen of Bright Moon invite a group of hunters to stay in the kingdom?

—No need to insult her with your sarcasm…— Micah briefly interrupted.

Holding back a chuckle, Catra gave Adora a look and she explained —Remember I mentioned having pulled this sword?

—I was going to ask about that— Castaspella admitted.

—Well, it turns me into some goddess-like warrior.

—And they told us that's some legendary hero called She-Ra— Catra concluded.

—She-Ra?— Shadow Weaver repeated, looking back at the demon next to her for answers.

—I told you it wasn't angelic heritage. But… I didn't think she was She-Ra either. I barely remember that legend.

—The one destined to heal or destroy the world. The one with the power to return balance to Etheria— Angella explained.

—So that's the reason. You didn't want such a powerful weapon to return to the Horde— Shadow Weaver taunted, smug.

—It doesn't matter!

—Adora is *not* a weapon!

—Why is *that* your first conclusion!?

—We're her friends!

—Light Spinner…— Adora's voice cut through the sudden uproar.

—Don't call me that— the woman promptly retorted. —"Light Spinner" died.

—Then *what* should we call you?— Catra angrily asked.

—Nothing. Don't address me— Shadow Weaver replied, just as angry.

The hunter stood from her chair, aimed to leave, but turned around once more to say —You may not care for us, probably never did! But *we* care for you! "Light Spinner is dead", then *fuck you*!

—Ca-Catra, wait!— Adora called, but the girl was soon gone.

—You just *have* to be *so* nice and caring, no?

—When they told us about you…— Glimmer began, looking at Shadow Weaver. —They mentioned you were a jerk and all, but also that your teachings were *nice* in contrast with that. I couldn't understand how that worked, but now I see it. And I *seriously* don't know *why* they care so much about you.

—Well, they *shouldn't*.

—But they do— Bow remarked. —Can't you appreciate that, at least?

—It's not that simple…

Before anyone could talk back, the doors to the war-room opened and the rest of the hunters walked in. Adora, who had been silently looking down since Catra left, immediately turned around, surprised.

—Guys!

—What's everyone doing here?— Lonnie immediately asked. —Weren't you supposed to be gone!?

—I told you we were back already.

—You said you found Light Spinner! I thought only you two returned! But *where* is she!?

—Erm, Lonnie…— Kyle called, pointing at Shadow Weaver.

—No way!

Rogelio roared behind them, between surprised and indignant, and the three rushed to the woman, messily saluting her.

—At ease, hunters. I am no longer your Master, your Commander, *or Light Spinner*— she immediately told them.

—What!? But then… what do we call you?— Kyle asked, completely at a loss.

—Nothing!

Castaspella immediately grabbed her hand stealthily and squeezed it a bit, muttering —Bea… come on.

—I am not…

—What the fuck is wrong with you!?— Lonnie interrupted. —Do you have any idea what we've done for you!? What we *suffered* for you!? Those two were crazy enough to take us into the Woods, to catch a demon and get any intel on your whereabouts, and we ended up here!— she went on, gesturing at Catra and Adora. —But now you don't even want to-to…

—Save it— Shadow Weaver interrupted her.

—Did we… do something wrong?— Kyle shyly asked.

—You didn't. *I did*.

The woman rested back on her chair and let out a long sigh.

—Why don't you all sit down?— Castaspella offered.

—Sorry, who are you?— Lonnie inquired, suspicious.

—I…

—That's the scout Sparkles told us about— Catra replied, interrupting her.

—Wouldn't that mean- If you're the princess' aunt… Aren't you a demon!?

—I am…

—Then what the *fuck* are *you* doing with her!?— Lonnie exclaimed, addressing Shadow Weaver again.

—None of your business!

—But… Catra said you- That a demon did something to you…

—It wasn't her— the woman promptly clarified.

—I-I don't get it— Lonnie insisted, sitting down.

Rogelio roared, taking a seat too, and Kyle nodded.

—He's got a point. If we understood right, then… relationships between mortals and immortals are possible… So, why is the inquisition happening?

Castaspella sighed, taking it upon herself to explain —Unfortunately, the fact that such relationships are possible is *exactly* why the hunt began. It was the greed of the first mortal to find out about… the powers that can be obtained *if you survive*, that is.

—Survive!?

—So you could have *died*!?— Adora asked, snapping out of her trance.

—Well, talk about *greed*…

Catra's remark made Shadow Weaver close her fists tightly, but Castaspella caught her in time.

—The point is… we aren't something mortals should be afraid of. I won't deny there are bad demons, just like there are bad mortals, of course. But there's no real reason for this hunt, alright? You aren't in danger— Castaspella concluded.

—Yeah… we guessed as much— Lonnie nodded, looking down.

—Then what do we do?— Kyle asked. He looked back at Adora and added —Can we… do something?

—I-I don't know…— she stammered. —I don't- I mean, I'm not sure *how* I'm supposed to "restore balance" or anything!

—But you agree the inquisition must end, right?— Glimmer asked.

—Yeah— Adora nodded, quickly seconded by the rest of the team.

—Sure, Sparkles. But you can't expect her to do it all on her own— Catra quickly pointed out.

—Of course we're gonna help!

—We can't exactly stop you, can we?— Micah asked, with half a smile.

—Nope!— his daughter assured him.

—And we shouldn't— Castaspella clarified.

—So we're leaving it all to *children*?

—Mom! We're not children!

—We're over twenty already!

—It's their decision, Angella— the demon reminded her. —And it's the world *they* will inherit and rule one day.

—But…

—We can protect them, but shouldn't restrain them— Micah added, seconding his sister.

—Touching— Shadow Weaver spat. —I commend your eagerness to make Etheria a better world, but it's *not* going to happen soon.

—Always a ray of sunshine in the room— Castaspella sardonically commented, rolling her eyes.

It made them all laugh for a moment before they finally decided to retire for the night lest morning surprised them all up.

As the three hunters entered their room, Kyle nervously chuckled.

—So… She's alive. The-the girls were right!

—And she obviously hates us… I was right, too— Lonnie spat. —And I hate that— she groaned, pulling her shirt off. —I need a bath. Quick.

Rogelio immediately roared in response and headed to the bathroom.

—Oh, that sounds nice!— Kyle beamed. —Don't you think?

—I'm not in the mood for any- Wait, you mean…

Another roar came from the bathroom along with the sound of running water, and her expression softened little by little.

—Come on, Lonnie… You know you want it— Kyle giggled, pulling her towards the bathroom.

—Fine, fine. You, moron— she finally accepted, letting out half a smile and failing to hide a fond look. —I *suppose* a warm bath together would be better than a quick rinse.

The three hunters helped each other into the hot bathtub and shared a pleasant while, resting together until almost falling asleep. Lonnie had to admit they knew how to help her relax no matter how tense she was, and nothing felt nicer than laying on Rogelio's chest while gently embraced by Kyle.

It was perfect.

Until a commotion stirred them awake.

—Wha-what's going on!?

—Shit. That doesn't sound good— Lonnie immediately reacted. —Stay here, I'll go check— she decided, leaving the bathtub and throwing on a bathrobe. —I swear, someone better be dying…— she muttered angrily, opening the door just enough to leave and shutting it close.

Meanwhile, just earlier, Glimmer took Bow to her room, all the time groaning about how their fun was cut short.

—Glim… I-I- Why are you- Won't your parents ask why you brought me with you?— he nervously pointed out, as soon as he managed to get a word in.

—What? Oh… Right!— she realized. —I suppose that's true— she admitted, looking away shyly. —But that will give us the perfect chance to tell them, don't you think?

She finally looked back at him with a sheepish expression, and he felt speechless.

—You want… to tell them… about us?

—If you want, that is…— she quickly clarified, taking his hands and pulling him a bit closer. —What do you…

—Yes— he immediately nodded, interrupting her. —I- Ye-yes, Glim.

Her expression lit up with a grin, and she jumped to kiss him deeply for a moment, giggling in a way that always made him smile. He held her close, taking a deep breath with his eyes closed as if wanting to preserve the moment in his memory, before carrying her to the bed.

They lay on the mattress, staring at each other for a while; he lazily played with her hair whilst muttering how much he loved her, making her chuckle. She then grabbed his hand,

gently showed him where she wanted it, and they lost track of time…

Until someone yelling startled them.

—What the fuck!?— the Princess exclaimed, staring at the door, fearing someone would open any moment now.

—That sounds like your…

—I know— she interrupted him, immediately jumping off the bed. —Better stay here, I'll go check…

—No, I'm going with you!— he cut her. —What if something bad happened?

—*Obviously* something bad happened! So I don't want you to-to come until I know there's no danger!

—Forget it, Glim. I'm going with you— he insisted, fixing his clothes.

—Ugh, you're so stubborn. I love you— she groaned. —Let's go, then.

At the same time, since earlier, Adora and Catra found themselves together in a very steamy bathroom.

—Better?

—Much, Adora. Thanks…

The hunter still felt angry, betrayed, defeated… But now her tension melted away as her partner massaged her back.

Perhaps she'd be upset for days, and with all due reason, yet all Adora wanted was for her to, at least, have a good night of sleep.

—I know you don't want to talk about it, so I won't ask, but if you want to vent…

—I'd rather yell my frustration at her, Dor…

—I know— she chuckled. —But, I guess, if you… can't wait until tomorrow… just know that I don't mind it. You need to let it out, Love— Adora insisted.

—Yeah… But I don't wanna- I mean, it'd be like taking it out on you. So, no… I'm alright— she insisted. —I'm enjoying this— she admitted, purring lowly.

—I'm glad— the hunter replied with a soft smile, working down Catra's back.

She almost fell asleep by the time Adora finished, so the hunter didn't hesitate to carry her partner in her arms back to the bedroom.

Adora was staring lovingly at her and had almost reached the bed, when a commotion startled her. Catra was also awakened by it, and she practically jumped from her partner's arms.

—What the fuck!?

—A-are you alright?

—Yeah, Dor, just… who the heck is screaming!?

—I'll go see— she replied, gently taking her to the bed. —Wait for me here…

—No way, I'm going too.

—But you were sleepy.

—Not anymore— Catra insisted. —Come on, let's go.

Just earlier, in another part of the palace, the Queen stalked into her room, followed closely by her husband, who no longer knew what to say to calm her down.

—Angie… Please!

—Save your breath, Micah. I'm…

—Wait— he interrupted her, catching her arm and finally stopping her. —I *know*, I *understand*, but I don't think it's up to negotiation— he gently remarked. —Can you look at me, my Dear?

—What?— she asked, more tired than angry now, finally turning to face him.

—Come on, now. Let's sit— he invited her, guiding Angella to sit down on the edge of the bed. —I won't try to convince you of anything tonight. I'd rather… wait until we can all sit down together and discuss this.

—So, in the meantime, we allow that damned *murderer* in here!? To sleep in a *comfortable* bed, enjoy a *comfortable* bath, and surely have a *decent* breakfast tomorrow morning!?

—Since when are we uncivilized? Even if she were in a cell, she'd still have all of that, and you *know it*. At least… certainly more comfortable than what they have been having in the Crimson Waste's prison and then on the ship— Micah pointed out.

—Why are you so… *alright* with this!? Your sister is…

—I know— he quickly interrupted her. —And, trust me, I don't want to think too much about it. But I didn't want the unpleasant reality to slap me in the face when Casta followed that… *woman* into a cell. Do you… understand?

—Oh, Dear— she sighed, finally realizing. She hadn't even considered it… —You're right. I'm so sorry…

—Don't be— he exhaled. —I know why you're reacting like this, just like I understand why Casta is… reacting so strongly, too.

—You think she…

—I don't know— he replied, knowing what she would ask. —But I can recognize that look she gave her. Because it's the same way I look at you, Angie.

—Tomorrow will be difficult.

—Very— he admitted. —So, perhaps we need to… *relax* a bit.

There was a shine in the demon's eyes which the Queen could hardly resist. Angella bit her lip, knowing what would happen next, and didn't even try to hide her eagerness. The regents both let their immortal forms out and pushed aside the events of the day to fully focus on each other.

Eventually, the King rested back on Angella's chest, feeling the warmth of her wings enveloping him, while she toyed with the tip of his horns; both of them comfortable and unconcerned.

—Thank you, my Love— she mumbled.

—I should… be saying that— he replied, interrupted by a yawn, which made her giggle.

—You can always say it back— she was saying, until a scream made them both jolt. —Is that…

—Casta— Micah let out, brushing away the sleepiness.

—Wait, wait…— Angella tried to stop him, but he was already bolting out of the room, fast enough that she had to fly behind him.

While, earlier, everyone retired to their rooms, Castaspella found herself alone with Shadow Weaver in the otherwise-empty war-room.

—Bea…

—No.

—So you prefer a cell? Is that what you're saying?

—If that will keep you from- Ugh… I *don't* want to say you're going to manipulate me, Esmeralda, but you *most certainly* will try to convince me to "stop being mean towards those kids", and…

—Forget it. I know I can't— Castaspella interrupted her, looking down, defeated. —Besides, it… *would be* manipulation. I want you to find it in you to accept them; I don't want you to do so just because I, or-or anyone else convinced you!

—Then what were you…

—I was just…— the demon began, yet trailed off, blushing a bit. —Everyone went to sleep, aren't you coming too?

—Are you… inviting me to *your room*, Es?— the woman asked, smirking smugly.

—Stars… Of course! Now you better accept before I change my mind!

With an amused scoff, Shadow Weaver finally gave in and followed the demon down a series of empty corridors. When they arrived, she whistled seeing the luxurious chamber.

—You're ridiculous…

—Why now!?

—You *really* go on weeks-long missions and spend nights in prison or even exposed to the elements… when you have *this* here!?

—It's my job, Bea— Castaspella pointed out, pushing aside her initial indignation. —But if that's your way of telling me you *do* prefer my room to a prison cell, then I'll gladly take the compliment— she giggled.

—Ah… but we had such *fun* in prison— Shadow Weaver mockingly replied. —Or so you manifested…

—Yes, yes, we did— the demon admitted, wrapping her arms around the woman's waist. —Good to know you haven't forgotten…

—How would I? It wasn't that long ago…

—You only remember what you want to remember— Castaspella sighed, rolling her eyes. —So I *do* take it as a compliment…

—I was going to say you're easy to please, but no, you're not…

—As if you didn't like some good challenge— the demon pointed out, raising a brow and starting to turn purple.

—I most certainly do.

It began sweet and soft.

As they reminisced about their time in prison, noticing how far they had come, how much or how little things had changed, the women enjoyed each other for a while.

And just as Castaspella expected, eventually it turned more *intense*. It always did. But… there was something *wrong* this time.

—Bea… Beatrix…— she called, struggling to open her eyes. She felt sleepy, but unnaturally so, and *that* was probably what she perceived as wrong. —Bea— she insisted, trying to raise her voice. —I think… you need… to stop.

—No— the woman quickly denied, holding the demon in place. —I'm… fine…

So she said, but… then why was she feeling something amiss?

She could hardly think straight, but the unease was strong enough that she pushed herself to look down at the woman under her. While certainly *liking* what she was doing, the vision of those scars getting darker finally turned her off.

—Beatrix, stop!— she insisted, practically jumping off her immediately. It *was* wrong. And feeling Shadow Weaver's strong grip vanish was the only missing sign. —Bea?— she called, now cupping her face as she knelt next to the woman. Perhaps she had realized too late. Her scars pulsated now, in a dark, almost black colour… It could only mean one thing… —Bea! Beatrix, please! Wake up!— she began yelling, as realization dawned on her. —Help! Please! Please, please, Bea, wake up! Someone help me!

The demon remained in her immortal form, far too distressed to turn back, and pulled the woman onto her lap, cradling her while still calling for her to wake up. Now crying in full earnest, her throat almost torn by her screaming, which had woken up everyone else, unbeknownst to her.

As she cried, her senses went numb, and she didn't even react when the door to her room burst open…

Chapter End Notes

I know, I know. Please don't hate me too much…
But, like, leave it to SW to ruin good things even for herself (-_-)

Anyways!! This isn't the end just yet!
The denouement is close already, yes, but we have a final plot-point to tackle!

And again, you're gonna hate me so much for what shall happen… Oh, gods…

See ya next Monster Monday <("^_^)

Chapter 14

Chapter Summary

About an hour later…

Chapter Notes

So, another chapter in a single part, quite short, I won't lie, but *very* important

You're gonna *hate it so much*, and with all due reason…

But again, it's quite important, tho it's not the end, it's the last plot point to tackle! The next chapter will be in two parts again, and then we have the epilogue in a single part to finish ~~not conclude~~ this story!
Also, the next chapter further deepens the plot point, takes it to its lowest level, and it will be the epilogue that finally concludes it~ But won't really conclude the fic, since it's gonna have an open ending <("^_^)

Perhaps, and it's a *huge* "perhaps", I might one day write a part two, if I get any ideas…
But, for now, this will end soon and you all will be free to headcanon how things went on from there lol

So, anyways! Welcome to another chapter! And I hope you enjoy it ~~and the attached angst~~!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 14

—What the fuck have you been doing the past hour, Sparkles!?

The hunters were still in their bathrobes when the Princess returned to the castle, too anxious to think about changing back into their clothes, and Catra didn’t hesitate to question Glimmer as soon as she saw her.

—Ca-calm down. I swear we’re just trying to help her…

—By doing *what*!? Last we knew, your mother put her in some kind of coma and you all took her to that-that place, *Myscor* or whatever!

—Mystacor— the Princess corrected her. —It's a floating island where we can go for healing and… magic-related stuff that we immortals sometimes struggle with.

—You're still not answering the question!

—It's just that… it's difficult to explain.

—Listen, Glimmer. We don't understand what happened and no one has explained to us what your aunt did to her— Adora interceded. —She said it herself that, you know, that a mortal may not survive having inter- uh, *that*…

—Sex with a demon. So *how* do we know she didn't do it on purpose, huh!?

—Catra, I don't think- I'm sure it was just an accident! You-you saw them, it's obvious they have a romantic relationship. So why would she!?

—What if it's… I don't know, I mean, perhaps she was pretending?— Adora suggested.

—I…— Glimmer began, but interrupted herself and looked away. —I'm pretty sure that's not the case— she sighed.

—Oh, really!? And how are you *so sure*, Sparkles? Just because she's your "dear auntie"?

—No, no! It's not that— she quickly replied. —Stars… I'm not- I shouldn't tell you this, but… Remember the argument she had with my parents before we all left for Mystacor?

—They were pretty loud, so, yeah…— Lonnie answered from a few meters away, where she and the other two hunters were sitting. —We didn't understand shit, though.

—Yeah, we didn't get what your aunt decided to do, or why your parents insisted she shouldn't do… *whatever* that would be— Adora added.

—I can… explain— the Princess resignedly admitted. —Again, I shouldn't be telling you this because it's…— she began, but once again interrupted herself, shaking her head. —Never mind, you deserve to know. There is *one way* of fixing what happened to save Shadow- Light Spinner— she finally managed to say, hesitating in how to call her. —Only the demon that caused the… corruption can purge it. It's… a complicated process to explain but, in simple words, she has to… renounce her immortal nature so that her demonic energy is dispelled.

—What?— Adora reacted, now concerned.

—What does that mean? What will happen to Light Spinner?— Catra asked, suspicious.

—It will cleanse her. Completely. Unfortunately, the corruption from the other demon will remain, but all the powers she got, which put her on the verge of dying, will be gone.

—Are you *serious*!?— Lonnie exclaimed, jumping to stand up and approach them. —Sorry, Princess, but you have no idea what that would mean…

Behind them, Rogelio let out a roar and Kyle nervously added —Our Master is… somewhat intense when it comes to power, you know?

—Then… wha-what does that mean?

—She once got demoted, stripped of *some* privileges she had in the Horde, and went *insane* — Adora explained, looking away as she recalled what happened. —They are right. If you do this…

—There's no telling what her reaction will be— Catra interrupted, indignant. —We want her to survive, but… Shit, she has even said, at least twice, that she'd rather die than be powerless.

—There's no other way— Glimmer argued.

—Then we should at least warn your parents— Adora suggested. —Just in case her rage blinds her…

—Tha-that bad?— the Princess stammered, scared.

—Look, Sparkles. That woman is unpredictable as fuck. She could do anything: from lashing out at them, to trying to kill them with her bare hands. You do *not* want to risk it. And *we* don't want to risk it either, because that would only end with her dead anyways.

—I-I'll go warn them— Glimmer nodded.

—We should go too— Adora stopped her. —At least me and Catra. We could try to… handle her.

—You can't go to other kingdoms— she reminded them.

—This is important, Sparkles!

—You can trust them, Princess. They know Light Spinner better than anyone— Lonnie assured her.

—Ugh… I *guess* I could convince the Alliance that the situation's dire enough…

—Better safe than sorry. We should get there *fast*.

Adora nodded at Catra before adding —Perhaps we can stop your aunt and find another way…

—I don't think there's any other way, but, ah… yeah, let's go— Glimmer finally accepted, sighing.

The Princess still struggled with the demonic teleportation skill, but after a few tries, the three appeared on the floating island.

They rushed to a huge place Glimmer called the “Lunarium”, while discussing how Shadow Weaver must have ended in that state if it wasn't Castaspella's fault, and bumped into Bow meters before the entrance.

—What are they doing here!?— he immediately asked, alarmed. —They can’t be in Mystacor, or anywhere other than Bright Moon!— he reminded the Princess. —If your parents see them…

—We don’t have time, Arrow Boy. We need to stop her aunt!

—What!?

—I’ll explain later— Glimmer promised. —Just let us pass.

—But… it’s done already.

—*What*!?— the three exclaimed.

—Has Light Spinner… said something?— Catra asked, expecting the worst.

—Not yet. She should wake up soon— Bow replied.

—Then we can still warn them— Adora realized.

—Warn who? A-about what?

—Just let us pass, Bow. We’ll explain *later*— Glimmer insisted.

—Fine, fine— he resignedly conceded.

The four of them rushed the rest of the way down the corridor leading to the Lunarium.

But it was, in fact, too late.

—What have you *done*!?

Shadow Weaver was struggling to get out of some small pool that shone with light-blue light, and tried to crawl towards Castaspella. The former demon was standing next to her brother, hunched over, looking pale and weak, and barely reacted to the woman’s outcry.

—Shit— Catra muttered.

—I don’t feel it! The power! What have you done to me!?

As Shadow Weaver pushed herself up and stumbled forward, Adora and Catra rushed to hold her back.

—What are you…— the Queen was asking, yet trailed off as she saw the hunters grab the woman’s arms to keep her from reaching Castaspella.

Angella seemed about to interfere, but Glimmer stopped her, silently shaking her head.

—Don't!— Catra yelled. —Please!

—Let go!

—If you attack them, they will banish you!— Adora remarked. —Calm down!

—They took my powers!

—Because *you* took too much! Damn it!— Catra reproached her, now that she better understood. —If you *stopped* being so greedy for a moment…

—You have no idea what I went through to get them!— the woman exclaimed, struggling against the hunters to break free. —You better give them back!— she then demanded, her sight fixed on Castaspella.

—Bea… I can't do that— she managed to utter, as if in a daze.

—You're still alive because she renounced her immortal nature— Micah explained, not wanting his sister to strain too much.

—What!? Are you *insane*!?

—She obviously loves you, fucking moron!— Catra reproached her again, admitting it to herself too and regretting her initial accusations.

—You *renounced* your immortality!? Your powers!?— she went on, ignoring the hunter. —And deprived me of *mines*!? Which now you can't even return!?

—Bea…

—You're nothing but a *fool*!

—Light Spinner…

—A weak human!

—Stop!

—Completely *useless*!

Castaspella let out a gasp, eyes wide open, and raised a hand to her chest, feeling it tightening.

Just as shocked, the hunters looked at each other, frozen in place. They knew she was starting to spout demeaning remarks and wanted her to stop before she said something she'd regret… But once again, they couldn't.

Adora looked at Castaspella, concerned, and her heart sank when she saw her glassy eyes and trembling lip.

Shadow Weaver had called her *useless* because she's no longer a demon?

She couldn’t possibly mean it, *could she*?

—You…

She tried to speak but felt breathless and couldn’t utter a word.

And Shadow Weaver no longer struggled. She only breathed hard, seemingly depleted of strength, her sight deranged and unfocused.

She looked more like a wild beast, instead of the composed, prim and proper woman they all knew.

Perhaps it was seeing her like that, or perhaps it was the word “useless” still ringing in her ears that made Castaspella’s senses go numb, and then take a step back, standing straighter on her own.

Micah wanted nothing more than to stop her, hug her, and of course, give Shadow Weaver a piece of his mind… But he couldn’t do any of that. *No one* could do anything, as if they were all paralyzed.

And so, in absolute silence, everyone watched Castaspella turn round and walk away, seemingly in a trance too.

Chapter End Notes

(/^\) I *know* that was cruel, but that's exactly the point!!!

Look, like it or not, SW has a serious issue with power, and what's more, she's a mean person overall, so this was the only possible outcome. It doesn't mean she can't later *regret* the things she said and all, but like… Seriously, this was in-character, you can't tell me otherwise.

So just… sit tight and wait for the end, I beg of you. It *will* be worth it!

See you next Monster Monday! <("^_^) ~~I hope~~

Chapter 15

Chapter Summary

Hours later, in the morning…

Chapter Notes

Well, it's very late and I'm nowhere near tired, so I'm fortunately ~~kind of~~ able to properly edit this chapter that I *totally did not* just finish a few hours ago lol

Oh, but I actually even finished the epilogue! Meaning I won't have to rush next week to finish posting this!!

Incredible, we're already in the end…

Well, I hope you enjoy this chapter, despite it being short again, and I'll let you read now!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 15

Adora and Catra didn’t sleep that night.

It wasn’t long before everyone in Mystacor knew the hunters appeared there and, as expected, Queen Angella had to handle the furious couple of interim regents of the island: Spinnerella and Netossa.

As if they weren’t averse enough to the hunters already, them breaking the arrangement only made things worse. Hence, Adora and Catra weren’t allowed to return to Bright Moon until it was settled, and were forced to wait with Princess Glimmer under the vigilance of a couple of guards.

Absolutely no one was in the mood for it, but they couldn’t do much in any case.

The Princess was desperate to see her aunt, understandably so, just as the hunters wanted to check on Shadow Weaver, who passed out shortly after Castaspella left.

However, everything was a mess, and only after a few hours, when the sun was rising already, did Adora and Catra return to Bright Moon.

They lost no time finding the woman, who was already awake, looking out the window of the spare room she had been taken to.

—Master?

—Do *not* call me that— Shadow Weaver insisted once more, her tone weaker than expected.

She didn't even turn to look at the girls, and it angered Catra easier than usual since she hadn't slept.

—Fine! *Commander*, then!

—I am not…

—*I don't care* — Catra interrupted. —I- *We* care about how you are, and it seems you're *pretty fine* already. So you're gonna listen to us and we'll have a little chat— she sentenced, folding her arms.

That finally made Shadow Weaver turn around, mostly out of curiosity.

—A chat, you say?

—We just want to know what happened, Commander— Adora clarified, sorrowful.

—You were there. What explanation do you need?

—Just *what happened* back there!?

—Once again, Catra, you *were there*. What you saw is what happened.

—No, no. Don't play dumb— the hunter quickly denied. —You *know* what I'm talking about. What happened with that demon!?

—*Former* demon, mind you.

—*Who cares*!?

—*I care*!— the woman barked back, her voice booming inside the room. —I care…— she repeated, breathless and looking away.

—You called her "useless"…

—Be-because…

—As she's no longer a demon, she can't give you powers— Adora completed, realizing. —But if you care about that…

—Don't— the woman warned her.

—It's because you *love* her— she still said. —You want your powers back but don't want to get them from any other demon.

Shadow Weaver rolled her eyes and finally sat on the room's bed. The girls moved closer but wouldn't dare take a seat next to her; they only gave her pained looks.

—We *know you*, Commander— Catra eventually began. —We get it, alright? But they don't. And it's unfair for that de- It's unfair for Castaspella to do this.

—It's done now— the woman seethed.

—But you can still clarify this situation— Adora insisted. —*We* know you're angry precisely because of the meaning behind this whole mess! I-I mean: you lost your powers, can't get them back from Castaspella, the only way to get them back would be through… *someone else*, but you don't want to do it. And it all only makes you angrier because you dislike everything related to love in general.

—So *of course* you hate that you're feeling love yourself now— Catra completed. —Even more when said love is what keeps you from getting your powers back.

—Are you two *done*!?

—It depends. Are *you* done being stupid?— she countered, folding her arms and looking smug.

—What do you want from me?

—Can you be honest?— Adora asked back.

—I don't… know. I need… time.

The hunters exchanged concerned glances and she finally decided —We'll leave then. Take your time, Commander.

Without another word, they did as promised, leaving the woman alone with her thoughts…

<~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~§~~~~~~~~~~>

As soon as she could, Glimmer rushed to find Bow, who had been allowed to return to Bright Moon earlier.

—How's Auntie!? I-is she alright!? Has she said anything!?

—Calm down, Glim— he gently said, placing his hands on her shoulders. —She's in her room.

—She-she just walked away on her own, and now has no powers, and I was afraid! I mean, she couldn't return on her own, so…

—A couple of angels from Mystacor brought her here safely, don't worry.

—Oh… alright— the Princess sighed.

—You want to see her?

—Yes.

—Then let's go— Bow smiled.

As the couple headed for Castaspella's room, they happened to see Angella and Micah right as they walked in. They knew it'd be a bit crowded in there if they went in too, yet saw no reason to return later and still aimed for the door.

However, they stopped right before opening when they heard the conversation inside.

—Just… please tell us, Casta— the King pleaded. —Don't keep us in the dark.

Glimmer and Bow exchanged a confused glance.

What could he be talking about?

—It's not like anything can be done now, Brother.

—Regardless. We can see you're… sick in some way, and it's unlikely related to having lost your immortal nature— the Queen argued. —Even if we can't do anything, we rather know what's going on. Or do you *not* know?

—I… most certainly do. But I just…— Castaspella began, yet interrupted herself with a sigh. —Alright. I didn't give it much importance before because I didn't even want to think something like this would happen, but… at some point during our return, while we were on the ship, I realized I had- I bonded myself to her.

—You- Wait, *what*!?— Micah exclaimed, matching Glimmer's surprise outside.

She gave Bow an alarmed look and, despite not knowing what that meant, he realized it was nothing good.

—You know it's not something we can control— Castaspella quickly argued. —It's done now, and…

—And now you will *die*— Angella interrupted, with a tone both indignant and sorrowful. —Yet you weren't going to tell us!?

The Princess had to press her hands to her mouth to suppress a gasp, eyes soon going teary.

She couldn't believe what she was hearing, and Bow had no idea what to do to support her.

—What difference would it make?

—Casta… that's- I-I don't- You can't die already!— Micah exclaimed again, his voice now broken. —Sis, please!

—It's not my choice— she insisted. —I didn't mention it to her, nor to anyone when we arrived because I didn't think she'd… have reasons to suddenly reject me— she lamented.

—Then we must tell her— Angella replied. —For starters, it's ridiculous to *reject you* for saving her life the way you did! But with your life at stake, it's even more important that she *knows* her petty behaviour has severe consequences.

—*No*— Castaspella immediately reacted, her voice hoarse. —She can't- she mustn't accept me just because otherwise I'll die. I don't want that.

—But…

—Forget it, please…

—You can't ask me to do that, Sis— Micah denied, sniffing. —I didn't want you to do this, to begin with, a-and now…

—Please, Brother— she insisted. —And don't blame her.

—*Of course* I'll blame her!

—No one's to blame— Castaspella denied. —Just like I couldn't choose whether to get bonded to her, she isn't now choosing to reject me just for me to die.

—You can't keep defending her— he sobbed. —And if I lose you, I can't promise what I'll do to her!

—I need you to promise me, Micah— she begged. —Don't tell her anything, and don't blame her. Let her stay here with her trainees, and… let go.

Unable to listen anymore, Glimmer took a step back, her hands still on her mouth and tears slowly falling. Bow tried to approach her, but she backtracked again; only the second time he reached for her did she let him embrace her.

After a moment, Adora's voice called their attention —Guys?

—What happened?— Catra asked, as soon as she realized she was crying.

But the Princess couldn't answer. She only shook her head and broke down, falling to her knees as she cried even more.

The hunters rushed to her and, along with Bow, held her tightly for a long while until her parents walked out of Castaspella's room.

—Glimmer?— Angella uttered, concerned.

—I know— she sobbed. The four got up slowly, and the Princess hesitantly approached her father. Despite knowing the answer, she asked —Is Auntie really going to die?

—I'm afraid so, baby girl— he replied, his voice still broken. —I'm so sorry…

Chapter End Notes

I know… sad, yes.

I am so so sorry, I'm making Glimmer and Micah suffer so much, but I had tooooo

Everything has a reason to be, and so does the angst here :D

Sorry, haha, I'll stop now
In any case, I hope you enjoyed and see you next week with the epilogue!! Bye!

Epilogue

Chapter Summary

Less than an hour later…

Chapter Notes

Alright! Welcome to the last Monster Monday one final time!

I certainly hope you enjoyed this story and, with some luck, this epilogue too ^_^

Many many thanks for reading all the way through this, I appreciate any comments you want to leave, and wish you happy reading!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Epilogue

Not even an hour had passed, yet Adora decided it was time to speak with Shadow Weaver regardless.

She promised her time, but she needed the woman to tell her the truth *now*.

After the regents explained everything to her, she and Catra vowed to help however they could and, for Adora, that meant having another chat with the woman.

—You came alone?— she noticed from her spot on a couch under the window.

—We hadn't told the others that you're fine already, so Catra went to handle that.

—I see— she sighed. —Why do you want the truth, Adora? What do you expect me to say? What would you gain from this?

The hunter had sworn not to tell her what was happening to Castaspella, so she couldn't answer truthfully. Or at least, not completely.

She *had* her own reasons…

—I… may not know how to restore peace or anything, I don't know how I can become the "hero" the immortals have been waiting for, nor do I know how I could possibly heal or destroy Etheria. But I think… I can at least restore a small part of that peace— she began. —I want to know what you really feel, Commander, because I would say that your relationship with Castaspella is a-a small scale representation of the relationship between mortals and immortals.

—How so?

—You're a mortal who was initially working for and with the immortals, then got betrayed by one of them, yet ended up falling for another one so many years later, and *remained* with her after learning as much— Adora attempted to explain. —Despite your hate being justified, *something* allowed you to cast it aside. And I want to know what that something is. Because if you could amend your relationship with immortals, in spite of everything, then it'd mean anyone in Etheria can.

—And if you figured out what allowed *me* to do it, you think you'd be able to replicate it on a bigger scale?— Shadow Weaver asked, curious.

—I hope as much. Starting with mortal-immortal couples, to eventually getting rid of all the irrational fear of immortals in the Crimson Waste— she replied. —If mortals see, like us, that we're not so different, I might be able to put a stop to the Inquisition, to the Hunt… Perhaps that's what restoring balance means. And I think you two are a good start because I- *we*, your trainees, know you; whatever your feelings are, they must be genuine. That's why your rage manifests.

—You might be a bit too optimistic, Adora. No one would care…

—It's the opposite. I think everyone would. Just like we can vouch for your feelings being authentic, Castaspella's actions, renouncing her immortality to save you, speaks volumes about her feelings. And with you both being so close to the Royal Family…

—You think we'd set an example?— the woman scoffed. —You certainly can't count on *me* to be an example, Adora.

—Please, Commander. How do you feel? *What* do you feel?

Shadow Weaver let out a sigh and rested back on the couch.

—Allow me to start from the beginning— she decided. —How do I feel? Like a fool, Adora. When I met Castaspella, I believed her to be a human. A rare one, for sure, but… I wouldn't have imagined, after my experiences with all those demons I killed, that one of them would ever do what she did for me.

—You mean in prison?— the hunter asked, sitting by her.

—Yes— she nodded. —She was… selfless. A bit too much, I would say. What she did for me, even before knowing my name at least, I didn't deserve it. And much less from a demon.

—What was it?

—I always antagonized the guards. They are ordered not to harm prisoners in any way, they couldn't starve us, but, as Castaspella pointed out, they could make us starve ourselves— she began. —How? By throwing the food to the floor so I wouldn't want to eat it. But she was fast; she told them not to waste the food, which they interpreted as her wanting them to give her my food instead. Yet they asked for something… disgusting in exchange. And she did it. For me. To get the food for me.

—What?

—They asked her to undress herself. Only that, fortunately. But it was still a lot… For a stranger— Shadow Weaver sighed. —She was a demon. She didn't even have to stay in prison. She was there out of her own will… And *that* was a blessing for me. One I didn't deserve— she went on, looking up to the ceiling with her head resting back.

—What else did she do for you?

—She was nice to me. Despite me being insufferable, she still bore with me, didn't ignore me even when she had plenty of reasons… *she cared* when I did not. And she did so, being a demon who *knew* I was a hunter who killed her kind with my own hands.

—She sympathized with you regardless?

—Precisely. So I began… caring too, I suppose. When her sentence was passed and she was set to be executed, I… panicked. I questioned the hunter who delivered the news, and got beaten as a consequence. And she… cried— Shadow Weaver uttered, lost in her memories.

—In fact, she risked using her powers to stop the guards, but they fortunately didn't notice… I didn't either, not even while we were escaping, despite how much obvious it was.

—You fell for her back then.

—Perhaps. I wasn't sure, but I did… trust her. And *that* is not something I often do— the woman went on. —It… scared me, I think.

—But you followed her. After knowing the truth, you still came here with her.

—I don't know what I feel, Adora. Whether it's love or not, I can't tell for sure— she admitted. She then looked back at the hunter and added —However, I can tell you something: what you need for mortals to rescind their fear of immortals, is *trust*. Be it that I love Castaspella or not, I *know* I trust her and she never disappointed me. On the contrary, she proved my trust was well-placed.

Adora let out a small smile.

It was such a rare occurrence to hear Shadow Weaver, of all people, saying something like this.

The woman was changed. And for the best, it seemed.

—Do you regret what happened last night?

—I suppose I do— she sighed. —I don't really care about her being a demon or not, but losing my powers, after everything I had to sacrifice to get them… and being unable to get them back since I- Well, I don't have to tell you why I'm not getting them back, do I?— she went on, with a breathless laugh. —I shouldn't have called her useless, but you have no idea how much I had to sacrifice for what I had… and it's all gone… I stooped down to giving everything of me to someone I hated, as payment for those powers; seeing Castaspella undress for those filthy guards reminded me of it. Yet it was for *nothing*.

Right.

Of course she'd feel like that.

After a moment of reflection, Adora decided to argue —But power isn't everything.

—It is for me.

—There are more important things to live and die for, Commander— she insisted. —Castaspella sacrificed half of who she was, half of her identity, and all of her powers, for *you*. Because *you* are more important to her than anything else— she remarked. —Don't you think that's someone for whom it's worth living? Someone for whom the sacrifice of your powers is but a little price to pay?

The woman closed her eyes and let out a deep sigh.

Adora was absolutely right, but part of her still felt enraged.

—It doesn't matter now. I ruined it— she finally let out.

—I think you just need to talk. Maybe, apologize. Tell her the truth: that you trust her. Even if you can't say that you love her, *your trust* is worth a lot— she assured her.

—I don't think it'd be possible, Adora. She wouldn't want to see me after I called her "useless", as if I only cared about the powers I could get from her…

—Let me get you at least one more conversation— the hunter proposed. —Even if it's the last time you talk. Even if your relationship falls apart.

—I don't think I deserve it.

—What about her? Don't you think she does?

With a sad chuckle, the woman had to admit she was right once more.

As promised, the hunter went to speak with Castaspella, whom she found bedridden.

—Adora?— she asked, confused when she saw it was her who knocked on the door.

—I'm sorry to bother you— she began. —May I speak with you a moment?

—Of course…

—How are you feeling? You don't look well…

—I apologize for my appearance. I'm… sick, so to speak— she said, with a sad smile. —I feel mostly tired, but I can still talk with you. What did you need?

Adora dared approach a few steps as she kindly asked —Would you mind telling me why you're like this?

Castaspella closed her eyes, took a deep breath, and eventually nodded.

—I don't see why not… It will likely be known eventually— she considered, sure her brother would reveal it all after she passed. —I'm dying, Adora. While we were on our way here with Bea, I- Well, it's a demons' thing, but my life got attached to hers.

—And now you're dying because she… rejected you— the hunter completed. —Not because you're now mortal…

—Precisely.

—Wouldn't that mean you must speak with Light Spinner?

—She can't know.

—But…

—I can't have her "accept me" out of pity, just to keep me from dying, Adora.

Right.

—I see— she sighed. —But I think you need to talk to her; have an honest conversation. I *know* she wants to speak with you. I can't- I don't know if she will apologize, I don't know if it will help at all. But I can assure you that, if this follows its course and you die, you will regret not having talked to her one last time.

Castaspella lowered her gaze and a small smile appeared on her lips.

—You have a good heart, Adora.

—Thank you— she chuckled.

—I'll… do as you said— she accepted. —Thank *you*.

A while later, the hunter returned with Shadow Weaver, who was a mix of confused and scared to see Castaspella in such a state.

—I'm glad you both agreed to this. I'll leave you to talk now— Adora told them before leaving, encouraging.

—Bea…

—Es…

The older woman looked away for a moment, ashamed, but gathered the courage to approach slowly until she was kneeling next to the bed.

—I'm sorry— Castaspella began. —For your powers.

—Forget it— Shadow Weaver quickly denied. —You look ill. What happened to you?

—I'm… dying, Bea— she admitted, closing her eyes. —But I can't tell you why.

—But…

—I don't want you to pity me.

—You suddenly sound like me— she pointed out, smirking. —Will you also be as stubborn as me?

—Perhaps— the younger woman weakly chuckled. With a deep sigh, she gathered the strength to tell her —I imagined losing your powers would make you react like that, especially since you went through so much to get them, but… I couldn't lose you, Bea. Although I guess I still did…

—No, Es. It's not like that— Shadow Weaver quickly denied. She reached out to cup her face and caressed her cheek for a moment. —I should… apologize to you. I definitely suck at it, but… I can try, I suppose. I do owe you, after all— she smirked again.

—You don't owe me, Bea. And you don't have to apologize.

The older woman couldn't help noticing how Castaspella was acting just as resigned as when her execution sentence had been delivered. And yet, this time she had no escape, it seemed…

So why?

—Do you… *want* to die?

—I just don't want you to feel responsible.

—What if now *I* don't want to lose you?

Castaspella's eyes opened a bit more, surprised, and she stammered —You-you mean it?

—I can't figure out what I feel just yet, but… Es, I trust you. I would never trust anyone with my life, yet you- Since the very beginning, you have proved I can.

With a wider smile, the younger woman rested her head back on the pillow, eyes closed, and let out a sigh, feeling peaceful.

—Then I hope I'll last enough to know what you feel, Bea…

Meanwhile, out in the gardens of Bright Moon, Adora joined her friends. Catra and their team were discussing in hushed tones with Glimmer and Bow, the atmosphere a bit grim, and everyone looked at her when she arrived.

—They are talking now— she told them.

—Adora, you know Light Spinner. Do you think…

—I'm not sure— she admitted, sitting on the bench next to Catra.

—Dor, you did everything you could. So don't take it as a failure on your part if it doesn't work.

—She's right— Glimmer nodded. —I don't want Auntie to die, but… if she does, it's not your fault either.

—I know— she replied, albeit looking down. After a moment, she looked up again at the group and assured them —Regardless of what happens now, I still want to help mortals and immortals like this. Especially if, like Castaspella said, the greed of a mortal began this.

—Then you just have to lead the way, Adora— Lonnie smirked. Exchanging a glance with Kyle and Rogelio, she promised —We're gonna follow you.

—And you can count with us— Bow added.

—Thanks, guys.

Chapter End Notes

Well… this ends here…
Open ending, unlikely to have a sequel; feel free to headcanon how you think this went on! XD

Could Adora and her friends end the Inquisition?
Did they stop the Hunt?
Did Castaspella survive?
Will the Alliance ever take Scorpia and Entrapta back as immortal princesses?

It's all up to you now!

Once again, thanks for reading, commenting, and accompanying me the past few months :D

Hope to see you again in another story! Bye!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!